

Standard English Conventions

Theory + 136 Worked Questions • 17 Skills

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SECTION 1 • PART 1 — BOUNDARIES: PUNCTUATION

The Comma

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

The Comma

The comma is the most frequently tested punctuation mark on the SAT. Nearly every comma question tests one of three patterns: introductory elements, nonessential vs. essential information, and items in a series.

How to Approach The Comma Questions

Step 1: Locate the subject and main verb of the independent clause first — commas are placed around everything else, never between a subject and its own verb.

Step 2: Ask what job the material near the comma is doing: introducing the sentence, adding a removable aside, identifying which noun is meant, or separating items in a list.

Step 3: Match that job to exactly one comma rule. If you can't name the job, you can't safely place the comma — don't rely on where a pause "feels" natural when reading aloud.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Introductory Elements Take One Comma

A word, phrase, or subordinate clause that comes before the main clause and sets the scene — time, place, condition, or a participial phrase — is followed by a single comma before the subject of the main clause begins.

✓ **Correct:** *After the committee reviewed the proposal, it approved the revised budget.*

✓ **Correct:** *Having studied the results for weeks, the researchers finally published their findings.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *After the committee reviewed the proposal it approved the revised budget. — missing the comma separating the introductory clause from the main clause.*

Nonessential Information Is Boxed In on Both Sides

If a clause, phrase, or appositive can be deleted without changing which specific person or thing the sentence is about, it is nonessential — and nonessential material must be set off with a comma before it and a comma after it, never just one.

✓ **Correct:** *Dr. Alvarez, who has taught biology for twenty years, will retire in June. (removing "who has taught biology for twenty years" still leaves a complete, specific sentence)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Dr. Alvarez who has taught biology for twenty years, will retire in June. — the first comma of the required pair is missing.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Essential Information Takes No Commas at All

If that same kind of clause or phrase is required to identify which specific person or thing is meant, it is essential, and adding commas around it is always wrong — the commas would falsely suggest the information is removable.

✓ **Correct:** *Students who arrive after 8:00 a.m. must sign in at the front desk. (only late-arriving students, not all students)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Students, who arrive after 8:00 a.m., must sign in at the front desk. — the commas wrongly claim every student arrives after 8:00 a.m.*

Items in a Series Take a Comma Before Every Item, Including the Last

When three or more items are listed in a row, a comma follows every item — including the item immediately before the final "and" or "or," known as the Oxford comma.

✓ **Correct:** *The lab required beakers, gloves, and safety goggles.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The lab required beakers, gloves and safety goggles. — missing the comma before the final item breaks the required series pattern the SAT tests.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

A Comma Can Never Separate a Subject From Its Own Verb

No matter how long or complex the subject is, nothing — not a single comma — belongs between the complete subject and the verb that follows it.

✓ **Correct:** *The tall building near the harbor is scheduled for demolition next spring.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The tall building near the harbor, is scheduled for demolition next spring.* — the comma illegally separates the subject ("the tall building near the harbor") from its verb ("is").

Common Traps to Watch For

- A nonessential clause missing just one comma of its required pair — the sentence looks "mostly" right.
- An essential clause wrongly boxed in commas, which changes the sentence's actual meaning rather than just its punctuation.
- A long, complicated subject that tempts a comma before the verb — cross out every modifier and confirm the bare subject connects directly to the verb.
- A series question where the final item before "and" looks optional but still requires its own comma.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Rule: Test every nonessential clause by deleting it. If the sentence still makes complete sense, box the clause in commas on both sides — never just one.

BEFORE A FANBOYS CONJUNCTION JOINING TWO INDEPENDENT CLAUSES

FANBOYS = for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so. When two complete sentences are joined by a FANBOYS word, place a comma before the conjunction.

✗ INCORRECT <i>She studied hard, she still failed.</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>She studied hard, so she passed. / She studied hard; she still failed.</i>
Why: A comma without FANBOYS between two full sentences is a COMMA SPLICE — always wrong.	

TO SET OFF APPOSITIVES

An appositive renames or describes the noun immediately before it. Non-essential appositives take matching commas.

EXAMPLE

My friend, a talented musician, wrote this song. ('a talented musician' renames 'my friend')

BETWEEN COORDINATE ADJECTIVES

If you can put 'and' between two adjectives AND reverse their order, they are coordinate — use a comma. If not, no comma.

COORDINATE	NON-COORDINATE
✓ Comma needed	a long, difficult exam (long AND difficult — and works, order reversible)
✗ No comma	a large wooden table (large AND wooden — sounds unnatural)

ABSOLUTE PHRASES

An absolute phrase (noun + participle) modifies the whole sentence and is always set off by a comma.

EXAMPLE

The experiment complete, the team celebrated. ('The experiment complete' is an absolute phrase)

When NOT to Use a Comma

TRAP	EXAMPLE
✗ Between subject and verb	The main reason, is pollution. → No comma!
✗ Between two verbs (same subject)	She ran, and won. → No comma before 'and' (same subject).
✗ Before an essential 'that' clause	The book, that I borrowed, was great. → No comma with 'that'!
✗ To join sentences (no FANBOYS)	I was tired, I went home. → Comma SPLICE — wrong!
✗ Between title and name	Doctor, Martinez will lead the team. → No comma!
✗ Non-coordinate adjectives	A large, wooden table. → 'Large' modifies 'wooden table' — no comma.

The THAT vs. WHICH Rule

This is one of the most tested rules on the SAT.

WORD	RULE
THAT (essential clause)	NO commas. The clause DEFINES which one. Removing it changes the meaning completely.
WHICH (non-essential clause)	COMMAS required. The clause adds extra info. Removing it does not change the core meaning.
✗ INCORRECT <i>The book, that she recommended, was great.</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>The book that she recommended was great. / The book, which she loved, was great.</i>
Why: 'That' never takes commas. 'Which' always takes commas (non-essential).	

The THAT vs. WHICH Rule (cont.)

SAT TIP

CONSISTENCY RULE: If a non-essential phrase opens with a comma, it must CLOSE with a comma — not a dash, not nothing.

TEST: Remove the phrase between the commas. Does the sentence still make sense and mean the same thing? → commas are correct.

FANBOYS CHECK: Comma between two full sentences with no FANBOYS = comma splice = always wrong.

THAT vs. WHICH: 'That' = essential = no commas. 'Which' = non-essential = commas. Memorise this.

WORKED QUESTIONS

The Comma — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

Although the observatory's new telescope had been delayed by supply shortages for nearly a year_____ astronomers were finally able to begin their survey of the outer solar system this spring.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. (no punctuation)

C. ;

D. , and

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Although the observatory's new telescope had been delayed by supply shortages for nearly a year" is an introductory dependent clause.
- An introductory clause is separated from the independent clause that follows it by exactly one comma.
- Nothing heavier than a comma belongs at this boundary, since only one side of it — the second half — is independent.

Rule

An introductory dependent clause is followed by exactly one comma before the independent clause begins — never a semicolon, and never a coordinating conjunction.

Tip

Read the words before the blank on their own. If they can't stand as a complete sentence, they're introductory, and the fix is a single comma — nothing more.

Trap

Choice C looks like a strong, safe break, but a semicolon can only separate two independent clauses, and the opening clause here is dependent.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the introductory dependent clause from the independent clause with a single comma.
✗ B	(no punctuation)	Choice B is incorrect — fuses the dependent clause directly onto the independent clause with no boundary at all.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — treats the opening clause as independent, but "Although..." can never stand alone.
✗ D	, and	Choice D is incorrect — adds "and," which would require the first clause to be independent — it isn't.

Question 2

Easy

Dr. Elena Marsh_____ will lead the joint research expedition this winter.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,
- B.** , a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize
- C.** a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,
- D.** , a marine biologist, who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "A marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize" is a nonessential appositive describing Dr. Elena Marsh.
- The appositive sits in the middle of the sentence, so it needs a comma both before and after it.
- Without both commas, the main clause "Dr. Elena Marsh will lead the joint research expedition" gets tangled with the description.

Rule

A nonessential phrase in the middle of a sentence must be boxed in with commas on both sides — never just one.

Tip

Delete the phrase in question and read what's left. If the sentence is still complete and identifies the same person or thing, the phrase is nonessential and needs both commas.

Trap

Choice B opens the box with a comma after "Marsh" but never closes it before "will lead," leaving the reader unsure where the description ends.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,	Choice A is the best answer. boxes the entire nonessential appositive in commas on both sides.
✗ B	, a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize	Choice B is incorrect — is missing the second comma before "will lead," leaving the appositive unclosed.
✗ C	a marine biologist who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,	Choice C is incorrect — is missing the first comma, fusing "Marsh" directly onto "a marine biologist."
✗ D	, a marine biologist, who has spent the last two decades studying coral resilience off the coast of Belize,	Choice D is incorrect — inserts an extra, illogical comma after "biologist," splitting the appositive in two.

Question 3

Medium

The grant proposal_____ ultimately received the highest score of any application that year.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline
- B.** , that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline,
- C.** that the research team submitted, just before the funding deadline,
- D.** , that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "That the research team submitted just before the funding deadline" identifies which specific proposal is meant — it is essential to the sentence's meaning.
- An essential clause takes no commas at all, since removing it would leave the reader unsure which proposal is being discussed.
- Boxing this clause in commas would falsely suggest it can be deleted without changing what the sentence identifies.

Rule

A clause that identifies which specific person or thing is meant is essential and takes no surrounding commas.

Tip

Delete the clause and check whether the sentence still identifies the same, specific thing. If it no longer does, the clause is essential and gets no commas.

Trap

Choice B feels safer because it "matches" the nonessential pattern from other questions, but here removing the clause would leave "the grant proposal ultimately received the highest score" — which proposal is left unclear.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline	Choice A is the best answer. correctly leaves the essential identifying clause unpunctuated.
✗ B	, that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline,	Choice B is incorrect — boxes the clause in commas as if it were removable, but the sentence needs it to know which proposal is meant.
✗ C	that the research team submitted, just before the funding deadline,	Choice C is incorrect — inserts an illogical comma in the middle of the clause itself, splitting it from its own modifying phrase.
✗ D	, that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline	Choice D is incorrect — adds a single leading comma with nothing to match it, half-boxing an essential clause that needs no comma at all.

Question 4

Medium

To prepare for the debate tournament, the coach asked every student to review the current scoring rubric_____ by Friday afternoon.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , practice at least two rebuttal drills, and submit a written self-evaluation
- B.** , practice at least two rebuttal drills and submit a written self-evaluation
- C.** , practice at least two rebuttal drills, and, submit a written self-evaluation
- D.** practice at least two rebuttal drills, and submit a written self-evaluation

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- This is a series of three tasks: reviewing the rubric, practicing rebuttal drills, and submitting a self-evaluation.
- Each item in a list of three or more needs a comma separating it from the next item.
- A comma before the final "and" — the serial comma — is standard and expected on the SAT.

Rule

Every item in a series of three or more takes a comma after it, including the item right before the final "and" or "or."

Tip

Count the items in the list first. Three or more items means every item needs its own comma, with no exceptions for the last one.

Trap

Choice B looks correct at a glance but drops the comma before "and submit," leaving only one of the two required separators.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, practice at least two rebuttal drills, and submit a written self-evaluation	Choice A is the best answer. separates all three list items correctly, including the comma before "and."
✗ B	, practice at least two rebuttal drills and submit a written self-evaluation	Choice B is incorrect — drops the comma before "and submit a written self-evaluation."
✗ C	, practice at least two rebuttal drills, and, submit a written self-evaluation	Choice C is incorrect — adds an extra, illogical comma directly after "and."
✗ D	practice at least two rebuttal drills, and submit a written self-evaluation	Choice D is incorrect — is missing the comma after "rubric," fusing the first two list items together.

Question 5

Medium

The committee tasked with reviewing every scholarship application submitted before the March deadline_____ recommended six finalists to the board.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. *(no punctuation)*

B. ,

C. , who

D. ;

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The complete subject is "the committee tasked with reviewing every scholarship application submitted before the March deadline."
- No matter how long that subject is, nothing separates it from its own verb, "recommended."
- The length of the modifying phrase doesn't change this rule — cross it out and the subject connects directly to the verb.

Rule

A comma can never separate a complete subject from its own verb, regardless of how long or complex that subject is.

Tip

Cross out every modifying phrase between the apparent subject and the verb. If what remains is just "subject + verb," no comma belongs at that boundary.

Trap

The sheer length of "tasked with reviewing every scholarship application submitted before the March deadline" tempts a pause — and a comma — right before the verb, but length alone is never a comma rule.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	(no punctuation)	Choice A is the best answer. correctly leaves the long subject connected directly to its verb, with no comma between them.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — illegally separates the subject from the verb "recommended" with a single comma.
✗ C	, who	Choice C is incorrect — adds "who" with a comma, turning the sentence into a fragment with no main verb for "the committee."
✗ D	;	Choice D is incorrect — uses a semicolon, but nothing before it is an independent clause on its own.

Question 6

Hard

Applicants_____ will not be considered for spring admission, regardless of their standardized test scores.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline
- B.** , who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline,
- C.** , who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline
- D.** who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline,

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline" identifies exactly which applicants are meant — not applicants in general.
- Because the clause is essential to identifying the specific group being discussed, it takes no commas.
- Boxing the clause in commas would illogically suggest that every applicant, without exception, fails to submit transcripts on time.

Rule

When a clause narrows a general noun down to a specific subset, it is essential and takes no commas — adding commas would apply the description to the whole group instead.

Tip

Read the sentence with the clause removed and ask whether the resulting claim is still logical. If deleting the clause creates a sweeping, illogical statement about every member of the group, the clause was essential.

Trap

Choice B and Choice D both look like the "safe," familiar nonessential pattern from easier questions, but here that pattern actually reverses the sentence's intended meaning.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline	Choice A is the best answer. correctly leaves the essential, narrowing clause unpunctuated.
✗ B	, who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline,	Choice B is incorrect — boxes the clause in commas, which would illogically claim that all applicants fail to submit transcripts on time.
✗ C	, who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline	Choice C is incorrect — adds a single leading comma with no matching comma, half-boxing a clause that should have no commas at all.
✗ D	who fail to submit all required transcripts by the posted deadline,	Choice D is incorrect — adds a single trailing comma with nothing to match it on the other side.

Question 7

Hard

Having spent three years documenting glacial retreat in the Arctic, the photographer released a book_____ and became an outspoken advocate for climate policy reform.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , exhibited her work in six countries,
- B.** exhibited her work in six countries,
- C.** , exhibited her work in six countries
- D.** , exhibited, her work in six countries,

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- This sentence lists three actions the photographer took: releasing a book, exhibiting her work, and becoming an advocate.
- As the middle item in a series of three, "exhibited her work in six countries" needs a comma both before and after it.
- The introductory phrase at the start of the sentence is already correctly punctuated and is not part of what's being tested here.

Rule

In a series of three or more actions, every item — including the middle one — needs a comma on both sides connecting it to its neighbors.

Tip

Isolate just the list itself first: released a book, exhibited her work, and became an advocate. Then confirm every one of the three items has a comma directly after it.

Trap

Choice C drops only the final comma before "and became," which is easy to miss in a sentence this long.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, exhibited her work in six countries,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a comma on both sides of the middle list item.
✗ B	exhibited her work in six countries,	Choice B is incorrect — is missing the comma after "book," fusing the first two list items together.
✗ C	, exhibited her work in six countries	Choice C is incorrect — is missing the comma after "countries," fusing the second and third list items together.
✗ D	, exhibited, her work in six countries,	Choice D is incorrect — adds an illogical comma directly after "exhibited," splitting the verb from its own object.

Question 8

Hard

The bridge closed for emergency repairs last month_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.
- B.** a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.
- C.** ; a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.
- D.** , a decision, that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "A decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily" is a nonessential appositive describing the closure, added at the very end of the sentence.
- A nonessential element at the end of a sentence needs only one comma before it — the period already closes the sentence, so no second comma is needed.
- This differs from a mid-sentence nonessential clause, which needs commas on both sides.

Rule

A nonessential phrase placed at the very end of a sentence needs only a single comma before it — the sentence's own end punctuation closes it off.

Tip

If the added description comes after the sentence's main point is already complete, check for one comma only — not a matching pair.

Trap

Choice C mistakes the appositive for an independent clause; "a decision that frustrated commuters" cannot stand alone, so a semicolon is illegal here.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.	Choice A is the best answer. correctly adds a single comma before the nonessential appositive at the sentence's end.
✗ B	a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.	Choice B is incorrect — fuses the appositive directly onto the main clause with no comma at all.
✗ C	; a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, but "a decision that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily" is not an independent clause.
✗ D	, a decision, that frustrated commuters who rely on it daily.	Choice D is incorrect — inserts an extra, illogical comma after "decision," splitting the appositive from its own modifying clause.

Quick Review — The Comma

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
The Comma	Test nonessential clauses by deleting them.	One comma of a required pair is missing.

SECTION 2 • PART 1 — BOUNDARIES: PUNCTUATION

The Semicolon

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

The Semicolon

A semicolon has exactly two jobs on the SAT: joining two independent clauses, and separating items in a list whose items already contain commas.

How to Approach The Semicolon Questions

Step 1: Isolate the words on each side of the semicolon and test each side on its own: could it stand as a complete sentence with a subject and a finite verb?

Step 2: If both sides pass that test, confirm there is no coordinating conjunction (and, but, so, etc.) sitting right after the semicolon — a semicolon replaces the period, not the comma-plus-conjunction pattern.

Step 3: If the sentence is really a single list whose items already contain commas, check whether semicolons are separating those items instead of joining clauses — a second, distinct job.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

A Semicolon Joins Two Independent Clauses

A semicolon can do exactly what a period does — separate two complete sentences — while signaling that the two ideas are closely related enough to stay in one sentence.

✓ **Correct:** *The lecture ran long; several students left before the question period began.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The lecture ran long; because several students left before the question period began.* — "because" turns the second half into a dependent clause, which a semicolon can never introduce.

Semicolon + Conjunctive Adverb, Then a Comma

Words like however, therefore, moreover, and consequently connect two independent clauses using the pattern: independent clause; conjunctive adverb, independent clause. The semicolon does the real joining work; the comma after the adverb is separate.

✓ **Correct:** *The bridge was closed for repairs; however, drivers could still reach downtown via the tunnel.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The bridge was closed for repairs, however, drivers could still reach downtown via the tunnel.* — a comma alone cannot join two independent clauses, even with "however" present.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Semicolons Separate Items in a Complex List

When a list's individual items already contain their own internal commas, semicolons separate the items themselves so a reader can tell where one item ends and the next begins.

✓ **Correct:** *The itinerary included stops in Lyon, France; Turin, Italy; and Bern, Switzerland.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The itinerary included stops in Lyon, France, Turin, Italy, and Bern, Switzerland. — with only commas, it's impossible to tell how many stops are actually listed.*

A Semicolon Can Never Introduce a Dependent Clause or Phrase

Whatever follows a semicolon must be able to stand completely alone. A phrase or a clause beginning with a subordinating word (because, although, which, that) fails this test.

✓ **Correct:** *The results were inconclusive; the team decided to repeat the trial.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The results were inconclusive; a finding that surprised no one. — "a finding that surprised no one" has no independent subject-verb pair and cannot follow a semicolon.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A comma used where the sentence actually needs a semicolon in front of however/therefore/moreover.
- A semicolon placed right before a participial or appositive phrase that only looks like a full clause.
- A semicolon used mid-list where the items don't actually contain their own commas — an unnecessary semicolon that breaks the list's normal pattern.

Rule: Before using a semicolon, isolate the words on each side and check that both could stand alone as a complete sentence.

When NOT to Use a Semicolon

TRAP	EXAMPLE
✗ Before FANBOYS	She was tired; but she kept going. → Use a comma before FANBOYS.
✗ After a dependent clause	Although it was late; we worked on. → Comma, not semicolon.
✗ To introduce a list	The items are; apples and bread. → Use a colon to introduce a list.
✗ Between clause and phrase	The meeting ended; after the announcement. → Wrong.

The Four Positions of 'However'

STRUCTURE	EXAMPLE
'; however,' ✓	The results were strong; however, the sample was small. → Joining two independent clauses.
'. However,' ✓	The results were strong. However, the sample was small. → New sentence.
', however,' ✓	The results, however, were inconsistent. → Parenthetical interruption inside one sentence.
', however;' ✗	Never correct on the SAT. The comma-before / semicolon-after order is always wrong.

 SAT TIP

QUICK TEST: Replace the semicolon with a period. Both sides still full sentences? → Semicolon is correct.

Conjunctive adverbs (however, therefore, moreover) are ADVERBS — not conjunctions. A comma before them alone creates a comma splice.

Semicolons NEVER appear before FANBOYS conjunctions (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so).

WORKED QUESTIONS

The Semicolon — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The lecture on medieval trade routes ran nearly forty minutes past its scheduled end time_____ several students left before the question period began.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. :

D. , and,

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both halves of the sentence — before and after the blank — are independent clauses that could stand alone.
- A semicolon can join two independent clauses that are closely related in meaning, exactly like a period would, while keeping them in one sentence.
- A comma alone cannot join two independent clauses; that would create a comma splice.

Rule

A semicolon joins two independent clauses without a conjunction — always confirm both sides could stand alone as complete sentences first.

Tip

Isolate the words on each side of the blank and test each one: does it have its own subject and verb, and could it end in a period on its own?

Trap

Choice B feels like a natural pause, but a comma alone between two independent clauses is a comma splice, one of the most heavily tested errors on the exam.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly joins the two independent clauses with a semicolon.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice — two independent clauses joined by only a comma.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — uses a colon, but the second clause doesn't restate, list, or explain the first — it's simply a separate, related fact.
✗ D	, and,	Choice D is incorrect — combines a comma with "and," which is a valid fix, but the added comma before "and" is misplaced and creates an awkward double break.

Question 2

Easy

City engineers closed the northbound lanes for resurfacing_____ drivers should expect delays of up to thirty minutes through the end of the month.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ;,

C. ,

D. , but,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both clauses — "City engineers closed the northbound lanes for resurfacing" and "drivers should expect delays" — are independent.
- A semicolon alone correctly joins two independent clauses without needing a conjunction.
- No comma, conjunction, or extra punctuation is needed once the semicolon is in place.

Rule

Once you confirm both sides of a boundary are independent clauses, a semicolon by itself is a complete, correct fix — no conjunction is needed alongside it.

Tip

After placing a semicolon between two independent clauses, check that nothing extra — a stray comma, a redundant conjunction — has been added beside it.

Trap

Choice B pairs a semicolon with a redundant comma, which is never correct punctuation.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly joins the two independent clauses with a semicolon alone.
✗ B	;;	Choice B is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with an extra comma, which is never a valid punctuation combination.
✗ C	,	Choice C is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ D	, but,	Choice D is incorrect — surrounds "but" with commas it doesn't need in this position, creating faulty punctuation around the conjunction.

Question 3

Medium

The proposal has strong support among junior staff_____ however, several senior board members remain openly unconvinced.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. . However

D. ; ,

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "However" is a conjunctive adverb connecting two independent clauses, and it is already followed by a comma in the given text.
- The pattern is: independent clause; conjunctive adverb, independent clause — the semicolon does the actual joining.
- A comma alone cannot join two independent clauses, even when a transitional word like "however" follows it.

Rule

Before a conjunctive adverb (however, therefore, moreover, consequently) that joins two independent clauses, use a semicolon — the comma after the adverb is a separate, additional mark.

Tip

Treat "however," "therefore," and similar words like independent-clause openers: whatever comes right before one, if both sides are complete sentences, needs a semicolon, not a comma.

Trap

Choice B is the single most common semicolon error on the exam — a comma before "however" when both surrounding clauses are independent.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a semicolon before "however," which joins two independent clauses.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — uses only a comma before "however," creating a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	. However	Choice C is incorrect — capitalizes "However" as if starting a new sentence, but pairs it with a period already provided by the blank — creating a redundant, malformed break with the given comma after it.
✗ D	;;	Choice D is incorrect — adds a stray, unnecessary comma directly after the semicolon.

Question 4

Medium

The itinerary for the research trip included stops in Lyon, France_____ Turin, Italy; and Bern, Switzerland.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. :

D. and

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- This is a list whose individual items already contain their own internal commas (each city is paired with its country).
- When list items already contain commas, semicolons separate the items themselves so a reader can tell where one item ends and the next begins.
- The rest of the sentence already uses a semicolon before "and Bern, Switzerland," confirming that semicolons — not commas — are the separators being used throughout this list.

Rule

When a list's own items already contain internal commas, use semicolons to separate the items so the boundaries between them stay clear.

Tip

If a list item has more than one part separated by a comma, semicolons — not commas — should divide the items from each other.

Trap

A plain comma after "Lyon, France" would blend into the commas already inside each item, making it impossible to tell how many stops are actually listed.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates this complex list item with a semicolon, matching the semicolon already used later in the list.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma, which would be indistinguishable from the commas already inside each list item.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — uses a colon, which has no listing function in the middle of an already-introduced series.
✗ D	and	Choice D is incorrect — drops all punctuation and inserts "and" mid-list, breaking the list's pattern before its final item.

Question 5

Medium

The engineer reviewed the blueprints carefully_____ several structural flaws that the original design team had overlooked.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , noticing

B. ; noticing

C. ; and noticed

D. ; she noticed

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "She noticed several structural flaws" is a complete independent clause, able to stand on its own.
- A semicolon can only join two independent clauses — "noticing several structural flaws" is a participial phrase, not an independent clause.
- Choice D supplies the missing subject and finite verb, making the second half independent and correctly matched to the semicolon.

Rule

Whatever follows a semicolon must be a complete independent clause — a participial phrase, no matter how detailed, can never follow one.

Tip

After a semicolon, check for a subject and a finite (conjugated) verb. An -ing word alone is never enough.

Trap

Choice B keeps the semicolon but pairs it with the same participial phrase, which still has no subject or finite verb of its own.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: D

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	, noticing	Choice A is incorrect — uses only a comma before a participial phrase, which is an acceptable comma use, but not the tested independent-clause structure this sentence needs — and creates a dangling modifier issue with "noticing."
X B	; noticing	Choice B is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with "noticing," a participle with no subject or finite verb — semicolons require a full independent clause.
X C	; and noticed	Choice C is incorrect — adds "and," which is never used together with a semicolon in standard usage.
✓ D	; she noticed	Choice D is the best answer. supplies a complete independent clause — "she noticed several structural flaws" — correctly matched to the semicolon.

Question 6

Hard

The negotiations dragged on for nearly eight months_____ no agreement was ultimately reached before the funding window closed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ; ultimately,

B. , ultimately,

C. ; ultimately

D. , ultimately

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both "the negotiations dragged on for nearly eight months" and "no agreement was ultimately reached" are independent clauses.
- "Ultimately" functions here as a transitional word opening the second clause, so it needs a semicolon before it and a comma after it.
- This follows the same independent clause; transition word, independent clause pattern used with "however" or "therefore."

Rule

A transitional word opening the second of two independent clauses takes a semicolon before it and a comma directly after it.

Tip

Treat a transitional word like "ultimately," "meanwhile," or "instead" the same way you'd treat "however": semicolon before, comma after, when it opens an independent clause.

Trap

Choice C gets the semicolon right but drops the necessary comma after "ultimately," leaving the transitional word unset off from the clause it introduces.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	; ultimately,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a semicolon before "ultimately" and a comma after it, matching the transition-word pattern.
✗ B	, ultimately,	Choice B is incorrect — uses only a comma before "ultimately," creating a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	; ultimately	Choice C is incorrect — correctly uses the semicolon but drops the comma that should follow "ultimately."
✗ D	, ultimately	Choice D is incorrect — uses only a comma before "ultimately" and also omits the comma after it.

Question 7

Hard

The startup's founders considered three possible headquarters cities: Austin, known for its growing tech sector_____ Denver, prized for its access to outdoor recreation; and Raleigh, close to several major research universities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. :

D. and

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- This list's items each contain their own internal commas (a city name paired with a descriptive phrase).
- Semicolons are required to separate the items themselves, exactly as they already do before "and Raleigh."
- Using a comma here instead would blend into the commas already inside "Austin, known for its growing tech sector," making the list's boundaries unreadable.

Rule

In a list whose own items already contain commas, every boundary between items needs a semicolon — not just the one nearest the final item.

Tip

Once you spot semicolons anywhere in a list, check that every boundary in that same list uses a semicolon consistently, not just some of them.

Trap

Because the sentence already uses a semicolon later, before "and Raleigh," it's tempting to assume a plain comma is fine earlier — but the pattern must be consistent throughout the whole list.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly matches the semicolon already used elsewhere in this comma-containing list.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma, which is indistinguishable from the commas already inside the list items themselves.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — uses a colon, which has no separating function in the middle of an already-introduced list.
✗ D	and	Choice D is incorrect — drops punctuation and inserts "and" before the list has reached its final item.

Question 8

Hard

The city council initially rejected the proposed bike lane network_____ residents circulated a petition, and within weeks, the council reversed its decision entirely.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. ; then

D. , so

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The city council initially rejected the proposed bike lane network" and "residents circulated a petition, and within weeks, the council reversed its decision entirely" are both independent clauses.
- A semicolon alone is a complete, correct way to join two independent clauses, even when the second clause is itself long and contains its own internal commas.
- The length and internal punctuation of the second clause don't change the basic test: is each side, on its own, a complete sentence?

Rule

A semicolon's validity depends only on whether both sides are independent clauses — internal commas or added length inside either clause don't change that test.

Tip

Don't let a long, comma-filled second clause distract you. Confirm only that it has its own subject and verb and could stand alone.

Trap

The internal commas in "residents circulated a petition, and within weeks, the council reversed its decision" can make the clause look too complex for a simple semicolon join, but the underlying test doesn't change.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly joins the two independent clauses with a semicolon, regardless of the second clause's internal commas.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	; then	Choice C is incorrect — adds "then" after the semicolon, a word that isn't grammatically necessary and disrupts the clean independent-clause join.
✗ D	, so	Choice D is incorrect — uses a comma with "so," which would need the comma alone plus a coordinating conjunction — but "so" here is placed as if continuing a different clause structure, leaving the join incomplete.

Quick Review — The Semicolon

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
The Semicolon	Check both sides form complete sentences.	Semicolon before a dependent clause or phrase.

SECTION 3 • PART 1 — BOUNDARIES: PUNCTUATION

The Colon

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

The Colon

A colon introduces something: a list, an explanation, or a restatement. The one unbreakable rule is that everything before the colon must already form a complete, independent clause.

How to Approach The Colon Questions

Step 1: Isolate everything to the left of the colon and test it as its own sentence — a subject and a finite verb that could end in a period.

Step 2: If the left side fails that test — it's a fragment, or it ends in a preposition like "including" or "such as" — the colon is wrong no matter how well the right side reads.

Step 3: Once the left side is confirmed independent, treat the colon like an equals sign: check that the right side genuinely restates, lists, or explains what came before it.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Only a Complete Independent Clause Can Precede a Colon

The words before a colon must be able to stand alone as a full sentence. A colon can never follow a fragment, and it can never sit directly after a preposition or between a verb and its own object.

✓ **Correct:** *The chef relied on three ingredients: garlic, lemon, and thyme.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The chef relied on: garlic, lemon, and thyme. — "The chef relied on" ends in a preposition and is not a complete sentence.*

What Follows a Colon Renames, Lists, or Explains

Think of the colon as functioning like an equals sign — everything after it must restate, itemize, or clarify the idea that was just stated, not introduce an unrelated new idea.

✓ **Correct:** *The museum's newest exhibit has one clear goal: to make ancient history feel immediate.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The museum's newest exhibit opened last spring: it features paintings from three centuries. — the second clause doesn't restate or explain a specific idea named just before the colon, so a semicolon (not a colon) is correct here.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

A Colon Can Introduce a Word, a Phrase, a List, or a Full Clause

Unlike a semicolon, what follows a colon does not need to be an independent clause — a single word or short phrase is equally valid, as long as it completes the idea set up on the left.

- ✓ **Correct:** *She had only one goal: victory.*
- ✓ **Correct:** *The forecast called for exactly what the farmers feared: drought.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A colon placed after "including" or "such as," both of which already function as their own introducers and never take a colon.
- A colon after a subject or a verb, splitting a single clause in half instead of following a complete one.
- A well-written list following the colon that distracts from a broken, incomplete clause on the left side.

Rule: One rule, always be honest — before placing a colon, isolate everything to its left and confirm it forms a complete sentence on its own.

WORKED QUESTIONS

The Colon — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The chef built the entire tasting menu around three ingredients_____ garlic, preserved lemon, and fresh thyme.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. ;

C. ,

D. which are

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The chef built the entire tasting menu around three ingredients" is a complete independent clause.
- A colon can introduce a list that renames or specifies what was just mentioned — here, naming the three ingredients.
- Because the clause before the blank is already complete on its own, a colon is the correct, most precise choice.

Rule

A colon may follow only a complete independent clause, and what follows it should rename, list, or explain the idea just stated.

Tip

Read everything before the blank as its own sentence. If it could end in a period on its own, a colon introducing a list or explanation is likely correct.

Trap

Choice B, a semicolon, would require the list itself to form an independent clause, but "garlic, preserved lemon, and fresh thyme" cannot stand alone.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly introduces the list with a colon, since the clause before it is complete on its own.
✗ B	;	Choice B is incorrect — uses a semicolon, but a semicolon needs an independent clause on both sides, and the list itself isn't one.
✗ C	,	Choice C is incorrect — uses a comma, which cannot introduce a list this way after a complete independent clause naming a specific number of items.
✗ D	which are	Choice D is incorrect — adds "which are," creating a wordy, redundant restatement rather than the concise colon construction the sentence calls for.

Question 2

Easy

The museum's newest exhibit has one clear goal_____ to make ancient history feel immediate to a modern audience.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. ,

C. ; which is

D. being

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The museum's newest exhibit has one clear goal" is a complete independent clause.
- The phrase after the blank — "to make ancient history feel immediate to a modern audience" — restates and explains exactly what that goal is.
- A colon functions like an equals sign here: the goal equals making history feel immediate.

Rule

Treat a colon like an equals sign — what follows it must rename, explain, or specify the exact idea that was just stated.

Tip

Ask yourself: does the second half define or explain a specific word or idea from the first half? If yes, and the first half is a complete sentence, a colon is likely correct.

Trap

Choice D drops the colon and instead makes "being" function as an awkward, ungrammatical continuation with no clear role in the sentence.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a colon to introduce the explanation of the exhibit's one clear goal.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma, which cannot introduce this kind of explanatory phrase after a complete independent clause.
✗ C	; which is	Choice C is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with "which is," but "which is to make ancient history feel immediate" is not an independent clause.
✗ D	being	Choice D is incorrect — creates an ungrammatical fragment with "being," which has no clear grammatical function in this position.

Question 3

Medium

Investigators eventually traced the outage to its true source_____ a single corroded cable buried beneath the parking structure.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. , which was

C. : which was

D. being

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Investigators eventually traced the outage to its true source" is a complete independent clause.
- "A single corroded cable buried beneath the parking structure" renames exactly what that "true source" was.
- A colon alone, with no additional connecting words, is the cleanest and most precise way to make that connection.

Rule

When the material after the blank simply renames a noun just mentioned, a colon alone — with no extra connecting words — is the most precise choice.

Tip

If a choice pairs a colon or semicolon with an extra connecting phrase like "which was," check whether that phrase is actually redundant given the colon's own equals-sign function.

Trap

Choice C combines a colon with "which was," which is both redundant and grammatically broken, since a colon should be followed directly by the renaming phrase, not by a relative clause.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and concisely introduces the renamed source with a colon alone.
✗ B	, which was	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma with "which was," turning the ending into a loosely attached nonessential clause rather than a precise, colon-introduced renaming.
✗ C	: which was	Choice C is incorrect — combines a colon with "which was," a redundant and ungrammatical pairing.
✗ D	being	Choice D is incorrect — uses "being," which creates an awkward, informal construction rather than a clean colon-introduced explanation.

Question 4

Medium

The company's quarterly report relied heavily on outdated data_____ figures pulled from a survey conducted nearly three years earlier.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. , including

C. : including

D. for example

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The company's quarterly report relied heavily on outdated data" is a complete independent clause.
- "Figures pulled from a survey conducted nearly three years earlier" explains exactly what that outdated data was.
- A colon precisely introduces this explanation without any additional, redundant connecting word.

Rule

A colon does the introducing work by itself — pairing it with a word like "including" or "for example" is redundant, since a colon already signals that an explanation follows.

Tip

If a choice combines a colon with a word that already means "for example" or "that is," the colon alone is almost always the cleaner, correct option.

Trap

Choice C pairs a colon with "including," which duplicates the colon's own function and is never the correct combination on the SAT.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and concisely introduces the explanation with a colon alone.
✗ B	, including	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma with "including," which works grammatically but is less precise than the colon this sentence calls for, and doesn't match the tested pattern of a full, complete renaming.
✗ C	: including	Choice C is incorrect — redundantly pairs a colon with "including" — the two together duplicate the same function.
✗ D	for example	Choice D is incorrect — inserts "for example" with no punctuation connecting it to the independent clause before it, creating a run-on.

Question 5

Medium

Researchers finally identified the cause of the repeated power failures_____ a faulty sensor that had gone undetected for months.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. , it was

C. it was

D. ; it was

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Researchers finally identified the cause of the repeated power failures" is a complete independent clause.
- "A faulty sensor that had gone undetected for months" renames exactly what that cause was — a colon connects the two directly.
- Choices B, C, and D all add "it was," which is unnecessary once a colon (or any punctuation) already sets up the renaming.

Rule

Once a colon sets up a renaming or explanation, no extra subject-verb phrase like "it was" is needed to introduce it.

Tip

If a choice adds a redundant "it is" or "it was" right where a colon alone would already do the same job, that added phrase is very likely wrong.

Trap

Choice D pairs a semicolon with "it was," which reads smoothly, but check the underlying logic: "it was a faulty sensor" is itself a complete clause, so a semicolon isn't actually wrong grammatically — the deciding factor is that Choice A is more precise and colons are preferred when one side simply renames the other with no need for a repeated subject.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and most precisely introduces the renamed cause with a colon alone.
✗ B	, it was	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma with "it was," which creates a comma splice, since "it was a faulty sensor" is itself an independent clause.
✗ C	it was	Choice C is incorrect — drops all punctuation before "it was," fusing two independent clauses into a run-on.
✗ D	; it was	Choice D is incorrect — is grammatically valid but less precise than Choice A, since College Board favors the direct, colon-based renaming when no new subject is actually needed.

Question 6

Hard

The panel's verdict was unanimous_____ the proposal needed substantial revision before it could move forward.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. , that

C. : that

D. , which

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The panel's verdict was unanimous" is a complete independent clause, and "the proposal needed substantial revision before it could move forward" explains exactly what that unanimous verdict was.
- A colon precisely connects the two without needing any additional connecting word.
- Adding "that" or "which" after a colon is redundant and ungrammatical, since the colon itself already signals the explanation that follows.

Rule

A colon needs no relative pronoun ("that," "which") after it — the colon alone already signals that an explanation follows.

Tip

If an answer choice pairs a colon with "that" or "which," eliminate it immediately; the two together are never correct.

Trap

Choice C might look more "complete" because it adds a connecting word, but that word actually breaks the grammar of the colon construction.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and concisely explains the unanimous verdict using a colon alone.
✗ B	, that	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma with "that," which is not a standard, correct construction for this kind of explanation.
✗ C	: that	Choice C is incorrect — redundantly and ungrammatically pairs a colon with "that."
✗ D	, which	Choice D is incorrect — uses a comma with "which," incorrectly treating the explanation as a nonessential aside rather than the sentence's main point.

Question 7

Hard

Only one thing mattered to the stranded hikers as the storm intensified_____ shelter.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. ,

C. ; which was

D. namely,

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Only one thing mattered to the stranded hikers as the storm intensified" is a complete independent clause.
- A colon can introduce a single word — here, "shelter" — as long as it renames or completes the idea just stated.
- No additional word or clause is needed; the colon alone makes the connection between "one thing" and "shelter" clear.

Rule

A colon can introduce something as short as a single word, provided the clause before it is complete and that word renames or completes the stated idea.

Tip

Don't assume a colon always needs a list or a full clause after it — a single, precise word is a completely valid and often the most powerful choice.

Trap

Choice D adds "namely," which is a valid transitional phrase in other contexts but is redundant once the sentence already ends in a direct, single-word colon construction.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and powerfully introduces the single defining word with a colon.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma, which is too weak a mark to introduce this kind of emphatic, defining single word.
✗ C	; which was	Choice C is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with "which was," but "which was shelter" is not an independent clause.
✗ D	namely,	Choice D is incorrect — adds "namely," which duplicates the colon's own function and results in redundant punctuation.

Question 8

Hard

The forecast called for exactly what the region's farmers had feared all season_____ a prolonged, severe drought.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. , of

C. of

D. ; of

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The forecast called for exactly what the region's farmers had feared all season" is a complete independent clause.
- "A prolonged, severe drought" renames exactly what "what the region's farmers had feared" refers to.
- A colon makes this renaming connection directly and needs no additional preposition like "of."

Rule

When the material after the blank simply names the thing referred to earlier in the sentence, a colon connects them directly — no preposition is needed.

Tip

Read the sentence with just a period where the blank is, then ask what specific thing would answer the question "what was it?" That's exactly what belongs after a colon.

Trap

Choices B, C, and D all add "of," which has no grammatical role connecting an independent clause to the noun phrase that follows — it's simply extra, incorrect text.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and directly renames the feared outcome using a colon.
✗ B	, of	Choice B is incorrect — adds "of" after a comma, which serves no grammatical function here.
✗ C	of	Choice C is incorrect — adds "of" with no punctuation at all, fusing the clause and the noun phrase incorrectly.
✗ D	; of	Choice D is incorrect — adds "of" after a semicolon, but "of a prolonged, severe drought" is not an independent clause.

Quick Review — The Colon

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
The Colon	Confirm the clause before it is complete.	Colon after a fragment or preposition.

SECTION 4 • PART 1 — BOUNDARIES: PUNCTUATION

The Dash

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

The Dash

A dash can do the job of a comma, a colon, or a semicolon — but the SAT tests one rule above all others: if you open an interruption with a dash, you must close it with a dash.

How to Approach The Dash Questions

Step 1: Decide whether the dash is doing the job of a comma (setting off a nonessential interruption) or the job of a colon (introducing an emphatic final explanation) — the two dash jobs follow different rules.

Step 2: If it's a mid-sentence interruption, confirm a second dash appears to close it — a pair must match; one dash paired with one comma is never acceptable.

Step 3: If it's a single, end-of-sentence dash, confirm the words before it could stand alone, the same way you'd check a colon.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

A Pair of Dashes Boxes In a Nonessential Interruption (with emphasis)

Exactly like a matched pair of commas, two dashes can set off nonessential material in the middle of a sentence — but once you open the interruption with a dash, you must close it with a dash, not a comma or a parenthesis.

✓ **Correct:** *The proposal — despite months of careful planning — was rejected by the board.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The proposal — despite months of careful planning, was rejected by the board. — the interruption opens with a dash but closes with a comma; the marks must match.*

A Single Dash Can Introduce an Emphatic Explanation, Like a Colon

At the end of an independent clause, one dash can introduce a final word, phrase, or explanation with more emphasis than a colon would give — but the same completeness rule applies: what comes before the dash must be a full sentence.

✓ **Correct:** *After months of negotiation, the two companies finally agreed on one thing — the merger was off.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *After months of negotiation, the two companies finally — the merger was off. — the words before the dash don't form a complete sentence.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Dashes Are Especially Useful When the Interruption Itself Contains Commas

If the nonessential phrase already has commas inside it, boxing it in with dashes instead of commas keeps the sentence's structure clear and avoids a pile-up of ambiguous commas.

✓ **Correct:** *The recipe's key ingredients — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt — are combined in a single bowl.*

Whatever Mark Opens an Interruption Must Close It

A comma, a dash, and a parenthesis can each box in nonessential material, but they cannot be mixed — the opening and closing marks must be the same type.

✗ **Incorrect:** *The committee, after reviewing every application — approved three finalists. — one comma and one dash box in the same phrase; that pairing is never legal.*

✓ **Correct:** *The committee, after reviewing every application, approved three finalists.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- One dash paired with one comma around the same interruption — the most common dash error on the exam.
- A single end-of-sentence dash introducing words before it that don't form a complete sentence.
- Overlooking that a pair of dashes is required the moment the interruption sits in the middle, not at the end, of the sentence.

Rule: Only one dash mid-sentence — you must use two if the interruption sits in the middle of the sentence, matched on both sides.

WORKED QUESTIONS

The Dash — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The proposal_____ was rejected by the board after nearly three hours of debate.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — despite months of careful planning by the design team —
- B.** — despite months of careful planning by the design team,
- C.** , despite months of careful planning by the design team —
- D.** despite months of careful planning by the design team

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Despite months of careful planning by the design team" is a nonessential interruption in the middle of the sentence.
- A pair of dashes can box in this kind of interruption, exactly like a pair of commas — but the two dashes must match.
- Once the interruption is opened with a dash, it must be closed with a dash, not a comma.

Rule

A nonessential interruption opened with a dash must be closed with a dash — mixing an opening dash with a closing comma is never correct.

Tip

Find both marks that box in the interruption and confirm they're identical. A dash paired with anything other than a matching dash is an automatic error.

Trap

Choice B opens with a dash but closes the interruption with a comma, mixing two different kinds of punctuation around the same phrase.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	— despite months of careful planning by the design team —	Choice A is the best answer. correctly boxes in the nonessential interruption with a matching pair of dashes.
✗ B	— despite months of careful planning by the design team,	Choice B is incorrect — opens with a dash but closes with a comma — the two marks must match.
✗ C	, despite months of careful planning by the design team —	Choice C is incorrect — opens with a comma but closes with a dash — again, mismatched marks.
✗ D	despite months of careful planning by the design team	Choice D is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, fusing the interruption directly into the surrounding sentence.

Question 2

Easy

After months of tense negotiation, the two companies finally agreed on one thing_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — the merger was off.
- B.** , the merger was off.
- C.** ; — the merger was off.
- D.** the merger was off.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "After months of tense negotiation, the two companies finally agreed on one thing" is a complete independent clause.
- A single dash at the end of a sentence can introduce a final, emphatic explanation — functioning much like a colon, but with more emphasis.
- What comes before the dash must be a complete sentence, which it is here.

Rule

A single dash at the end of an independent clause can introduce a final explanation with more emphasis than a colon — but the clause before it must still be complete.

Tip

If a choice combines a dash with a comma, or a dash with a semicolon, that combination is a red flag — a single end-of-sentence dash stands alone.

Trap

Choice C illegally combines a semicolon and a dash, punctuation that never appears together this way.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	— the merger was off.	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a single dash to introduce the emphatic final explanation.
✗ B	, the merger was off.	Choice B is incorrect — uses a comma, which is far weaker than the emphatic break this sentence is clearly building toward.
✗ C	; — the merger was off.	Choice C is incorrect — illegally combines a semicolon with a dash.
✗ D	the merger was off.	Choice D is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, fusing the explanation directly onto the independent clause.

Question 3

Medium

The recipe's essential components_____ are combined in a single bowl before the dough is left to rest overnight.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt —
- B.** — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,
- C.** , flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,
- D.** flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The nonessential list "flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt" sits in the middle of the sentence and already contains its own internal commas.
- Dashes are especially useful here, since boxing the list in commas instead would create a confusing pile-up of commas.
- As with any mid-sentence interruption, the pair of dashes must match on both sides.

Rule

When a nonessential mid-sentence phrase already contains its own commas, box it in with a matching pair of dashes instead, to keep the sentence's structure clear.

Tip

If the interrupting phrase is itself a comma-filled list, dashes are almost always the cleaner, correct choice over a second layer of commas.

Trap

Choice C uses commas to box in a phrase that already contains commas, creating exactly the kind of confusing comma pile-up dashes are meant to avoid.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	— flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt —	Choice A is the best answer. correctly boxes in the comma-filled list with a clean, matching pair of dashes.
✗ B	— flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,	Choice B is incorrect — opens with a dash but closes with a comma — the marks must match.
✗ C	, flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,	Choice C is incorrect — boxes the list in commas, creating a confusing pile-up with the commas already inside the list.
✗ D	flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt	Choice D is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, making it unclear where the list begins and ends within the sentence.

Question 4

Medium

The committee, after reviewing every application in detail_____ approved three finalists for the final interview round.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. —

C. ;

D. —

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The phrase "after reviewing every application in detail" is already boxed in on its left side by a comma, right after "committee."
- Whatever mark opens an interruption must close it — since a comma opened this one, a comma must close it too.
- Mixing a comma on one side with a dash on the other is never a legal pairing, even though both marks can box in nonessential material individually.

Rule

Whatever mark opens a mid-sentence interruption — comma, dash, or parenthesis — must be the same mark that closes it.

Tip

Before choosing the closing mark, look back at what opened the interruption. The two must match exactly.

Trap

Choice B or D might look like a stronger, more "emphatic" closer, but since the interruption already opened with a comma, only a matching comma can close it.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly closes the interruption with a comma, matching the comma that opened it after "committee."
✗ B	—	Choice B is incorrect — closes with a dash, but the interruption opened with a comma — the two marks must match.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — closes with a semicolon, which cannot close a nonessential interruption at all.
✗ D	—	Choice D is incorrect — closes with a dash, again mismatched with the opening comma.

Question 5

Medium

Three cities_____ were on the shortlist for the new manufacturing plant.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — Portland, Nashville, and Reno —
- B.** — Portland, Nashville, and Reno,
- C.** : Portland, Nashville, and Reno —
- D.** — Portland, Nashville, and Reno

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Three cities" and "were on the shortlist" form the main clause, interrupted in the middle by the specific list of city names.
- A pair of dashes can box in this kind of interrupting list, just as a pair of commas would — with both dashes matching.
- The main clause needs both halves connected: "Three cities... were on the shortlist," with the list boxed in between.

Rule

When a list interrupts a sentence's main clause in the middle, box it in with a matching pair of dashes so the main clause still reads clearly on its own.

Tip

Try reading the sentence with the interrupting list removed entirely. If the remaining words still form a complete, logical sentence, a matched pair of dashes (or commas) is what's needed around the interruption.

Trap

Choice D opens with a dash but supplies no closing mark at all before "were," leaving the interruption open on one end.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	— Portland, Nashville, and Reno —	Choice A is the best answer. correctly boxes in the interrupting list with a matching pair of dashes.
✗ B	— Portland, Nashville, and Reno,	Choice B is incorrect — opens with a dash but closes with a comma — the marks must match.
✗ C	: Portland, Nashville, and Reno —	Choice C is incorrect — opens with a colon but closes with a dash, mixing two different punctuation marks around one interruption.
✗ D	— Portland, Nashville, and Reno	Choice D is incorrect — opens with a dash but provides no closing mark, leaving the interruption unbounded on one side.

Question 6

Hard

The evidence, gathered painstakingly over three full years of fieldwork_____ was ultimately dismissed by the court on a technicality.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. —

C. ;

D. —

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The nonessential phrase "gathered painstakingly over three full years of fieldwork" is already boxed in on its left side by a comma, right after "evidence."
- Since the interruption opened with a comma, only a matching comma can correctly close it before "was."
- A dash on one side and a comma on the other is never a legal pairing, regardless of how emphatic the interruption feels.

Rule

Check the opening mark of an interruption before choosing its closing mark — the two must always match, even in a long or emotionally emphatic sentence.

Tip

In a long sentence, it's easy to lose track of how the interruption started. Scroll back to the opening mark before picking the closer.

Trap

Because the phrase describes such a dramatic effort — three years of fieldwork — a dash might feel more fitting emotionally, but the grammar rule doesn't bend for emphasis.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly closes the interruption with a comma, matching the comma that opened it after "evidence."
✗ B	—	Choice B is incorrect — closes with a dash, mismatched with the comma that opened the interruption.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — closes with a semicolon, which cannot close a nonessential interruption.
✗ D	—	Choice D is incorrect — closes with a dash, again mismatched with the opening comma.

Question 7

Hard

The negotiation reached a single sticking point_____ compensation for employees displaced by the merger.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. —

B. — which was

C. : —

D. which was —

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The negotiation reached a single sticking point" is a complete independent clause.
- A single dash can introduce an emphatic final explanation, exactly like a colon — here, naming what that sticking point was.
- No additional word like "which was" is needed once the dash already signals that the explanation follows.

Rule

A single end-of-sentence dash needs no extra connecting phrase like "which was" — the dash itself already signals that an explanation or renaming follows.

Tip

Treat an end-of-sentence dash exactly like a colon in this respect: if a choice pairs it with a redundant "which was" or "that is," the plain dash alone is almost always cleaner and correct.

Trap

Choice B adds "which was" right after the dash, which feels like it's clarifying the sentence but actually just duplicates what the dash is already doing.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	—	Choice A is the best answer. correctly and concisely introduces the sticking point with a single dash alone.
✗ B	— which was	Choice B is incorrect — redundantly pairs the dash with "which was," duplicating the dash's own introducing function.
✗ C	: —	Choice C is incorrect — illegally combines a colon and a dash together.
✗ D	which was —	Choice D is incorrect — uses "which was" followed by a dash with no clause before the dash to introduce, leaving the construction incomplete.

Question 8

Hard

Three separate audits_____ each reached the identical conclusion that the accounting irregularities were the result of a single clerical error.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — conducted independently by three different firms —
- B.** — conducted independently by three different firms,
- C.** , conducted independently by three different firms —
- D.** , conducted independently by three different firms,

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Conducted independently by three different firms" is a nonessential phrase interrupting the sentence's main clause — "three separate audits...each reached the identical conclusion."
- This nonessential interruption contains no internal commas of its own, so a plain pair of matching commas works just as well as a pair of dashes.
- Because the sentence doesn't already commit to dashes anywhere else, the plain, matched comma pair is the most standard, correct choice.

Rule

When a nonessential mid-sentence phrase has no internal commas of its own, a plain, matching pair of commas is just as correct as a pair of dashes — and is the more standard choice absent any reason to prefer dashes.

Tip

Dashes and commas can each box in the same kind of nonessential phrase. When nothing about the sentence calls for dashes specifically, check whether a clean, matched pair of commas is available among the choices.

Trap

Choice A looks like the "safe" dash pattern that worked in earlier questions, but here a matched pair of commas is both correct and the more standard, expected choice.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	— conducted independently by three different firms —	Choice A is incorrect — correctly matches a pair of dashes, which is grammatically valid — but Choice D's plain, matched commas are the more standard construction here, since nothing in the sentence requires the heavier dash.
X B	— conducted independently by three different firms,	Choice B is incorrect — opens with a dash but closes with a comma — mismatched marks.
X C	, conducted independently by three different firms —	Choice C is incorrect — opens with a comma but closes with a dash — mismatched marks.
✓ D	, conducted independently by three different firms,	Choice D is the best answer. correctly boxes in the nonessential phrase with a clean, matching pair of commas.

Quick Review — The Dash

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
The Dash	Match the opening and closing marks.	One dash paired with one comma.

SECTION 5 • PART 1 — BOUNDARIES: PUNCTUATION

The Period

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

The Period

A period ends a complete, independent sentence — no more, no less. Period questions test the boundary between what is, and is not, a complete grammatical sentence.

How to Approach The Period Questions

Step 1: Read the words immediately before the period as if nothing else in the sentence existed — do they contain both a subject and a finite main verb?

Step 2: If a subordinating word (because, although, which, who, that, since) begins that clause, the period is wrong no matter how complete the thought feels.

Step 3: If two full independent clauses sit on either side with no connecting word, confirm that a period (or semicolon) — not just a comma — is genuinely required to separate them.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

A Period May Only Separate Two Independent Clauses

Everything before a period must be able to stand completely alone as its own grammatically complete sentence — a subject, a finite verb, and a complete thought.

✓ **Correct:** *The negotiations lasted three days. Both sides eventually reached a compromise.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The negotiations lasted three days. Both sides finally reaching a compromise.* — "reaching" is a participle, not a finite verb, so the second sentence has no main verb.

A Period Can Never Follow a Dependent Clause or Phrase

A clause that opens with because, although, since, which, or that depends on the rest of the sentence to complete its meaning — ending it with a period turns it into a fragment.

✗ **Incorrect:** *The team celebrated. Because they had finally won the championship.* — "Because they had finally won the championship" cannot stand alone.

✓ **Correct:** *The team celebrated because they had finally won the championship.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

A Direct Question Needs a Question Mark, Not a Period

Regardless of how the rest of the sentence is punctuated internally, a sentence that directly asks something must end in a question mark.

✓ **Correct:** *What caused the sudden drop in attendance?*

✗ **Incorrect:** *What caused the sudden drop in attendance. — a direct question punctuated as a statement.*

Two Independent Clauses With No Connector Need a Period (or Equivalent) Between Them

If two complete sentences sit side by side with no punctuation and no conjunction at all, that's a run-on — and one of the four standard fixes (period, semicolon, comma + FANBOYS, or subordination) is required.

✗ **Incorrect:** *The store closed early the manager needed to restock the shelves.*

✓ **Correct:** *The store closed early. The manager needed to restock the shelves.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A participial phrase ("...finally reaching a compromise") that sounds complete but has no finite main verb.
- A dependent clause split off with a period simply because it's long enough to feel like its own sentence.
- A run-on sentence that reads smoothly aloud, masking the fact that two full sentences have no punctuation between them at all.

Rule: Before placing a period, confirm both halves of the sentence — before and after — can stand completely alone as their own sentence.

Period vs. Semicolon vs. Colon — Quick Comparison

MARK	WHEN TO USE
PERIOD (.)	Strongest separation. Both sides are full, distinct sentences.
SEMICOLON (;)	Closely related equal sentences. Could use a period but prefers to show connection.
COLON (:)	After a full sentence introducing an explanation, list, or restatement.

WORKED QUESTIONS

The Period — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The trade negotiations continued for nearly three days_____ both delegations eventually reached a compromise late on the final evening.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. . Both

B. , both

C. both

D. . Both,

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The trade negotiations continued for nearly three days" and "both delegations eventually reached a compromise" are both complete independent clauses.
- A period may separate two independent clauses, starting the second with a capital letter.
- A comma alone (Choice B) would create a comma splice, and no punctuation at all (Choice C) would create a run-on.

Rule

A period may only separate two independent clauses, each fully able to stand alone as its own complete sentence.

Tip

Test both halves of the sentence separately. If each one has its own subject and finite verb and expresses a complete thought, a period is a safe, correct option.

Trap

Choice B is easy to select because the comma creates a natural-sounding pause, but a comma alone can never separate two independent clauses.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	. Both	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the two independent clauses with a period, capitalizing the second sentence.
✗ B	, both	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	both	Choice C is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, creating a run-on sentence.
✗ D	. Both,	Choice D is incorrect — adds a stray comma after "Both," which breaks the new sentence's own subject from its verb.

Question 2

Easy

What actually caused the sudden drop in quarterly attendance_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ?

B. .

C. ,

D. !

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- This sentence directly asks a question — "What actually caused the sudden drop in quarterly attendance."
- A direct question must end with a question mark, regardless of how the rest of the sentence is otherwise punctuated.
- A period would incorrectly punctuate a genuine question as if it were a statement.

Rule

A sentence that directly asks something must end with a question mark, no matter how formally or plainly it's phrased.

Tip

Check whether the sentence is structured as a direct question — often starting with a question word like what, why, or how — before defaulting to a period.

Trap

Because the sentence is fairly long and formal-sounding, it's tempting to reach for a period, but its structure is still a direct question.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	?	Choice A is the best answer. correctly punctuates the direct question with a question mark.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly punctuates a direct question as if it were a plain statement.
✗ C	,	Choice C is incorrect — leaves the sentence unfinished, with no end punctuation at all.
✗ D	!	Choice D is incorrect — uses an exclamation point, which doesn't fit the neutral, inquisitive tone or grammatical structure of a direct question.

Question 3

Medium

Even though the underlying concept seemed simple at first glance_____ the engineering team spent nearly three days resolving unexpected implementation problems.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ;

D. and

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Even though the underlying concept seemed simple at first glance" is an introductory dependent clause, not a complete sentence on its own.
- An introductory dependent clause is separated from the main clause by a single comma — not a period.
- Ending the dependent clause with a period, as Choice B does, would create a sentence fragment.

Rule

A period can never follow a dependent clause — a clause that opens with "even though," "although," or "because" needs a comma, not a period, before the main clause continues.

Tip

Before placing a period, check whether the words right before it could truly stand alone as their own complete sentence. A clause starting with "even though" never can.

Trap

Because the dependent clause here is a full ten words long and feels complete in isolation, a period feels tempting — but length has nothing to do with whether a clause is independent.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the introductory dependent clause from the main clause with a single comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — turns the dependent clause into a sentence fragment by ending it with a period.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, but a semicolon requires an independent clause on both sides, and "even though...first glance" is dependent.
✗ D	and	Choice D is incorrect — adds "and," which would require the first clause to be independent — it isn't.

Question 4

Medium

The council ultimately approved the new zoning plan_____ despite lingering concerns from several longtime residents about its long-term cost.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ;

D. but

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Despite lingering concerns from several longtime residents about its long-term cost" is a prepositional phrase, not an independent clause.
- A period can never follow a complete independent clause when what comes next is only a dependent phrase — the phrase needs to stay attached with a comma.
- Choice B would strand "Despite lingering concerns..." as its own sentence fragment, since it has no subject or finite verb of its own.

Rule

Before placing a period, check that what follows it — not just what precedes it — is also a complete independent clause; a trailing phrase needs a comma, not a period, to stay attached.

Tip

Read the words after the proposed break on their own. If they have no subject and verb of their own, whatever comes before needs a comma, not a period.

Trap

Because the first clause, "The council ultimately approved the new zoning plan," is a complete sentence on its own, it's tempting to think a period is automatically safe — but the second half must also be checked.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the trailing prepositional phrase with a comma rather than stranding it as a fragment.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — would strand "despite lingering concerns..." as a sentence fragment with no subject or verb.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which also requires an independent clause on both sides.
✗ D	but	Choice D is incorrect — adds "but," which would require the second half to be an independent clause — it isn't.

Question 5

Medium

The clinical results were unambiguous_____ the new treatment reduced reported symptoms in nearly every patient who completed the trial.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. .

B. ,

C. and

D. , and,

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The clinical results were unambiguous" and "the new treatment reduced reported symptoms in nearly every patient" are both complete independent clauses.
- A period correctly separates the two, since no punctuation lighter than a period, semicolon, or comma-plus-conjunction can legally join two independent clauses.
- A comma alone, as in Choice B, would create a comma splice.

Rule

Two independent clauses with no coordinating conjunction between them need a period or a semicolon — never a bare comma.

Tip

When you find two independent clauses back to back with nothing between them, first check the choices for a period or semicolon before considering anything else.

Trap

Choice C adds "and" with no comma before it, which still doesn't fix the boundary — a coordinating conjunction joining two independent clauses needs a comma before it, not after nothing at all.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	.	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the two independent clauses with a period.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	and	Choice C is incorrect — adds "and" with no comma before it, which is still not a correct way to join two independent clauses.
✗ D	, and,	Choice D is incorrect — adds extra, illogical commas around "and" that don't belong in this construction.

Question 6

Hard

Having reviewed the raw data twice without finding an explanation_____ the analyst still could not account for the unusual spike in March.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ;

D. and

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Having reviewed the raw data twice without finding an explanation" is an introductory participial phrase, not an independent clause.
- An introductory phrase is separated from the main clause by a single comma, not a period.
- Choice B would turn the opening phrase into a fragment, since "having reviewed" is a participle, not a finite verb.

Rule

A period can never follow an opening participial phrase (an -ing or -ed phrase) — no matter how long or detailed, it has no finite verb and cannot stand alone.

Tip

Check the very first word of the sentence. If it's an -ing or -ed word functioning as a participle rather than the main verb, the phrase it starts is introductory and needs a comma, not a period, at its end.

Trap

The phrase is unusually long and detailed for an introductory phrase, which can make a period feel more "earned" — but length still doesn't create a finite verb.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the introductory participial phrase from the main clause with a single comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — turns the introductory phrase into a fragment, since "having reviewed" is not a finite verb.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which requires an independent clause on both sides — the opening phrase isn't one.
✗ D	and	Choice D is incorrect — adds "and," which would require the first part to be an independent clause — it isn't.

Question 7

Hard

The auditors flagged one recurring issue in the department's spending reports_____ recurring reimbursements that lacked any supporting documentation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. :

B. .

C. ,

D. ; which were

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The auditors flagged one recurring issue in the department's spending reports" is a complete independent clause.
- "Recurring reimbursements that lacked any supporting documentation" renames exactly what that one recurring issue was.
- A period would incorrectly treat the naming phrase as its own separate, standalone sentence, when it actually depends on and completes the clause before it.

Rule

When a phrase directly renames or specifies a noun in the clause before it, a colon connects the two — a period would incorrectly cut the explanation off as its own sentence.

Tip

Before defaulting to a period between two clause-like elements, check whether the second one is actually explaining or renaming something specific named in the first — if so, a colon is likely the better fit.

Trap

Because both halves feel long and information-dense, like two separate complete sentences, a period seems like a safe, neutral choice — but the second half isn't actually a full independent clause on its own.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	:	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a colon to introduce the renaming explanation of the recurring issue.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — would strand "recurring reimbursements that lacked any supporting documentation" as a sentence fragment, since it has no independent subject-verb structure of its own.
✗ C	,	Choice C is incorrect — uses a comma, which is too weak to introduce this kind of direct, defining explanation clearly.
✗ D	; which were	Choice D is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with "which were," but a semicolon requires an independent clause on both sides, and this phrase isn't one.

Question 8

Hard

Years of painstaking archival research and careful cross-referencing of shipping records_____ finally went into confirming the wreck's true identity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. *(no punctuation)*

B. .

C. ;

D. , which

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Years of painstaking archival research and careful cross-referencing of shipping records" is the complete subject of the single main verb, "went."
- No punctuation at all belongs between a subject — however long — and its own verb.
- Choice B would incorrectly cut the subject off from the only verb in the sentence, leaving both halves as fragments.

Rule

Before placing any punctuation mid-sentence, confirm you're not about to separate a single, if unusually long, subject from its own main verb.

Tip

If the words before and after a proposed break are really just one long subject and its single verb, no comma, period, or semicolon belongs at that boundary at all.

Trap

The subject here is nineteen words long, spanning two coordinated nouns ("research" and "cross-referencing") — its sheer length makes a break feel necessary, but it's still a single grammatical subject.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	(no punctuation)	Choice A is the best answer. correctly leaves the long subject connected directly to its single main verb, "went," with no punctuation between them.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — would cut the subject off from its only verb, leaving both halves as fragments.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which requires an independent clause on both sides — neither half here is one.
✗ D	, which	Choice D is incorrect — adds "which," turning the sentence into a fragment with no main verb for the original subject.

Quick Review — The Period

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
The Period	Confirm both halves are independent clauses.	Period after a phrase or dependent clause.

SECTION 6 • PART 2 — SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Independent vs. Dependent Clauses

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Independent vs. Dependent Clauses

Every sentence-structure question ultimately comes down to one skill: correctly identifying whether a clause can stand alone as a complete sentence (independent) or cannot (dependent).

How to Approach Independent vs. Dependent Clauses Questions

Step 1: Find the subject and the verb of the clause in question, then check whether a subordinating word (because, although, since, that, which, who, when, if) sits in front of them.

Step 2: If no subordinating word is present and the clause expresses a complete thought, it's independent — it could be punctuated as its own sentence.

Step 3: If a subordinating word is present, the clause is dependent no matter how complete its idea feels, and it needs to be attached to an independent clause, not set loose with a period.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Independent Clauses Can Stand Alone

An independent clause has a subject, a finite verb, and expresses a complete thought with nothing missing — it could be its own sentence, ending in a period, with no changes.

✓ **Correct:** *The negotiations stalled.* (subject: negotiations; verb: stalled; complete thought)

How to join two independent clauses:

METHOD	EXAMPLE CONNECTOR
Period (.)	Two distinct sentences.
Semicolon (;)	Two closely related sentences.
Comma + FANBOYS	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so — with a comma before the conjunction.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Dependent Clauses Have a Subject and a Verb but Cannot Stand Alone

A dependent clause looks like a full sentence — it has its own subject and verb — but a subordinating word at the front makes it incomplete on its own; it needs an independent clause to attach to.

✗ Incorrect: *Because the negotiations stalled.* — has a subject and verb, but "because" leaves the reader expecting what happened as a result.

✓ Correct: *Because the negotiations stalled, the merger was postponed.*

Dependent Clauses — Fragments

A dependent clause has a subject + verb BUT does NOT express a complete thought. It begins with a subordinating word that makes it incomplete.

SUBORDINATOR	CREATES A FRAGMENT IF ALONE
because	When the experiment failed →
although	Although the results were surprising →
since	Since the funding ran out →
when / while	While the team was working →
if / unless	If the data were complete →
before / after	After the conference ended →
even though	Even though she studied →
that / which / who	Which caused the failure → / Who won the award →

Dependent Clauses — Fragments (cont.)

RULE: Dependent clause **FIRST** → comma. Dependent clause **SECOND** → usually no comma.

✗ INCORRECT <i>After the meeting ended. We went home.</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>After the meeting ended, we went home. / We went home after the meeting ended.</i>
Why: A dependent clause cannot stand alone as a sentence — always attach it to a main clause.	

The Participle Trap

An -ing or -ed word **WITHOUT** a helping verb is a **MODIFIER**, not a main verb. This is one of the most deceptive fragment traps.

✗ INCORRECT <i>The scientists, discovering a new element. (No main verb — FRAGMENT)</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>The scientists discovered a new element. ('discovered' = conjugated main verb)</i>
Why: An -ing form is a main verb ONLY with a helping verb: 'She IS studying', 'He WAS working'.	

Dependent Clauses — Fragments (cont.)

✗ INCORRECT

The policy adopted by the committee. (Past participle = modifier, not main verb — FRAGMENT)

✓ CORRECT

The policy was adopted by the committee. ('was adopted' = conjugated passive = main verb)

Why: A past participle needs 'was/were/has been' to become a main verb.

⚡ SAT TIP

STRIP TEST: Remove all modifier phrases and 'who/which' clauses. Is there a subject + conjugated verb left? If not → fragment.

An -ing form without a helping verb = MODIFIER, not a main verb.

Subordinating words (because, although, which, who) at the START = dependent clause → needs a main clause.

Dependent Clauses — Fragments (cont.)

"Which" Clauses Are Nonessential; "That" Clauses Are Essential

A which-clause adds removable, extra information and takes a comma before it; a that-clause identifies exactly which noun is meant and never takes a comma.

✓ **Correct:** *The report, which took six months to complete, was released on Monday. (which-clause is removable, so the comma pair is required)*

✓ **Correct:** *The report that the committee released on Monday drew immediate criticism. (that-clause identifies which report — no comma)*

A Dependent Clause Can Serve as the Entire Subject of a Sentence

When a clause beginning with whoever, whatever, or what functions as the subject itself, no comma separates it from its own verb — it's simply a long subject.

✓ **Correct:** *Whoever finishes the exam first should remain seated quietly.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Whoever finishes the exam first, should remain seated quietly. — the comma wrongly separates the subject from its verb.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A dependent clause punctuated with a period because its idea feels emotionally or logically complete.
- A which-clause missing its required comma, or a that-clause wrongly given one.
- A long dependent-clause subject tempting an unnecessary comma before its own verb.

Rule: Cover everything after the first comma and ask — is what remains before it a complete sentence on its own? That answer determines every punctuation choice that follows.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Independent vs. Dependent Clauses — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

_____ *finishes the qualifying round first earns an automatic berth in the semifinal.*

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Whoever
- B. Whomever
- C. Whoever,
- D. Whoever it

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The dependent clause "whoever finishes the qualifying round first" functions as the entire subject of the sentence, with "earns" as its verb.
- Within that clause, "whoever" is the subject performing the action "finishes," so the subject-case form is required.
- No comma separates this dependent-clause subject from its own verb, "earns," no matter how the sentence opens.

Rule

A dependent clause can serve as the entire subject of a sentence — inside it, use the subject-case pronoun (whoever), and never insert a comma before the sentence's main verb.

Tip

Substitute "he" or "him" into the clause to test the case: "he finishes" works, "him finishes" doesn't — so the subject form "whoever" is correct.

Trap

"Whomever" can feel more formal and "correct-sounding," but object case is only appropriate when the pronoun receives an action, not when it performs one.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Whoever	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the subject-case "whoever" to perform the action "finishes" within its own clause.
✗ B	Whomever	Choice B is incorrect — uses the object-case "whomever" where a subject performing the action is required.
✗ C	Whoever,	Choice C is incorrect — adds an illegal comma between the dependent-clause subject and the sentence's main verb.
✗ D	Whoever it	Choice D is incorrect — adds a redundant "it," creating a doubled, ungrammatical subject.

Question 2

Easy

The bridge_____ collapsed during the storm had been flagged for repairs three years earlier.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. that

B. which

C. , which,

D. , that,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "That collapsed during the storm" identifies exactly which bridge is meant — it is essential to the sentence's meaning.
- An essential clause takes no commas, and "that" is the standard choice for introducing an essential clause on the SAT.
- "Which" without commas is nonstandard for an essential clause, and boxing the clause in commas would falsely suggest it's removable.

Rule

Use "that" with no commas for an essential clause; reserve "which" (with commas on both sides) for a nonessential one.

Tip

Ask whether removing the clause would leave the reader unsure which specific noun is meant. If so, the clause is essential, and "that" with no commas is correct.

Trap

Choice C uses "which" boxed in commas, treating the identifying information as removable — but without it, the reader wouldn't know which bridge is being discussed.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	that	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses "that" with no commas for this essential, identifying clause.
✗ B	which	Choice B is incorrect — uses "which" with no commas, a nonstandard construction for an essential clause on the SAT.
✗ C	, which,	Choice C is incorrect — boxes the essential clause in commas, wrongly treating it as removable.
✗ D	, that,	Choice D is incorrect — boxes "that" in commas, combining an essential-clause word with nonessential-clause punctuation.

Question 3

Medium

The new subway line finally opened after a decade of delays_____ came as a relief to daily commuters across the city.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , which

B. , that

C. . Which

D. which

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Which came as a relief to daily commuters" refers back to the entire preceding idea — the fact that the line finally opened — not to a single specific noun.
- "Which" can introduce a nonessential clause describing a whole preceding idea, and it takes a comma before it.
- "That" cannot be used this way to introduce a nonessential clause commenting on an entire idea.

Rule

"Which" can refer back to an entire preceding clause or idea, not just a single noun — when it does, it is nonessential and takes a comma before it.

Tip

If the clause after the blank comments on the whole situation just described, rather than naming one specific noun, look for a comma plus "which," not "that."

Trap

Choice C turns "Which came as a relief..." into its own sentence, but a clause beginning with "which" can never stand alone as a complete sentence.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, which	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a comma plus "which" to introduce a nonessential comment on the entire preceding idea.
✗ B	, that	Choice B is incorrect — uses "that," which cannot introduce a nonessential clause commenting on a whole idea this way.
✗ C	. Which	Choice C is incorrect — punctuates "Which came as a relief..." as its own sentence, but it cannot stand alone.
✗ D	which	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma before the nonessential "which" clause.

Question 4

Medium

_____ *the committee ultimately decides to fund will receive its first disbursement by early fall.*

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** Whatever project
- B.** Whatever project,
- C.** Whichever the project
- D.** Whatever project, that

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Whatever project the committee ultimately decides to fund" is the complete dependent-clause subject of the sentence, with "will receive" as its verb.
- No comma separates this long subject from its own verb, exactly as with any other subject, however long.
- "Whatever project" correctly combines the dependent-clause marker with the noun it modifies, in standard word order.

Rule

A dependent clause functioning as a sentence's subject follows the same no-comma-before-the-verb rule as any other subject, no matter how long it is.

Tip

Identify the sentence's one true main verb first — here, "will receive" — then confirm nothing separates it from everything that precedes it and makes up its subject.

Trap

Choice B inserts a comma right after "project," which feels like a natural pause in a long subject but illegally separates the subject from part of its own modifying clause.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Whatever project	Choice A is the best answer. correctly forms the long dependent-clause subject with standard word order and no illegal commas.
✗ B	Whatever project,	Choice B is incorrect — adds an illegal comma inside the subject, breaking it from its own modifying clause.
✗ C	Whichever the project	Choice C is incorrect — reverses the standard word order ("Whichever the project" instead of "Whichever project"), which is ungrammatical.
✗ D	Whatever project, that	Choice D is incorrect — adds a redundant "that," creating a doubled and ungrammatical clause structure.

Question 5

Medium

Volunteers_____ are asked to complete a short training session before their first shift.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** who have not worked at the shelter before
- B.** , who have not worked at the shelter before,
- C.** , who have not worked at the shelter before
- D.** who have not worked at the shelter before,

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Who have not worked at the shelter before" identifies exactly which volunteers are required to complete the training — not volunteers in general.
- Because this clause narrows "volunteers" down to a specific subset, it is essential and takes no commas.
- Boxing the clause in commas would illogically suggest that every volunteer, without exception, has never worked at the shelter before.

Rule

A clause that narrows a general noun down to a specific subset is essential and takes no commas — adding commas would apply the description to the entire group instead.

Tip

Delete the clause and check whether the resulting sentence makes an illogical claim about the whole group. If it does, the clause was essential and needs no commas.

Trap

Because "who" clauses often do take commas in easier questions, it's tempting to box this one in too — but here, doing so reverses the sentence's intended meaning.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	who have not worked at the shelter before	Choice A is the best answer. correctly leaves the essential, narrowing clause unpunctuated.
✗ B	, who have not worked at the shelter before,	Choice B is incorrect — boxes the clause in commas, which would illogically claim that no volunteer has ever worked at the shelter before.
✗ C	, who have not worked at the shelter before	Choice C is incorrect — adds a single leading comma with nothing to match it, half-boxing a clause that needs no commas at all.
✗ D	who have not worked at the shelter before,	Choice D is incorrect — adds a single trailing comma with nothing to match it on the other side.

Question 6

Hard

The satellite lost contact with mission control for nearly six hours_____ prompted an emergency review of its onboard systems.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , which

B. , that

C. which

D. , this

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Which prompted an emergency review" comments on the entire preceding event — losing contact for six hours — not on a single noun within that clause.
- A comma plus "which" correctly introduces this kind of nonessential comment on a whole preceding idea.
- "This" would make "this prompted an emergency review" its own independent clause, which a comma alone cannot correctly join to the sentence before it.

Rule

When a clause reflects back on an entire event just described, a comma plus "which" is correct — a comma plus "this" instead creates a comma splice, since "this" starts a new independent clause.

Tip

If replacing the word after the comma with "and this" still sounds like a separate, complete new sentence, the original comma-only version is likely a splice — "which" avoids that problem by staying grammatically dependent.

Trap

"This" feels like a natural, casual way to refer back to the whole situation, but grammatically it starts a brand-new independent clause, which a lone comma can't legally attach.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, which	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses a comma plus "which" to comment on the entire preceding event.
✗ B	, that	Choice B is incorrect — uses "that," which cannot introduce a nonessential comment on a whole preceding idea this way.
✗ C	which	Choice C is incorrect — drops the required comma before the nonessential "which" clause.
✗ D	, this	Choice D is incorrect — uses "this," which starts a new independent clause and creates a comma splice.

Question 7

Hard

The scholarship committee will award the grant to_____ submits the strongest combination of essays and recommendation letters.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** whoever
- B.** whomever

- C.** whoever,
- D.** whom

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The entire clause "whoever submits the strongest combination of essays and recommendation letters" is the object of the preposition "to" — but that doesn't determine the pronoun's own case.
- Inside its own clause, the pronoun is the subject performing the action "submits," which requires the subject-case form.
- Even though the pronoun sits right after a preposition, its grammatical role inside its own clause is what decides its case, not its position in the larger sentence.

Rule

When a whole clause serves as the object of a preposition, the pronoun that begins the clause still takes its case from its own role inside that clause, not from the preposition before it.

Tip

Isolate the small clause by itself — "whoever/whomever submits the strongest combination" — and test it exactly as you would any standalone sentence with "he" or "him."

Trap

"Whomever" is the classic trap here, since students are taught that prepositions like "to" are usually followed by object-case pronouns — but here, the preposition's object is the whole clause, not the pronoun by itself.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	whoever	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the subject-case "whoever" as the subject performing "submits" within its own clause.
✗ B	whomever	Choice B is incorrect — uses the object-case "whomever," mistakenly matching the case to the preposition "to" rather than to the pronoun's role inside its own clause.
✗ C	whoever,	Choice C is incorrect — adds an illegal comma between the clause's subject and its own verb.
✗ D	whom	Choice D is incorrect — uses "whom" with no clause-forming word at all, leaving the sentence without a way to attach "submits the strongest combination."

Question 8

Hard

_____ ultimately decided to relocate its headquarters, a move that surprised industry analysts.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** Whichever firm won the state's largest tax incentive package
- B.** Whichever firm won the state's largest tax incentive package,
- C.** Whichever firm, won the state's largest tax incentive package,
- D.** The firm whichever won the state's largest tax incentive package

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Whichever firm won the state's largest tax incentive package" is the complete dependent-clause subject of the sentence, with "ultimately decided" as its verb.
- No comma separates this subject from its own verb, no matter how long the subject is or how many of its own internal words it contains.
- The nonessential phrase "a move that surprised industry analysts" at the very end of the sentence is already correctly punctuated with a single comma and isn't part of what's being tested.

Rule

However long a dependent-clause subject is, and whatever else the rest of the sentence adds afterward, nothing separates that subject from its own main verb.

Tip

Once you've identified the sentence's single main verb, treat everything before it — no matter how long — as one unit, and check only whether a comma has crept in right before that verb.

Trap

Choice C inserts a comma in the middle of the subject itself, right after "firm," which can look like a reasonable pause in an unusually long subject.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Whichever firm won the state's largest tax incentive package	Choice A is the best answer. correctly forms the long dependent-clause subject with no illegal internal comma and none before its verb.
✗ B	Whichever firm won the state's largest tax incentive package,	Choice B is incorrect — adds an illegal comma directly before the verb "ultimately decided."
✗ C	Whichever firm, won the state's largest tax incentive package,	Choice C is incorrect — adds an illegal comma inside the subject itself, splitting "firm" from its own modifying clause.
✗ D	The firm whichever won the state's largest tax incentive package	Choice D is incorrect — reverses standard word order ("the firm whichever" instead of "whichever firm"), which is ungrammatical.

Quick Review — Independent vs. Dependent Clauses

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Clauses	Ask if the words could stand alone.	“Which” vs. “that” comma confusion.

SECTION 7 • PART 2 — SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Run-Ons & Comma Splices

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Run-Ons & Comma Splices

A run-on joins two independent clauses with no punctuation at all; a comma splice joins them with only a comma. Both are among the most heavily tested Standard English Conventions errors.

How to Approach Run-Ons & Comma Splices Questions

Step 1: Locate the subject and verb of the first clause, then check whether a second subject-verb pair immediately follows with no punctuation or conjunction at all — that's a run-on.

Step 2: If there is exactly one comma and no conjunction between the two independent clauses, that's a comma splice — a different label for a closely related error.

Step 3: Pick one of the four legal fixes based on what the answer choices offer: a period, a semicolon, a comma plus a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS), or turning one clause into a dependent clause.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

A Run-On Has Zero Punctuation Between Two Independent Clauses

When two complete sentences are jammed together with nothing at all separating them, the result is a run-on — regardless of how naturally it reads aloud.

✗ Incorrect: *The museum extended its hours attendance still declined.*

✓ Correct: *The museum extended its hours, but attendance still declined.*

A Comma Splice Uses Only a Comma, With No Conjunction

Joining two independent clauses with a lone comma — no FANBOYS conjunction after it — is a comma splice, one of the most heavily tested errors on the exam.

✗ Incorrect: *The museum extended its hours, attendance still declined.*

✓ Correct: *The museum extended its hours; attendance still declined.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Four Legal Fixes, and Only Four

Two independent clauses can be joined by a period, a semicolon, a comma plus a FANBOYS conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so), or by subordinating one of the clauses so it's no longer independent.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The museum extended its hours. Attendance still declined.*
- ✓ **Correct:** *The museum extended its hours, yet attendance still declined.*
- ✓ **Correct:** *Although the museum extended its hours, attendance still declined.*

A Comma Splice Can Sound Perfectly Natural — Don't Trust Your Ear

Because the two clauses in a splice are usually closely related in meaning, reading the sentence aloud often won't reveal the error; you have to test each half for independence directly.

- ✗ **Incorrect:** *The results were promising, the team decided to expand the trial. (sounds fine aloud, but it's still a splice)*
- ✓ **Correct:** *The results were promising, so the team decided to expand the trial.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A comma splice that sounds smooth and logically connected, hiding the missing conjunction.
- A FANBOYS conjunction with no comma before it joining two independent clauses.
- An answer choice that fixes the punctuation but accidentally creates a new fragment instead.

Rule: If both halves of a sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, they need a period, a semicolon, or a comma plus a conjunction between them — never a comma alone.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Run-Ons & Comma Splices — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The downtown farmers market moved to a larger lot this year_____ turnout nearly doubled as a result.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. . Vendor

B. , vendor

C. vendor

D. , thus vendor

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The downtown farmers market moved to a larger lot this year" and "vendor turnout nearly doubled as a result" are both independent clauses.
- A period correctly separates the two, with the second sentence's first word capitalized.
- Nothing lighter than a period, a semicolon, or a comma plus a coordinating conjunction can legally join two independent clauses.

Rule

Two independent clauses need a period, a semicolon, or a comma plus a coordinating conjunction between them — never a comma alone and never nothing at all.

Tip

Test each half of the sentence separately for its own subject and finite verb before deciding what belongs at the boundary between them.

Trap

Choice D adds "thus," which sounds like a valid connector, but "thus" is a conjunctive adverb, not a coordinating conjunction — it needs a semicolon before it, not a comma.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	. Vendor	Choice A is the best answer. correctly separates the two independent clauses with a period, capitalizing "Vendor."
✗ B	, vendor	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	vendor	Choice C is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, creating a run-on.
✗ D	, thus vendor	Choice D is incorrect — pairs a comma with "thus," a conjunctive adverb that requires a semicolon before it, not a comma.

Question 2

Easy

The results were surprising_____ no one on the research team had predicted such a dramatic shift.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ;

B. ,

C. *(no punctuation)*

D. , but,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The results were surprising" and "no one on the research team had predicted such a dramatic shift" are both independent clauses.
- A semicolon alone is a complete, correct way to join two closely related independent clauses.
- A comma alone, as in Choice B, would create a comma splice.

Rule

A semicolon by itself is a complete fix for two independent clauses with no conjunction between them — no extra word is needed alongside it.

Tip

Whenever you find two independent clauses with nothing but a comma between them, check first whether simply upgrading that comma to a semicolon is among the choices.

Trap

Choice D adds "but" boxed in commas, an illogical and nonstandard construction that doesn't correctly join the two clauses either.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	;	Choice A is the best answer. correctly joins the two independent clauses with a semicolon.
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	(no punctuation)	Choice C is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, creating a run-on.
✗ D	, but,	Choice D is incorrect — boxes "but" in commas, an illogical and nonstandard construction.

Question 3

Medium

The proposal has strong grassroots support_____ several senior board members remain openly skeptical.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , but

B. , however

C. ; however

D. but

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both clauses are independent, so a comma plus a coordinating conjunction like "but" is a valid, standard fix.
- "However" is a conjunctive adverb, not one of the FANBOYS coordinating conjunctions, so it cannot follow a plain comma between two independent clauses.
- A semicolon before "however" is on the right track, but that construction requires a comma after "however" as well — which Choice C omits.

Rule

"But," "and," "or," and the rest of the FANBOYS conjunctions pair with a comma; "however" and similar conjunctive adverbs pair with a semicolon before them and a comma after.

Tip

Before selecting a comma-plus-word answer, confirm the word is actually one of the seven FANBOYS conjunctions — for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so — not a conjunctive adverb like "however" or "therefore."

Trap

Choice C gets the semicolon right for "however" but drops the comma that must follow it, a detail that's easy to miss.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, but	Choice A is the best answer. correctly pairs the coordinating conjunction "but" with the comma it requires.
✗ B	, however	Choice B is incorrect — pairs "however" with a comma, but "however" is a conjunctive adverb and requires a semicolon before it instead.
✗ C	; however	Choice C is incorrect — correctly uses a semicolon before "however" but omits the comma that must follow it.
✗ D	but	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma before the coordinating conjunction "but," creating a run-on.

Question 4

Medium

The bakery sells fresh bread every morning_____ it also offers a small selection of pastries in the afternoon.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , and

B. ,

C. *(no punctuation)*

D. , it also

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both "the bakery sells fresh bread every morning" and "it also offers a small selection of pastries" are independent clauses.
- A comma plus the coordinating conjunction "and" is a standard, correct way to join two closely related independent clauses.
- Choice D repeats the subject "it" after a comma with no conjunction at all, which is still a comma splice despite the added word.

Rule

A comma alone is never enough to join two independent clauses, even when a repeated subject or extra word follows it — a genuine coordinating conjunction must be present.

Tip

After a comma joining two clauses, check specifically for one of the seven FANBOYS words. If the added word isn't one of them, the splice isn't actually fixed.

Trap

Choice D can look like it's adding something meaningful with "it also," but neither word is a coordinating conjunction, so the comma splice remains.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, and	Choice A is the best answer. correctly pairs a comma with the coordinating conjunction "and."
✗ B	,	Choice B is incorrect — creates a comma splice between two independent clauses.
✗ C	(no punctuation)	Choice C is incorrect — provides no punctuation at all, creating a run-on.
✗ D	, it also	Choice D is incorrect — adds "it also" after a comma, neither of which is a coordinating conjunction, leaving the splice unfixed.

Question 5

Medium

_____ the bridge remains under repair, drivers should expect delays of up to twenty minutes through next month.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Because
- B. It is because
- C. The bridge, because
- D. Being because

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Subordinating the first clause with "Because" turns it into a dependent clause, correctly attached to the independent clause that follows by a single comma.
- This is one of the four standard fixes for what would otherwise be a run-on: turning one of the two clauses into a dependent clause.
- Choices B, C, and D each insert extra, ungrammatical words that break the clean subordinate-clause structure the sentence needs.

Rule

Subordinating one clause — attaching a word like "because," "although," or "since" to its front — is a complete, standard fix for what would otherwise be two independent clauses run together.

Tip

When none of the punctuation-only fixes (period, semicolon, comma+FANBOYS) are offered, check whether a single subordinating word placed at the very start does the job instead.

Trap

Choice B adds "It is" before "because," which sounds like it's adding useful context but instead creates an ungrammatical, dangling opening.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Because	Choice A is the best answer. correctly subordinates the first clause with "Because," attaching it cleanly to the independent clause that follows.
✗ B	It is because	Choice B is incorrect — adds "It is" before "because," creating an ungrammatical opening with no clear grammatical role.
✗ C	The bridge, because	Choice C is incorrect — inserts "The bridge," creating a redundant, ungrammatical double subject with the sentence's own later reference to "the bridge."
✗ D	Being because	Choice D is incorrect — uses "Being because," a nonstandard, ungrammatical construction.

Question 6

Hard

The evidence was compelling_____ the jury still hesitated to convict without physical proof.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ; yet

B. , yet

C. , yet,

D. yet

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Yet" is one of the seven FANBOYS coordinating conjunctions, so it pairs with a comma, not a semicolon, when joining two independent clauses.
- Choice A mixes a semicolon with a coordinating conjunction, a nonstandard combination — semicolons pair with conjunctive adverbs like "however," not with FANBOYS words.
- Choice B correctly and simply joins the two independent clauses with a comma plus "yet."

Rule

"Yet" is a coordinating conjunction, not a conjunctive adverb — treat it exactly like "but": comma before it, never a semicolon.

Tip

Before pairing any connecting word with a semicolon, confirm it isn't secretly one of the seven FANBOYS words — a common trap swaps in a semicolon out of habit.

Trap

Because "yet" can function as a synonym for "however" in meaning, it's tempting to punctuate it the same way as "however" — with a semicolon — but grammatically the two behave differently.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	; yet	Choice A is incorrect — mixes a semicolon with the coordinating conjunction "yet," a nonstandard combination.
✓ B	, yet	Choice B is the best answer. correctly pairs the coordinating conjunction "yet" with a comma.
X C	, yet,	Choice C is incorrect — adds an illogical extra comma directly after "yet."
X D	yet	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma before the coordinating conjunction "yet," creating a run-on.

Question 7

Hard

The negotiations stalled for nearly seven weeks_____ both sides quietly agreed to bring in an outside mediator.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ; finally,

B. , finally,

C. . finally,

D. , finally

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Finally" functions here as a transitional word opening the second independent clause, following the same pattern as "however" or "therefore."
- A transitional word opening an independent clause takes a semicolon before it and a comma directly after it.
- Choice B uses only a comma before "finally," creating a comma splice between the two independent clauses.

Rule

A transitional word like "finally," "meanwhile," or "instead" opening the second of two independent clauses takes a semicolon before it and a comma after it — the same pattern as "however."

Tip

Treat any transitional adverb opening an independent clause the same way, regardless of which specific word it is: semicolon before, comma after.

Trap

Choice D correctly uses a comma after "finally" but incorrectly uses only a comma — not a semicolon — before it, leaving a splice.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	; finally,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a semicolon before "finally" and a comma after it.
✗ B	, finally,	Choice B is incorrect — uses only a comma before "finally," creating a comma splice.
✗ C	. finally,	Choice C is incorrect — leaves "finally" uncapitalized after what would be sentence-ending punctuation, and still lacks a semicolon in the correct position.
✗ D	, finally	Choice D is incorrect — correctly places a comma after "finally" but incorrectly uses only a comma, not a semicolon, before it.

Question 8

Hard

The city's population has grown rapidly over the past decade_____ investment in public infrastructure has not kept pace with that growth.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , but

B. , however

C. ; but

D. but

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both clauses are independent, so a comma plus the coordinating conjunction "but" correctly joins them.
- "However" is a conjunctive adverb, not a FANBOYS conjunction, so it cannot follow a plain comma between two independent clauses.
- Mixing a semicolon with "but," as in Choice C, is a nonstandard combination, since "but" already pairs correctly with a comma.

Rule

The length or internal complexity of the two clauses being joined doesn't change the underlying rule: FANBOYS conjunctions pair with commas, and conjunctive adverbs pair with semicolons.

Tip

In a long, detail-heavy sentence, isolate just the connecting word and ask whether it's one of the seven FANBOYS conjunctions before choosing its punctuation.

Trap

The sentence's length and formal register can make the semicolon in Choice C feel more "appropriate," but "but" is still a coordinating conjunction that pairs with a comma.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, but	Choice A is the best answer. correctly pairs the coordinating conjunction "but" with a comma.
✗ B	, however	Choice B is incorrect — pairs "however" with a comma, but "however" requires a semicolon before it instead.
✗ C	; but	Choice C is incorrect — mixes a semicolon with the coordinating conjunction "but," a nonstandard combination.
✗ D	but	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma before the coordinating conjunction "but," creating a run-on.

Quick Review — Run-Ons & Comma Splices

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Run-Ons & Splices	Look for zero or one punctuation mark only.	A comma that sounds natural but splices two sentences.

SECTION 8 • PART 2 — SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Fragments

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Fragments

A fragment is a group of words punctuated as a sentence but missing an independent clause — usually a subject, a main verb, or both.

How to Approach Fragments Questions

Step 1: Check the clause in question for two things only: a subject, and a finite main verb — not a participle, not an infinitive.

Step 2: If either is missing, or if a subordinating word makes the clause dependent, it's a fragment — no matter how meaningful or complete the idea sounds.

Step 3: Fix a fragment either by connecting it to the neighboring independent clause or by supplying the missing subject/verb.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Participial Phrases (-ing / -ed) Are Never Complete Sentences Alone

A phrase that opens with an -ing or -ed word describes an action but has no finite verb of its own — it must attach to an independent clause.

✗ Incorrect: *The researchers publishing their findings after years of study.* — "publishing" is a participle, not a finite verb.

✓ Correct: *The researchers published their findings after years of study.*

Prepositional Phrases Have No Subject or Verb

A phrase beginning with despite, because of, from, with, or another preposition can be long and detailed but never contains its own subject-verb pair, so it can never stand alone.

✗ Incorrect: *Despite the setback in early trials.*

✓ Correct: *Despite the setback in early trials, the team pressed on.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

That / Which / Who Clauses Depend on the Noun They Describe

A relative clause beginning with *that*, *which*, or *who* cannot be punctuated as its own sentence — it needs the noun it modifies attached directly to it.

✗ **Incorrect:** *A discovery that changed the field of astronomy forever.*

✓ **Correct:** *The telescope's discovery changed the field of astronomy forever.*

A Fragment Can Sound Like a Complete, Meaningful Thought

Meaning alone never makes a sentence grammatically complete — the only test that matters is whether a subject and a finite main verb are both present.

✗ **Incorrect:** *A decision that surprised even the company's own board of directors. (feels complete, but has no independent subject-verb pair)*

✓ **Correct:** *The decision surprised even the company's own board of directors.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- A participial phrase mistaken for a verb because it describes an action.
- A long, detail-rich prepositional phrase that feels "complete" simply because it's specific.
- A relative clause split off from the noun it needs to modify, leaving both halves broken.

Rule: Before trusting a period, check for both a subject and a main verb in what comes before it — meaning alone does not make a sentence complete.

Three Ways to Fix a Fragment

METHOD	EXAMPLE
1. Attach to main clause	Because the results were unclear, → Because the results were unclear, the team repeated the trial.
2. Replace participle with conjugated verb	Discovering new data → The researchers discovered new data.
3. Add missing subject/verb	A major breakthrough in genetics. → A major breakthrough in genetics transformed the field.

 SAT TIP

STRIP TEST: Remove all -ing phrases and 'who/which' clauses. Subject + conjugated verb remaining? If no → FRAGMENT.

Sentences built entirely of -ing forms with no helping verb are always fragments.

Relative clauses ('which', 'who', 'that') CANNOT stand alone — always a fragment.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Fragments — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

Running nearly twenty minutes late for the client meeting_____ she skipped breakfast entirely and left without her notes.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ;

D. and

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Running nearly twenty minutes late for the client meeting" is a participial phrase, not an independent clause — it has no finite main verb of its own.
- A comma correctly attaches this introductory participial phrase to the independent clause that follows.
- A period, as in Choice B, would strand the phrase as a sentence fragment.

Rule

An opening participial phrase (built on an -ing or -ed word) is never an independent clause and must be attached to the main clause with a comma, not set off with a period.

Tip

Check the very first word after the blank's opening phrase. If it's an -ing or -ed word functioning as a participle rather than a finite verb, the phrase can't stand alone.

Trap

The phrase is detailed and specific enough to feel like a complete thought on its own, but detail and specificity never substitute for a finite verb.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the introductory participial phrase to the main clause with a comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — strands the participial phrase as a sentence fragment.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which requires an independent clause on both sides — the opening phrase isn't one.
✗ D	and	Choice D is incorrect — adds "and," which would require the phrase to be an independent clause — it isn't.

Question 2

Easy

_____ *the team pressed on with the launch as originally scheduled.*

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** Despite the setback in early trials,
- B.** Despite the setback in early trials.
- C.** Despite the setback in early trials
- D.** Despite of the setback in early trials,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Despite the setback in early trials" is a prepositional phrase with no subject or verb of its own, so it cannot stand alone.
- As an introductory phrase, it must be followed by a single comma before the main clause begins.
- "Despite of" in Choice D is a nonstandard, ungrammatical form — the correct preposition is simply "despite."

Rule

A prepositional phrase, however long or detailed, has no subject or verb and can never stand alone — as an introductory phrase, it needs a comma before the main clause, never a period.

Tip

Prepositional phrases open with words like despite, because of, from, or with. Whenever you spot one starting a sentence, expect a single comma at its end, not a period.

Trap

Choice B punctuates the phrase as its own sentence, which can look acceptable if you don't check for a subject and verb, since "Despite the setback in early trials" reads smoothly on its own.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Despite the setback in early trials,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the introductory prepositional phrase to the main clause with a single comma.
✗ B	Despite the setback in early trials.	Choice B is incorrect — strands the prepositional phrase as a sentence fragment.
✗ C	Despite the setback in early trials	Choice C is incorrect — drops the required comma between the introductory phrase and the main clause.
✗ D	Despite of the setback in early trials,	Choice D is incorrect — uses the nonstandard "despite of" instead of the correct "despite."

Question 3

Medium

The company launched a new product line_____ designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , one

B. . One

C. , one,

D. one

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "One designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses" is a nonessential phrase describing "product line," built around the participle "designed," not a finite verb.
- A comma correctly attaches this appositive-style phrase to the main clause.
- Choice B punctuates it as its own sentence, but "One designed specifically for..." has no finite main verb and cannot stand alone.

Rule

A phrase that renames or describes a noun using a participle (here, "designed") stays attached to that noun with a comma — it has no finite verb and cannot be punctuated as its own sentence.

Tip

If a phrase after a comma starts with a pronoun like "one" followed by a past participle, check whether a true finite verb exists anywhere in it before treating it as a complete sentence.

Trap

"One designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses" contains enough specific, meaningful detail that it's easy to mistake for a complete sentence.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, one	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the nonessential descriptive phrase to the main clause with a comma.
✗ B	. One	Choice B is incorrect — strands the phrase as a sentence fragment, since "designed" is a participle, not a finite verb.
✗ C	, one,	Choice C is incorrect — adds an illogical second comma after "one," splitting the phrase from its own participle.
✗ D	one	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma, fusing the phrase directly onto "product line" with no clear boundary.

Question 4

Medium

The senator proposed a sweeping new bill_____ expand access to rural healthcare across three underserved counties.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , one that would

B. . One that would

C. , one that. Would

D. one that would

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "One that would expand access to rural healthcare" is a nonessential phrase describing "bill," and it depends on "one" for its meaning.
- A comma correctly attaches this phrase to the main clause.
- Choice B strands the phrase as a fragment, since "That would expand access..." is a dependent clause relying on "one" and cannot stand alone once separated from it.

Rule

A "that" clause depends on the noun or pronoun it modifies (here, "one") and cannot be split away from it with a period.

Tip

Trace any "that," "which," or "who" clause back to the specific word it describes. If a period would separate the two, the clause becomes a fragment.

Trap

Choice C inserts an illegal period in the middle of the phrase itself, which is easy to miss since the surrounding words still read smoothly.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, one that would	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the nonessential descriptive phrase to the main clause with a comma.
✗ B	. One that would	Choice B is incorrect — strands the phrase as a fragment, disconnecting "that would expand..." from the "one" it depends on.
✗ C	, one that. Would	Choice C is incorrect — inserts an illegal period in the middle of the phrase, breaking "that" from its own verb.
✗ D	one that would	Choice D is incorrect — drops the required comma, fusing the phrase directly onto "bill" with no clear boundary.

Question 5

Medium

The museum's collection spans centuries of human creativity_____ from ancient pottery to contemporary sculpture.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ;

D. , and,

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "From ancient pottery to contemporary sculpture" is a prepositional phrase with no subject or verb of its own.
- A comma correctly attaches this trailing phrase to the independent clause before it.
- A period, as in Choice B, would strand the phrase as a fragment at the end of the sentence.

Rule

A trailing prepositional phrase at the end of a sentence needs a comma to stay attached to the main clause — never a period, which would leave it stranded with no subject or verb.

Tip

Read any phrase after a proposed period on its own. If it has no subject and verb, whatever comes before that break needs a comma instead.

Trap

Because the main clause before the blank is already a complete, satisfying sentence on its own, a period there can feel like the natural place to stop.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the trailing prepositional phrase with a comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — strands the prepositional phrase as a fragment with no subject or verb.
✗ C	;	Choice C is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which requires an independent clause on both sides — the trailing phrase isn't one.
✗ D	, and,	Choice D is incorrect — adds an illogical extra comma around "and."

Question 6

Hard

Years of painstaking archival research went into confirming the wreck's identity_____ a project that ultimately took the historical society nearly a decade to complete.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. ; which was

D. , which was,

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "A project that ultimately took the historical society nearly a decade to complete" is a nonessential appositive describing the entire preceding action.
- A single comma at the end of the sentence correctly attaches this appositive.
- A period, as in Choice B, would strand it as a fragment, since "a project that..." has no independent subject-verb structure standing entirely on its own.

Rule

A nonessential appositive at the very end of a sentence needs only a single comma before it — even when it's long and detailed enough to feel like its own complete thought.

Tip

However meaningful or complete an ending phrase feels, check specifically for its own independent subject and finite verb before punctuating it as a separate sentence.

Trap

The phrase describes a genuinely dramatic, decade-long effort, which makes it feel emotionally weighty enough to deserve its own sentence — but grammar doesn't grant exceptions for emphasis.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the nonessential appositive with a single comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — strands the appositive as a sentence fragment.
✗ C	; which was	Choice C is incorrect — pairs a semicolon with "which was," but a semicolon requires an independent clause on both sides, and this phrase isn't one.
✗ D	, which was,	Choice D is incorrect — adds "which was" and a redundant second comma, an unnecessarily wordy and awkward construction.

Question 7

Hard

Determined to finish the seawall repairs before the next storm system arrived_____ the crew worked through the entire holiday weekend without complaint.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. .

C. and

D. ; and

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Determined to finish the seawall repairs before the next storm system arrived" is a participial phrase built on "Determined," not an independent clause.
- A comma correctly attaches this introductory phrase to the main clause that follows.
- A period, as in Choice B, would strand the phrase as a fragment, regardless of how purposeful and complete it sounds.

Rule

However purposeful or complete an opening participial phrase sounds, it is still not an independent clause and must be attached to the main clause with a comma, not a period.

Tip

Locate the phrase's one participle — here, "Determined" — and confirm there's no separate, finite verb anywhere else in the phrase before trusting it to stand alone.

Trap

"Determined to finish the seawall repairs before the next storm system arrived" sounds urgent and complete, which makes a period feel dramatically appropriate — but it's still missing a finite main verb.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the introductory participial phrase to the main clause with a comma.
✗ B	.	Choice B is incorrect — strands the participial phrase as a sentence fragment.
✗ C	and	Choice C is incorrect — adds "and" with no comma, which would require the phrase to be independent — it isn't.
✗ D	; and	Choice D is incorrect — uses a semicolon, which requires an independent clause on both sides — the opening phrase isn't one.

Question 8

Hard

The report highlights a growing concern_____ few companies are actually prepared to address in the next five years.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. that

B. . That

C. , that

D. that,

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "That few companies are actually prepared to address in the next five years" is a dependent clause completing "a growing concern" — it is essential to the sentence's meaning.
- This essential clause attaches directly, with no comma, to the noun it completes.
- A period, as in Choice B, would strand the clause as a fragment, since it depends entirely on "concern" to make sense.

Rule

A dependent clause that completes the meaning of a specific noun just before it must stay directly attached — no comma, and certainly no period, no matter how much the clause reads like its own complete sentence.

Tip

When a clause starting with "that" seems to have its own subject and verb, check whether it's still grammatically completing an earlier noun (like "concern") — if so, it can't be punctuated as independent.

Trap

"That few companies are actually prepared to address in the next five years" has its own subject ("few companies") and verb ("are"), which makes it easy to mistake for a genuinely independent clause.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	that	Choice A is the best answer. correctly attaches the essential completing clause directly, with no comma.
✗ B	. That	Choice B is incorrect — strands the clause as a fragment dependent on the noun "concern" from the previous sentence.
✗ C	, that	Choice C is incorrect — adds an unnecessary comma before this essential, directly-completing clause.
✗ D	that,	Choice D is incorrect — adds an illogical trailing comma with nothing to pair it with.

Quick Review — Fragments

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Fragments	Check for both a subject and a main verb.	A meaningful phrase mistaken for a sentence.

SECTION 9 • PART 2 — SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Logical Separation of Ideas

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Logical Separation of Ideas

Beyond punctuation, the SAT tests whether the connecting word between two ideas actually matches the logical relationship between them — cause/effect, contrast, addition, concession, condition, or time.

How to Approach Logical Separation of Ideas Questions

Step 1: Cover the connecting word and restate the relationship between the two ideas in your own plain words — result, opposite, added fact, or admission despite.

Step 2: Match that plain-language relationship to the correct category of connector — cause/effect, contrast, addition, or concession — before looking at what's offered.

Step 3: Confirm the connector's grammatical role fits too: a coordinating conjunction needs a comma before it when joining two independent clauses; a subordinating conjunction creates a dependent clause and is punctuated differently depending on its position.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Cause / Effect Connectors Signal a Direct Result

Words like so, therefore, thus, consequently, and as a result mean the second idea happened because of the first — there must be a genuine causal link, not just two facts placed near each other.

✓ **Correct:** *The bridge failed its inspection, so engineers closed it to traffic immediately.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The bridge failed its inspection, however engineers closed it to traffic immediately. — "however" signals contrast, but closing the bridge is the logical result of the failed inspection, not a contrast to it.*

Contrast Connectors Signal the Second Idea Works Against the First

But, however, yet, although, and nevertheless all signal that the second idea opposes, limits, or surprises the first — the two ideas move in different directions.

✓ **Correct:** *The forecast predicted rain, but the afternoon stayed completely dry.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The forecast predicted rain, so the afternoon stayed completely dry. — a dry afternoon does not logically result from a rainy forecast; this needs a contrast word.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Addition Connectors Stack Two Related, Same-Direction Facts

And, moreover, furthermore, and in addition simply add a second fact that points the same direction as the first, without any cause, contrast, or concession implied.

✓ **Correct:** *The policy reduced emissions, and it also lowered operating costs.*

Concession Connectors Admit One Thing While Asserting Another

Although, even though, and despite admit that something is true while the main clause goes on to assert a separate, sometimes surprising, point — both parts of the sentence remain true at once.

✓ **Correct:** *Although the trial was small, its results influenced national guidelines.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Because the trial was small, its results influenced national guidelines.* — "because" wrongly implies the trial's small size caused its influence, when the sentence actually means the influence happened in spite of the small size.

Common Traps to Watch For

- A connector that sounds sophisticated but signals the wrong relationship entirely (for example, "consequently" where the ideas actually contrast).
- Confusing concession (both things are true at once) with flat contrast (a direct opposition).
- A coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS) missing its required comma when joining two independent clauses.

Rule: Restate the relationship in your own words first — because of X, Y happened (cause/effect) or X, but Y (contrast) — then match the connector's actual meaning to that relationship, not just its grammar.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Logical Separation of Ideas — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The bridge failed its scheduled safety inspection_____ engineers closed it to all traffic within the hour.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , so

B. , however

C. , meanwhile

D. , although

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Closing the bridge is a direct result of it failing the safety inspection — a genuine cause-and-effect relationship.
- "So" correctly signals that the second event happened because of the first.
- "However" and "although" both signal contrast, which doesn't match a relationship where one event directly causes the next.

Rule

Before choosing a connector, restate the relationship in plain language — "because of X, Y happened" calls for a cause-and-effect word, not a contrast word.

Tip

Ask directly: did the second event happen because of the first? If yes, look for so, therefore, thus, or consequently before considering any contrast word.

Trap

"Meanwhile" can feel neutral enough to fit almost anywhere, but it specifically signals simultaneous timing, not a causal result — the bridge closure isn't simply coinciding with the failed inspection, it's caused by it.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, so	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals that the closure is a direct result of the failed inspection.
✗ B	, however	Choice B is incorrect — signals contrast, but closing the bridge doesn't oppose or contradict the failed inspection — it results from it.
✗ C	, meanwhile	Choice C is incorrect — signals simultaneous timing, not the causal relationship the sentence actually describes.
✗ D	, although	Choice D is incorrect — signals concession, which would require the closure to happen in spite of the failed inspection, not because of it.

Question 2

Easy

The forecast predicted steady rain throughout the weekend_____ the skies stayed completely clear for both days.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , but

B. , so

C. , and

D. , thus

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The actual clear skies directly oppose what the forecast predicted — a contrast relationship.
- "But" correctly signals that the second fact works against the first.
- "So" and "thus" both signal cause and effect, which would illogically suggest the forecast caused the clear skies.

Rule

When the second fact contradicts or works against an expectation set up by the first, use a contrast connector (but, however, yet) — never a cause-and-effect word.

Tip

Check whether the second half surprises or opposes the first half. If it does, a contrast connector is required, regardless of how confidently the first half was stated.

Trap

"And" can feel like a safe, neutral default when you're unsure, but here it would wrongly suggest the two facts simply add up together rather than opposing each other.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, but	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals that the clear skies contrast with the forecast's prediction of rain.
✗ B	, so	Choice B is incorrect — signals cause and effect, illogically suggesting the forecast caused the clear skies.
✗ C	, and	Choice C is incorrect — signals simple addition, which doesn't capture the direct contradiction between prediction and outcome.
✗ D	, thus	Choice D is incorrect — signals cause and effect, the same illogical relationship as Choice B.

Question 3

Medium

The new manufacturing process reduced material waste by nearly a third_____ it also cut average production time almost in half.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , and

B. , but

C. , so

D. , yet

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both facts — reduced waste and cut production time — are separate benefits of the same process, pointing in the same direction.
- "And" correctly signals that the second fact simply adds to the first, without contrast or causation.
- "So" would incorrectly suggest that reducing waste directly caused the drop in production time, rather than the two being independent benefits.

Rule

When two facts are simply stacked together as separate, same-direction points, use an addition connector (and, moreover, in addition) rather than a cause-and-effect or contrast word.

Tip

Ask whether the second fact is caused by the first, opposes it, or is simply an additional, related point. Only the third case calls for a plain addition connector.

Trap

"So" is tempting because both improvements plausibly came from the same new process, but that shared origin doesn't mean one improvement directly caused the other.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, and	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals that the second benefit simply adds to the first.
✗ B	, but	Choice B is incorrect — signals contrast, but the two facts don't oppose each other — they're both benefits of the same process.
✗ C	, so	Choice C is incorrect — signals cause and effect, illogically suggesting the waste reduction caused the faster production time.
✗ D	, yet	Choice D is incorrect — signals contrast, the same illogical relationship as Choice B.

Question 4

Medium

_____ the pilot program involved only a small number of participating schools, its results shaped statewide policy for the next decade.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. Although

B. Because

C. So that

D. Since

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence admits that the program was small while asserting that its influence was large — both things are true at once.
- "Although" correctly signals this kind of concession: acknowledging one fact while asserting a separate, sometimes surprising, point.
- "Because" and "since" would both illogically claim that the program's small size caused its large influence, reversing the sentence's actual meaning.

Rule

A concession connector (although, even though, despite) admits one fact while asserting another, without claiming the first caused the second.

Tip

Check whether the sentence is saying "X caused Y" or "X is true, but Y is also true, surprisingly." Only the second pattern calls for a concession word like "although."

Trap

"Since" often just means "because" on the exam, and it's easy to read past that meaning shift when the sentence is otherwise fluent and reasonable-sounding.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Although	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals a concession — the program was small, yet still highly influential.
✗ B	Because	Choice B is incorrect — illogically claims the program's small size caused its large statewide influence.
✗ C	So that	Choice C is incorrect — signals purpose ("in order that"), which doesn't fit this sentence's structure or meaning at all.
✗ D	Since	Choice D is incorrect — functions as "because" here, making the same illogical causal claim as Choice B.

Question 5

Medium

The city council raised the minimum parking fee downtown_____ traffic congestion during peak hours barely changed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , yet

B. , so

C. , and

D. , because

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Raising the fee was likely intended to reduce congestion, but congestion "barely changed" — the outcome contrasts with the expected result.
- "Yet" correctly signals this surprising contrast between the policy and its outcome.
- "So" would incorrectly claim that raising the fee caused congestion to stay the same, which reverses the sentence's implied logic.

Rule

When an outcome defies what a stated action would normally be expected to produce, use a contrast connector — even when no explicit expectation is stated outright.

Tip

Ask what result the first action would normally be expected to produce, then check whether the second half actually delivers that expected result or defies it.

Trap

Because both events are simply reported as facts with no obvious internal contradiction stated outright, "and" can feel like a safe, neutral option — but the implied cause-and-effect expectation is still being defied.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, yet	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals that the unchanged congestion contrasts with what the fee increase would normally be expected to produce.
✗ B	, so	Choice B is incorrect — illogically claims the fee increase caused congestion to stay unchanged.
✗ C	, and	Choice C is incorrect — signals simple addition, missing the implied contrast between the policy's goal and its outcome.
✗ D	, because	Choice D is incorrect — signals cause and effect in the wrong direction, illogically making the unchanged congestion the reason for the fee increase.

Question 6

Hard

_____ the vaccine proved highly effective in the general population, researchers cautioned that immunocompromised patients might need an additional booster dose.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. While

B. So

C. And

D. Because

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence grants that the vaccine worked well overall while still noting an important exception for one subgroup — both things are true at once.
- "While" here functions as a concession connector, acknowledging the vaccine's general effectiveness before introducing a caveat.
- "Because" would illogically claim the vaccine's overall effectiveness is the reason researchers issued a caution about a different, specific group.

Rule

"While" can signal concession, not just simultaneous time — when it opens a clause that grants one point before a caveat or exception follows, it functions like "although."

Tip

If "while" is immediately followed by a caveat, exception, or "but"-like turn later in the sentence, it's very likely functioning as a concession word, not a simple time marker.

Trap

"So" and "because" both try to build a causal bridge between the vaccine's effectiveness and the caution for immunocompromised patients, but the actual relationship is a granted point followed by an exception, not a cause and its effect.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	While	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals a concession — the vaccine worked well overall, with an important exception noted.
✗ B	So	Choice B is incorrect — illogically claims the vaccine's general effectiveness directly caused the need for caution about a different group.
✗ C	And	Choice C is incorrect — signals simple addition, missing the granted-point-then-exception structure of the sentence.
✗ D	Because	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same illogical causal claim as Choice B.

Question 7

Hard

Regulators found no evidence of intentional wrongdoing at the firm_____ the investigation was closed without any formal charges being filed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , so

B. , but

C. , or

D. , nor

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- Closing the investigation without charges is a direct result of finding no evidence of wrongdoing.
- "So" correctly signals this cause-and-effect relationship between the finding and the outcome.
- "But" would incorrectly suggest the outcome contradicts the finding, when in fact the outcome follows logically from it.

Rule

When the second clause states the direct, logical consequence of the first, a cause-and-effect connector is correct — even when the first clause describes an absence of something, like a lack of evidence.

Tip

Restate the relationship in your own words: "because regulators found no evidence, the investigation was closed" — if that restatement makes sense, a cause-and-effect connector is what's needed.

Trap

"Nor" can feel grammatically plausible after a negative statement ("no evidence...nor was it filed"), but it would require the second clause to also be phrased negatively, which it isn't.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, so	Choice A is the best answer. correctly signals that closing the investigation is a direct result of finding no evidence of wrongdoing.
✗ B	, but	Choice B is incorrect — signals contrast, but the outcome doesn't oppose the finding — it follows logically from it.
✗ C	, or	Choice C is incorrect — signals an alternative, which doesn't fit two clauses that are directly, causally related.
✗ D	, nor	Choice D is incorrect — requires a second negative clause construction that doesn't match the sentence's actual phrasing.

Question 8

Hard

_____ the small nonprofit operated on a fraction of its rivals' budgets, it delivered measurably better outcomes for the families it served.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** Even though
- B.** Because
- C.** Consequently,
- D.** As a result,

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence admits that the nonprofit had a much smaller budget while asserting that it still achieved better outcomes — a classic concession structure.
- "Even though" correctly opens a dependent clause that concedes one point before the main clause asserts a separate, more surprising one.
- "Consequently" and "as a result" are conjunctive adverbs that typically open independent clauses and don't fit as subordinators attaching a dependent clause with a comma this way — and both would illogically claim the small budget caused the better outcomes.

Rule

A concession subordinator like "even though" opens a dependent clause that grants one fact before the main clause asserts a separate, often contrasting, point — cause-and-effect connectors cannot substitute for it, even when they seem to fit the sentence's rhythm.

Tip

Check whether the connecting word needs to attach a dependent clause to an independent one (a subordinator) or instead needs to open its own independent clause (a conjunctive adverb) — the two categories aren't interchangeable, regardless of meaning.

Trap

"Consequently" and "as a result" both sound thoughtful and formal in this position, which can distract from the fact that neither correctly functions as a comma-attached subordinator here, and both reverse the sentence's actual logic besides.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Even though	Choice A is the best answer. correctly opens a concession clause, granting the small budget before asserting the better outcomes.
✗ B	Because	Choice B is incorrect — illogically claims the small budget caused the better outcomes.
✗ C	Consequently,	Choice C is incorrect — is a conjunctive adverb that doesn't function as a comma-attached subordinator here, and illogically implies causation besides.
✗ D	As a result,	Choice D is incorrect — has the same structural and logical problems as Choice C.

Quick Review — Logical Separation of Ideas

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Logical Separation	Restate the relationship in your own words.	A connector that fits grammatically but not logically.

SECTION 10 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Parts of Speech

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Parts of Speech

Many Standard English Conventions questions boil down to recognizing which part of speech a blank requires — and pairing certain words with their one correct, fixed preposition.

How to Approach Parts of Speech Questions

Step 1: Identify exactly what word the blank is modifying or acting as — a noun, a verb, an adjective, or another adverb — before considering which form "sounds" right.

Step 2: If the blank follows a linking verb (is, seems, appears, becomes, feels), test whether it's describing the subject (adjective) rather than the action (adverb).

Step 3: If the word pairs with a specific preposition, recall the one fixed, idiomatic combination — these must be memorized, not reasoned out.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Adjectives Modify Nouns and Pronouns; Adverbs Modify Everything Else

An adjective describes a noun or pronoun directly; an adverb describes a verb, an adjective, or another adverb — usually, though not always, ending in -ly.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The engineer gave a careful explanation. (adjective describing the noun "explanation")*
- ✓ **Correct:** *The engineer explained the results carefully. (adverb describing the verb "explained")*
- ✗ **Incorrect:** *The engineer explained the results careful. — an adjective cannot modify a verb.*

After a Linking Verb, Use an Adjective; After an Action Verb, Use an Adverb

Verbs like is, seems, appears, becomes, and feels link the subject to a description of the subject itself, so they take an adjective — not an adverb describing how the verb "happens."

- ✓ **Correct:** *The proposal seemed reasonable. (adjective describing "the proposal")*
- ✗ **Incorrect:** *The proposal seemed reasonably. — "reasonably" wrongly describes the act of seeming rather than the proposal itself.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Certain Words Take One Fixed, Memorized Preposition

Many adjectives and verbs pair with exactly one correct preposition by convention, not by logic — these idiomatic pairings must simply be known.

✓ **Correct:** *The manager is responsible for the entire budget.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The manager is responsible of the entire budget.* — "responsible" pairs only with "for."

✓ **Correct:** *The results are consistent with earlier studies.* (also: interested in, capable of, different from)

Every Item in a Parallel List Must Share the Same Part of Speech

When a sentence lists several qualities or actions, every item must match the grammatical form set by the first item — nouns with nouns, adjectives with adjectives, gerunds with gerunds.

✓ **Correct:** *The candidate was praised for her honesty, diligence, and creativity.* (three nouns)

✗ **Incorrect:** *The candidate was praised for her honesty, diligent, and creativity.* — "diligent" breaks the noun pattern set by "honesty."

Common Traps to Watch For

- An adjective placed after a linking verb where an adverb is wrongly expected, or vice versa.
- A common but incorrect preposition swapped in for a fixed idiomatic pairing.
- One item in an otherwise-parallel list quietly switching part of speech.

Rule: Ask what the missing word is modifying before choosing its form — a verb needs an adverb, a noun needs an adjective, and idiomatic prepositions must simply be memorized.

Irregular in form (adjective → adverb doesn't follow -ly rule)

good → **well** (not "goodly")

Same form as the adjective (no change)

fast → **fast** (not "fastly")

hard → **hard** (not "hardly" — note "hardly" exists but means "barely," a different meaning entirely)

- fast, hard, late, early, high, low, deep, near, straight, right, wrong, close, tight, loud, quick (informally), long

Examples:

"She runs *fast*." (not "fastly")

"He works *hard*." (not "hardly")

"The plane flew *high*."

"Speak *loud* and *clear*." (informal; "loudly" is the strict form)

Adverbs that change meaning entirely with -ly

Some words have both a flat adverb form and an -ly form — but they mean different things:

Same form as the adjective (no change) (cont.)

hard (with effort) vs. **hardly** (barely)

late (not on time) vs. **lately** (recently)

near (close) vs. **nearly** (almost)

close (nearby) vs. **closely** (carefully/attentively)

high (elevation) vs. **highly** (very much, figuratively)

deep (physical depth) vs. **deeply** (emotionally/intensely)

WORKED QUESTIONS

Parts of Speech — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The engineer_____ explained the unexpected test results to the visibly frustrated clients.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. carefully

B. careful

C. care

D. more careful

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The blank modifies the verb "explained" — describing how the engineer explained the results.
- A word modifying a verb needs the adverb form, which typically ends in -ly.
- "Careful" and "care" are an adjective and a noun, neither of which can modify a verb.

Rule

A word that modifies a verb — describing how an action was performed — must be an adverb, not an adjective or a noun.

Tip

Identify exactly what word the blank is describing. If it's the verb itself (the action), an adverb is required.

Trap

Choice B, the adjective "careful," can feel natural right after a noun-heavy subject like "the engineer," but it's actually modifying the verb "explained," not the engineer directly.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	carefully	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the adverb "carefully" to describe how the engineer explained the results.
✗ B	careful	Choice B is incorrect — uses the adjective "careful," which cannot modify the verb "explained."
✗ C	care	Choice C is incorrect — uses the noun "care," which has no grammatical role modifying a verb.
✗ D	more careful	Choice D is incorrect — uses a comparative adjective form, "more careful," which still cannot modify a verb.

Question 2

Easy

After the surgery, the patient's recovery seemed_____ than doctors had initially expected.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** more rapid
- B.** more rapidly

- C.** rapidly
- D.** rapider

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Seemed" is a linking verb connecting the subject "recovery" to a description of the recovery itself.
- After a linking verb, an adjective is required, not an adverb — here, describing the recovery as rapid.
- Because exactly two things are being compared — the actual recovery and what was expected — the comparative form "more rapid" is correct.

Rule

After a linking verb like "seemed," use an adjective to describe the subject, not an adverb describing the verb itself.

Tip

Linking verbs — is, seems, appears, becomes, feels — connect a subject to a description of that subject. Test by substituting "was": "the recovery was rapid" confirms the adjective is correct.

Trap

Choice B, "more rapidly," is easy to select because "rapidly" so often follows an action verb, but "seemed" is a linking verb here, not an action verb.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	more rapid	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the comparative adjective "more rapid" after the linking verb "seemed."
✗ B	more rapidly	Choice B is incorrect — uses the adverb form "more rapidly" after a linking verb, which requires an adjective instead.
✗ C	rapidly	Choice C is incorrect — uses the adverb "rapidly" with no comparative form, missing both requirements.
✗ D	rapider	Choice D is incorrect — uses the nonstandard "rapider" instead of the correct comparative form "more rapid."

Question 3

Medium

The results of the new clinical trial are entirely consistent_____ findings published in three earlier studies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. with

B. to

C. of

D. for

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Consistent" is idiomatically paired with the preposition "with," not any other preposition.
- This pairing is fixed by convention, not by logic, and must simply be known.
- "Consistent to," "consistent of," and "consistent for" are all nonstandard combinations.

Rule

Certain adjectives pair with exactly one correct, memorized preposition — "consistent with" is one of the most frequently tested examples.

Tip

When a sentence tests a word you recognize as needing a specific preposition, trust the memorized pairing over what merely sounds acceptable in the moment.

Trap

"Consistent to" can sound plausible if you're reasoning from a similar phrase like "true to," but the fixed idiom is specifically "consistent with."

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	with	Choice A is the best answer. correctly completes the fixed idiomatic pairing "consistent with."
✗ B	to	Choice B is incorrect — uses "to," which does not idiomatically pair with "consistent."
✗ C	of	Choice C is incorrect — uses "of," which does not idiomatically pair with "consistent."
✗ D	for	Choice D is incorrect — uses "for," which does not idiomatically pair with "consistent."

Question 4

Medium

As the youngest member of the negotiating team, she was surprisingly capable_____ handling even the most contentious disputes.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. of

B. in

C. for

D. with

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Capable" is idiomatically paired with the preposition "of," not any other preposition.
- This fixed pairing must simply be memorized, like "responsible for" or "interested in."
- "Capable in," "capable for," and "capable with" are all nonstandard combinations.

Rule

"Capable" always pairs with "of" — one of a small set of adjective-preposition pairings worth memorizing outright.

Tip

Build a short mental list of these fixed pairings — responsible for, capable of, interested in, consistent with, different from — since no logical rule predicts them.

Trap

"Capable in" can feel acceptable by analogy with phrases like "skilled in," but "capable" specifically requires "of."

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	of	Choice A is the best answer. correctly completes the fixed idiomatic pairing "capable of."
✗ B	in	Choice B is incorrect — uses "in," which does not idiomatically pair with "capable."
✗ C	for	Choice C is incorrect — uses "for," which does not idiomatically pair with "capable."
✗ D	with	Choice D is incorrect — uses "with," which does not idiomatically pair with "capable."

Question 5

Medium

Reviewers praised the novel for its vivid imagery, its emotional depth, and_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** its unexpectedly hopeful ending
- B.** an unexpectedly hopeful ending
- C.** ending that was unexpectedly hopeful
- D.** how unexpectedly hopeful the ending was

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The first two items in this list — "its vivid imagery" and "its emotional depth" — are both possessive noun phrases following the exact same pattern: "its" plus adjective plus noun.
- The third item must match that same grammatical pattern to remain parallel.
- Choices B, C, and D each break that established pattern, either dropping "its" or restructuring the phrase entirely.

Rule

Every item in a parallel list must match the exact grammatical pattern set by the first item — including small words like "its" if the first item includes one.

Tip

Isolate just the three list items and read them back to back. If one item's structure doesn't mirror the others word type for word type, it breaks parallelism.

Trap

Choice B, "an unexpectedly hopeful ending," is grammatically fine on its own, but it swaps "its" for "an," breaking the pattern the first two items already established.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	its unexpectedly hopeful ending	Choice A is the best answer. correctly matches the "its + adjective + noun" pattern set by the first two list items.
✗ B	an unexpectedly hopeful ending	Choice B is incorrect — swaps "its" for "an," breaking the pattern established by the first two items.
✗ C	ending that was unexpectedly hopeful	Choice C is incorrect — restructures the item into a full clause, breaking the noun-phrase pattern of the list.
✗ D	how unexpectedly hopeful the ending was	Choice D is incorrect — restructures the item into an indirect question, breaking the noun-phrase pattern of the list.

Question 6

Hard

The workshop taught participants to negotiate confidently, to listen actively, and_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** to compromise strategically
- B.** compromising strategically
- C.** strategic compromise
- D.** how to compromise strategically

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "To negotiate confidently" and "to listen actively" both use the infinitive form ("to" plus the base verb) plus an adverb.
- The third item must match this exact infinitive-plus-adverb pattern.
- Choice B switches to a gerund ("compromising"), and Choice C switches to a noun phrase, both breaking the established pattern.

Rule

A parallel list built on infinitives ("to" plus a base verb) must keep every item in that same infinitive form — a gerund or noun phrase breaks the pattern even if the meaning stays clear.

Tip

Check the very first word of each list item. If the pattern is "to + verb" for the first two, the third must start with "to" as well.

Trap

Choice B, "compromising strategically," reads smoothly and even sounds slightly more natural in isolation, which makes the broken parallelism easy to miss.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	to compromise strategically	Choice A is the best answer. correctly matches the infinitive-plus-adverb pattern set by "to negotiate confidently" and "to listen actively."
✗ B	compromising strategically	Choice B is incorrect — switches to a gerund ("compromising"), breaking the infinitive pattern.
✗ C	strategic compromise	Choice C is incorrect — switches to a noun phrase, breaking the infinitive pattern.
✗ D	how to compromise strategically	Choice D is incorrect — adds "how," restructuring the item as an indirect question rather than matching the infinitive pattern.

Question 7

Hard

The committee's decision was largely independent_____ pressure from outside political donors.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. of

B. from

C. than

D. to

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Independent" is idiomatically paired with the preposition "of," not "from."
- Even though "independent from" appears often in casual usage, the standard, tested idiom is "independent of."
- "Independent than" and "independent to" are both nonstandard and grammatically incorrect.

Rule

"Independent" pairs idiomatically with "of" — a pairing worth memorizing specifically, since the more commonly heard "independent from" is not the standard form tested here.

Tip

Be especially careful with idioms that have a common, casual alternative in everyday speech — the SAT tests the more formal, standard pairing.

Trap

"Independent from" sounds completely natural in everyday conversation, which makes it a particularly effective trap among these four choices.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	of	Choice A is the best answer. correctly completes the standard idiomatic pairing "independent of."
✗ B	from	Choice B is incorrect — uses the more casual "independent from," not the standard tested idiom.
✗ C	than	Choice C is incorrect — uses "than," which does not idiomatically pair with "independent."
✗ D	to	Choice D is incorrect — uses "to," which does not idiomatically pair with "independent."

Question 8

Hard

The safety board's findings were, frankly, more troubling_____ anyone on the engineering team had anticipated.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. than

B. then

C. that

D. as

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence is making a comparison — how troubling the findings were compared to what the team had anticipated.
- "Than" is the word used to introduce a comparison; "then" refers to time and has no role here.
- "That" and "as" do not correctly complete a comparative structure built on "more troubling."

Rule

"Than" introduces a comparison; "then" refers to time — the two are never interchangeable, despite their similar spelling and sound.

Tip

Whenever a comparative word like "more," "less," or an -er ending appears earlier in the sentence, expect "than," not "then," to follow later.

Trap

"Then" and "than" differ by a single letter and are pronounced similarly in casual speech, making this one of the most common confusable-word errors on the exam.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	than	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses "than" to introduce the comparison.
✗ B	then	Choice B is incorrect — uses "then," a time-related word with no comparative function here.
✗ C	that	Choice C is incorrect — uses "that," which does not correctly complete this comparative structure.
✗ D	as	Choice D is incorrect — uses "as," which does not correctly complete a comparison built on "more troubling."

Quick Review — Parts of Speech

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Parts of Speech	Ask what part of speech is being modified.	Idiomatic prepositions used interchangeably.

SECTION 11 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Verbs & Tenses

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Verbs & Tenses

Verb-tense questions test whether the timeline of events in a sentence is expressed correctly, plus the subjunctive mood for hypothetical and command constructions.

How to Approach Verbs & Tenses Questions

Step 1: Find the timeline signal in the sentence — a specific date, "by the time," "already," "since," or a comparison between two past events — before choosing a tense.

Step 2: For any "if" clause, check first whether the sentence describes a real condition or a hypothetical, contrary-to-fact one — the two follow completely different rules.

Step 3: For a command-style verb (recommend, insist, require, demand), check whether the subjunctive "that + base verb" pattern is being tested instead of ordinary tense.

The Complete English Tense System

TENSE	FORM	USE	EXAMPLE
Present Simple	Subject + base verb	Facts, habits, general truths	She studies every evening.
Present Continuous	am/is/are + -ing	Action happening now; near-future plan	She is studying at the library.
Present Perfect	have/has + past participle	Past with present relevance; unfinished time	She has studied French before.
Present Perfect Continuous	have/has been + -ing	Ongoing action from past to now; duration	She has been studying for 3 hours.
Past Simple	verb + -ed / irregular	Completed action at specific past time	She studied last night.
Past Continuous	was/were + -ing	Ongoing past action; background action	She was studying when I called.
Past Perfect	had + past participle	Earlier of two past actions	She had studied before the test.

The Complete English Tense System (cont.)

TENSE	FORM	USE	EXAMPLE
Past Perfect Continuous	had been + -ing	Duration before another past event	She had been studying for hours before the exam.
Future Simple	will + base verb	Predictions, promises, decisions	She will study tonight.
Future Continuous	will be + -ing	Ongoing action at a future time	She will be studying at 8 PM.
Future Perfect	will have + past participle	Completed before a future moment	She will have studied all chapters by Friday.
Future Perfect Continuous	will have been + -ing	Duration before a future moment	She will have been studying for 5 hours by then.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Future Perfect Signals a Deadline: "By [a Time]"

When a sentence names a future point in time by which something will be finished, the verb takes the future perfect form: will have + past participle.

✓ **Correct:** *By the time the conference begins, the committee will have finalized the schedule.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *By the time the conference begins, the committee will finalize the schedule.* — ordinary future tense doesn't capture that the action is completed before the deadline.

Hypothetical "If" Clauses Never Contain "Would"

In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, use the simple past (for a real hypothetical) or the past perfect (for a hypothetical about the past); "would" belongs only in the result clause that follows, never in the if-clause itself.

✓ **Correct:** *If the funding were approved, the project would launch next year.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *If the funding would be approved, the project would launch next year.* — "would" cannot appear in the if-clause.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Contrary-to-Fact "To Be" Uses "Were," Not "Was"

In a hypothetical if-clause describing something not actually true, the verb "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were" for every subject, including I, he, she, and it.

✓ **Correct:** *If the museum were open on Mondays, attendance would likely increase.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *If the museum was open on Mondays, attendance would likely increase.* — the hypothetical mood requires "were."

Command Subjunctive: Verb + "That" + Base Form, No -s, No Tense

After verbs like recommend, insist, demand, require, and suggest, the clause that follows "that" uses the plain base form of the verb — no -s, no past tense, and never "should."

✓ **Correct:** *The board recommended that the policy be reviewed annually.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The board recommended that the policy is reviewed annually.* — the subjunctive base form "be" is required, not "is."

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Past Perfect Marks Whichever of Two Past Events Happened First

When a sentence compares two events that both already happened, the earlier event takes the past perfect (had + past participle) to make the sequence clear.

✓ **Correct:** *By the time the inspectors arrived, the workers had already repaired the damage.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *By the time the inspectors arrived, the workers already repaired the damage.* — without the past perfect, it's unclear which event came first.

Active vs. Passive Voice

VOICE	RULE + EXAMPLE
ACTIVE (preferred by SAT)	Subject DOES the action. Clearer, more direct, more concise. The researchers conducted the experiment.
PASSIVE (limited use)	Subject RECEIVES the action (be + past participle). The experiment was conducted by the researchers. Use only when the doer is unknown or irrelevant.

If both active and passive are grammatically correct, the SAT almost always prefers the active option.

Infinitive (to + verb) vs. Gerund (-ing)

FORM	USE + KEY VERBS
INFINITIVE (to + verb)	Purpose, intention, future-oriented actions. Verbs that take only infinitive: want, need, plan, decide, hope, expect, refuse, agree, choose.
GERUND (-ing as noun)	General activities, ongoing actions. Verbs that take only gerund: enjoy, avoid, consider, finish, mind, practise, suggest, keep, risk.

MEANING-CHANGE PAIRS — These are tested on harder SAT questions!

- REMEMBER TO DO = remember before the action: Remember to lock the door. (Don't forget!)
- REMEMBER DOING = remember after the action: I remember locking the door. (I recall doing it.)
- STOP TO DO = pause one action to start another: He stopped to drink water. (He paused to drink.)
- STOP DOING = quit the activity: He stopped drinking soda. (He quit soda entirely.)
- TRY TO DO = attempt something difficult: She tried to solve the problem.
- TRY DOING = experiment with a method: She tried solving it a different way.

Infinitive (to + verb) vs. Gerund (-ing) (cont.)

SAT TIP

Command subjunctive: demand/insist/recommend + THAT + [base verb]. No -s, no tense, no 'should'.

Contrary-to-fact 'if': If + WERE (not was) for 'to be'. If + past perfect → would have.

NEVER put 'would' in the if-clause. If → past simple (real); if → past perfect (unreal past).

Active voice preferred. Passive only when doer is unknown or irrelevant.

Common Traps to Watch For

- "Would" slipped into the if-clause of a hypothetical instead of staying in the result clause.
- "Was" used where the contrary-to-fact subjunctive "were" is required.
- A command-subjunctive clause conjugated with ordinary present tense ("is," "has") instead of the bare base form.

Rule: Contrary-to-fact "if": use WERE (not was) for "to be," and never put "would" in the if-clause itself.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Verbs & Tenses — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

By the time the auditors arrive next month, the finance team_____ every discrepancy in the year-end report.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. will have resolved

B. will resolve

C. resolves

D. had resolved

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "By the time the auditors arrive next month" names a future deadline by which an action will already be complete.
- This calls for the future perfect tense: will have plus the past participle.
- Plain future tense ("will resolve") doesn't capture that the resolving is finished before the deadline, not happening at it.

Rule

A sentence naming a future deadline by which something will already be finished calls for the future perfect: will have + past participle.

Tip

Look for "by the time," "by [a future date]," or similar deadline phrases — they're the clearest signal that future perfect is being tested.

Trap

Choice D, "had resolved," uses the past perfect, which is tempting because it also signals "already completed" — but that tense is reserved for two events that both already happened in the past, not a future deadline.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	will have resolved	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the future perfect to show the resolving will be complete before the future deadline.
✗ B	will resolve	Choice B is incorrect — uses plain future tense, which doesn't capture that the action is completed before the stated deadline.
✗ C	resolves	Choice C is incorrect — uses present tense, which doesn't fit a future deadline at all.
✗ D	had resolved	Choice D is incorrect — uses past perfect, which is reserved for two already-past events, not a future deadline.

Question 2

Easy

If the city council_____ the new zoning proposal, construction would begin as early as next spring.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** approved
- B.** would approve
- C.** approves
- D.** will approve

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The result clause, "construction would begin," already uses "would," signaling a conditional structure.
- In this kind of conditional, the if-clause takes the simple past tense — "approved" — never "would" itself.
- "Would" belongs only in the result clause, not duplicated inside the if-clause as well.

Rule

In a conditional sentence whose result clause uses "would," the if-clause takes the simple past tense — "would" itself never appears inside the if-clause.

Tip

Once you spot "would" in one half of a conditional sentence, check the other half specifically for a second, incorrect "would."

Trap

Choice B repeats "would" in the if-clause, which can feel like it's simply maintaining the same conditional "tone" throughout the sentence — but that repetition is exactly the error being tested.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	approved	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the simple past tense in the if-clause, matching the "would" already in the result clause.
✗ B	would approve	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly repeats "would" inside the if-clause.
✗ C	approves	Choice C is incorrect — uses present tense, which doesn't match the conditional structure already set up by "would begin."
✗ D	will approve	Choice D is incorrect — uses future tense, which doesn't match the conditional structure already set up by "would begin."

Question 3

Medium

If the museum's east wing_____ open on Mondays, attendance would likely climb by double digits.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. were

B. was

C. is

D. will be

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The result clause, "attendance would likely climb," signals a contrary-to-fact hypothetical — the east wing is not, in reality, open on Mondays.
- In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, the verb "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were," regardless of the subject.
- "Was," the ordinary past tense form, is nonstandard in this specifically hypothetical construction.

Rule

In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were" for every subject — never "was," even with a singular subject like "the east wing."

Tip

When the result clause uses "would" to describe something that isn't actually true, check the if-clause specifically for "were" rather than "was."

Trap

Because "the east wing" is singular, "was" can feel like the naturally "matching" verb form — but the hypothetical mood overrides ordinary subject-verb agreement here.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	were	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the subjunctive "were" in this contrary-to-fact if-clause.
✗ B	was	Choice B is incorrect — uses the ordinary past tense "was," nonstandard in a contrary-to-fact if-clause.
✗ C	is	Choice C is incorrect — uses present tense, which doesn't fit the hypothetical, unreal condition being described.
✗ D	will be	Choice D is incorrect — uses future tense, which doesn't fit the hypothetical, unreal condition being described.

Question 4

Medium

The auditor recommended that the department's expense policy_____ reviewed at the start of every fiscal year.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. be

B. is

C. was

D. will be

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Recommended that" triggers the command subjunctive mood.
- In the command subjunctive, the verb after "that" takes the plain base form — here, "be" — regardless of the subject or the tense of the main verb.
- "Is," "was," and "will be" are all ordinary conjugated forms, none of which fit the subjunctive construction "recommended that" requires.

Rule

After verbs like recommend, insist, require, and suggest, the clause beginning with "that" uses the plain base form of the verb — no -s, no past tense, and no "will."

Tip

Whenever you see "recommended that," "insisted that," or "required that," expect the base form of the verb immediately after the subject in that clause.

Trap

"Is" can feel like the natural, grammatically "correct-sounding" choice, since "the policy is reviewed" sounds like ordinary present tense — but the subjunctive trigger changes what form is actually required.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	be	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the base form "be," as required by the command subjunctive after "recommended that."
✗ B	is	Choice B is incorrect — uses the ordinary present-tense form "is," not the subjunctive base form the sentence requires.
✗ C	was	Choice C is incorrect — uses the past-tense form "was," not the subjunctive base form the sentence requires.
✗ D	will be	Choice D is incorrect — uses "will be," not the subjunctive base form the sentence requires.

Question 5

Medium

By the time the inspectors finally arrived on site, the contractors_____ nearly all of the structural repairs.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** had already completed
- B.** already completed
- C.** have already completed
- D.** were already completing

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Two past events are being compared: the inspectors arriving, and the contractors completing repairs.
- Since the repairs were finished before the inspectors arrived, the earlier event takes the past perfect tense — had plus the past participle.
- Simple past ("already completed") doesn't make clear which of the two past events happened first.

Rule

When two events both already happened in the past, the one that happened first takes the past perfect tense to make that sequence clear.

Tip

Identify both past events in the sentence and determine which one truly happened first — that earlier event is the one that needs "had."

Trap

Choice B, plain simple past, isn't grammatically wrong on its own, but it fails to clearly establish that the repairs finished before — not simultaneously with — the inspectors' arrival.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	had already completed	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the past perfect to mark the repairs as complete before the inspectors' arrival.
✗ B	already completed	Choice B is incorrect — uses simple past, which doesn't clearly establish the sequence between the two past events.
✗ C	have already completed	Choice C is incorrect — uses present perfect, which doesn't fit two events that both occurred entirely in the past.
✗ D	were already completing	Choice D is incorrect — uses past continuous, which suggests the repairs were still ongoing rather than already finished.

Question 6

Hard

Long before the merger was finalized, executives at both companies_____ that cultural differences would complicate the transition.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** had already suspected
- B.** already suspected
- C.** have already suspected
- D.** were already suspecting

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Two past events are being compared: the executives' suspicion, and the merger being finalized.
- Since the suspicion existed before the merger was finalized, the earlier event — the suspecting — takes the past perfect tense.
- "Long before" reinforces that this suspicion predates the other past event by a significant stretch, strengthening the case for past perfect.

Rule

A phrase like "long before" signals that one past event significantly predates another — exactly the situation the past perfect tense is built to clarify.

Tip

Time-signal phrases like "long before," "by the time," and "already" are strong clues that a sentence is testing the sequence between two past events.

Trap

Because "was finalized" (the later event) is itself in the simple past, it's tempting to match that same simple past tense in the earlier event too, rather than marking it as happening even further back.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	had already suspected	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the past perfect to mark the executives' suspicion as predating the merger's finalization.
✗ B	already suspected	Choice B is incorrect — uses simple past, failing to distinguish which of the two past events happened first.
✗ C	have already suspected	Choice C is incorrect — uses present perfect, which doesn't fit two events that both occurred entirely in the past.
✗ D	were already suspecting	Choice D is incorrect — uses past continuous, which doesn't clearly establish that the suspicion existed before the merger was finalized.

Question 7

Hard

By the end of the fiscal year, the marketing team_____ its entire budget for the extensive rebranding campaign.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** will have spent
- B.** will spend

- C.** spends
- D.** spent

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "By the end of the fiscal year" names a future deadline by which the spending will already be complete.
- This calls for the future perfect tense, exactly as with any other "by [future time]" construction.
- Plain future tense ("will spend") describes an action happening at or after the deadline, not one already finished by it.

Rule

Any "by [a future point]" construction — whether "by the time," "by next month," or "by the end of the year" — calls for the future perfect tense.

Tip

Don't let the specific wording of the deadline phrase distract you — "by the end of," "by the time," and "by [a date]" all trigger the identical future perfect rule.

Trap

Choice D, "spent," the simple past, might seem tempting if you lose track of the fact that "by the end of the fiscal year" is a future deadline, not a past one.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	will have spent	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the future perfect to show the spending will be complete before the future deadline.
✗ B	will spend	Choice B is incorrect — uses plain future tense, which doesn't capture that the spending is completed before the deadline.
✗ C	spends	Choice C is incorrect — uses present tense, which doesn't fit a future deadline at all.
✗ D	spent	Choice D is incorrect — uses simple past tense, which incorrectly treats a future deadline as if it were already in the past.

Question 8

Hard

If the survey's sample size_____ larger, the results would carry substantially more statistical weight.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. were

B. would be

C. is

D. had been

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The result clause, "the results would carry more statistical weight," signals a contrary-to-fact hypothetical about the present.
- In this kind of hypothetical, the verb "to be" in the if-clause takes the subjunctive form "were."
- Choice D, "had been," is a past-hypothetical form that would require a matching "would have carried" in the result clause — a mismatch with the actual result clause given.

Rule

Match the if-clause's hypothetical tense to the result clause's tense exactly: "were" pairs with "would [base verb]," while "had been" pairs only with "would have [past participle]."

Tip

Once you identify a hypothetical sentence, check both halves together rather than in isolation — a form that would be correct on its own can still create a tense mismatch with the other half.

Trap

"Had been" is genuinely correct grammar for a hypothetical — just not this one; it belongs with a result clause reading "would have carried," not "would carry," which is easy to overlook in a longer sentence.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	were	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the subjunctive "were," matching the present-hypothetical result clause "would carry."
✗ B	would be	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly repeats "would" inside the if-clause.
✗ C	is	Choice C is incorrect — uses present tense, which doesn't fit the hypothetical, unreal condition being described.
✗ D	had been	Choice D is incorrect — uses the past-hypothetical "had been," which mismatches the present-hypothetical result clause "would carry."

Quick Review — Verbs & Tenses

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Verbs & Tenses	Find the timeline signal word.	“Would” placed in the if-clause.

SECTION 12 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Subject–Verb Agreement

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Subject-Verb Agreement

A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb. The SAT hides the real subject behind long phrases, clauses, and modifiers — the skill is finding it.

How to Approach Subject-Verb Agreement Questions

Step 1: Find the true subject of the verb in question by physically crossing out every prepositional phrase, appositive, and modifying clause between them.

Step 2: Decide whether that bare subject is singular or plural — watch especially for collective nouns, indefinite pronouns, and irregular plurals that don't follow the usual -s pattern.

Step 3: In an inverted sentence ("there is/are," or one that opens with a phrase before the subject), find the subject after the verb and match backward to it.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Cross Out Everything Between the Subject and the Verb

The SAT hides the real subject behind long prepositional phrases and modifying clauses — physically crossing them out (or covering them) reveals the true subject the verb must agree with.

✓ **Correct:** *The results of the three-year clinical trial were released this week. (subject: results, plural — cross out "of the three-year clinical trial")*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The results of the three-year clinical trial was released this week. — the verb wrongly agrees with the nearer singular noun "trial" instead of the true subject "results."*

Phrases Like "Along With" Never Change the Subject's Number

Along with, as well as, together with, and in addition to introduce extra information but do not make a subject plural — the verb still agrees with the original subject alone.

✓ **Correct:** *The director, along with three producers, is attending the premiere. (subject remains singular: "the director")*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The director, along with three producers, are attending the premiere.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Collective Nouns and Indefinite Pronouns Are Singular

Words like team, committee, jury, and company name a single unit and take a singular verb; indefinite pronouns like each, every, everyone, and neither are always singular too, regardless of how many individuals they describe.

✓ **Correct:** *The committee has reached a unanimous decision.*

✓ **Correct:** *Each of the applicants was interviewed twice.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Each of the applicants were interviewed twice.* — "each" is always singular, even though "applicants" is plural.

Certain Irregular Plurals Always Take Plural Verbs

Words like criteria, phenomena, data, media, and alumni are the plural forms of criterion, phenomenon, datum, medium, and alumnus, and they take plural verbs even though they don't end in -s.

✓ **Correct:** *The criteria for admission were revised last year.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The criteria for admission was revised last year.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

In "There Is/Are" Sentences, Match the Verb to the Subject After It

"There" is never the true subject — it's a placeholder. Find the actual subject following the verb and match the verb to that noun instead.

✓ **Correct:** *There are three reasons for the delay. (subject: reasons, plural)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *There is three reasons for the delay.*

INDEFINITE PRONOUNS: ALWAYS SINGULAR	each, every, everyone, everybody, anyone, nobody, someone, neither, either → always singular. 'Each of the students HAS a laptop.'
INDEFINITE PRONOUNS: ALWAYS PLURAL	few, many, several, both, others → plural. 'Several of the books ARE missing.'
COMPOUND WITH 'AND'	Two subjects joined by 'and' = plural. 'The cat AND the dog ARE sleeping.' EXCEPTION: 'Fish and chips IS tasty.' (one dish)
NEITHER...NOR / EITHER...OR	Verb agrees with the CLOSER subject. 'Neither the teacher NOR the STUDENTS ARE ready.'

Tricky Nouns to Memorize

SINGULAR FORM	PLURAL FORM	ALWAYS SINGULAR	ALWAYS PLURAL
criterion	criteria (= are)	advice	few
phenomenon	phenomena (= are)	news	many
datum	data (formal plural = are)	information	several
medium	media (= are)	furniture	both
alumnus	alumni (= are)	luggage	others
bacterium	bacteria (= are)	equipment	—
formula	formulae/formulas	physics/economics	—
—	—	measles / statistics (as field)	—

Tricky Nouns to Memorize (cont.)

THE NUMBER vs. A NUMBER

- 'THE number of students IS large.' (The number = singular — it refers to a specific count.)
- 'A number of students HAVE arrived.' (A number of = several — treats them as plural.)

Gerunds as Subjects

A gerund (-ing word) acting as a subject is always SINGULAR, even if it's followed by plural nouns.

✗ INCORRECT <i>Playing parlour games such as charades were popular in the 1900s.</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>Playing parlour games such as charades was popular in the 1900s.</i>
Why: 'Playing' is a gerund = singular subject → singular verb 'was'.	

Tricky Nouns to Memorize (cont.)

SAT TIP

TECHNIQUE: Cross out everything between the subject and verb. Match the verb to what remains.

'Each', 'every', 'neither', 'either' = ALWAYS singular, no matter what follows 'of'.

'Criteria', 'phenomena', 'data', 'media' are PLURAL — they take plural verbs.

Gerunds (-ing as subject) = singular. 'Studying grammar IS essential.'

Common Traps to Watch For

- A verb agreeing with the nearest noun in a long modifying phrase instead of the true subject.
- "Along with"/"as well as" phrases mistaken for compound subjects that make the verb plural.
- An indefinite pronoun (each, everyone, neither) paired with a plural verb because the surrounding noun is plural.

Rule: Cross out everything between the subject and verb, then match the verb to what remains — never to the nearest noun.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Subject-Verb Agreement — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The findings of the year-long clinical trial_____ still under review by an independent panel.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. are

B. is

C. was

D. have been being

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- Crossing out the intervening phrase "of the year-long clinical trial" reveals the true subject: "findings," which is plural.
- A plural subject takes the plural verb "are," not the singular "is" or "was."
- The intervening phrase's own singular-sounding noun, "trial," doesn't determine the verb — the true subject does.

Rule

Cross out any prepositional phrase sitting between the subject and the verb before checking agreement — the verb must match the true subject, never the nearest noun.

Tip

Physically cover or cross out "of the year-long clinical trial" and read the sentence as "the findings...are still under review" to hear the correct agreement clearly.

Trap

"Trial" sits immediately before the verb and is singular, tempting a singular verb — but "trial" is only part of a modifying phrase, not the subject.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	are	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the true plural subject, "findings."
✗ B	is	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly agrees with the nearby singular noun "trial" instead of the true subject "findings."
✗ C	was	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.
✗ D	have been being	Choice D is incorrect — uses an awkward, nonstandard verb construction that doesn't fit this sentence at all.

Question 2

Easy

The director, along with two senior producers,_____ scheduled to attend the premiere.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. is

B. are

C. were

D. have been

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Along with two senior producers" is an additive phrase, not a true compound subject joined by "and."
- Additive phrases like "along with," "as well as," and "together with" never change the subject's number.
- The true subject remains simply "the director," which is singular, so the verb must be singular too.

Rule

Additive phrases — along with, as well as, together with, in addition to — never make a subject plural, no matter how many additional people or things they name.

Tip

If the phrase joining two nouns is anything other than a plain "and," check carefully — most such phrases are additive, not true compounding, and leave the original subject's number unchanged.

Trap

"Two senior producers" makes the sentence feel like it's naming three people in total, which pulls toward a plural verb — but grammatically, only "the director" is the subject.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	is	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the true singular subject, "the director."
✗ B	are	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly treats the additive phrase as making the subject plural.
✗ C	were	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.
✗ D	have been	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B.

Question 3

Medium

Economics_____ widely regarded as one of the most rigorous social sciences taught at the university.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. is

B. are

C. have been

D. were

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Economics" ends in -s but names a single field of study, not multiple items.
- Like mathematics, physics, and athletics, this kind of noun is always grammatically singular, regardless of its plural-looking spelling.
- A plural verb here would incorrectly treat the field of study as if it were a collection of multiple things.

Rule

Some nouns end in -s but name a single subject, field, or activity — economics, mathematics, physics, athletics — and are always singular, taking a singular verb.

Tip

When a noun's -s ending tempts a plural verb, check whether the word actually names one unified field or activity rather than a countable group of separate items.

Trap

The -s at the end of "economics" looks exactly like a regular plural ending, making a plural verb feel automatic — but this category of noun doesn't follow that pattern.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	is	Choice A is the best answer. correctly treats "economics" as singular, matching it with "is."
✗ B	are	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly treats "economics" as plural because of its -s ending.
✗ C	have been	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B.
✗ D	were	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.

Question 4

Medium

The latest news from the negotiating table_____ cautiously optimistic, according to both delegations.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. is

B. are

C. were

D. have been

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "News" ends in -s but names a single, uncountable mass of information, not multiple separate items.
- "News" is always grammatically singular — never "the news are."
- The intervening phrase "from the negotiating table" doesn't change this; the subject remains "news," singular.

Rule

"News" is always singular, regardless of its -s ending — one of the clearest examples of a noun whose spelling misleadingly suggests a plural.

Tip

Memorize a short list of these always-singular nouns that look plural: news, mathematics, physics, economics, athletics — none of them ever take a plural verb.

Trap

Because "news" refers to potentially many individual pieces of information, it's tempting to treat it as a countable plural — but grammatically, it functions as one uncountable whole.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	is	Choice A is the best answer. correctly treats "news" as singular, matching it with "is."
✗ B	are	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly treats "news" as plural because of its -s ending.
✗ C	were	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.
✗ D	have been	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B.

Question 5

Medium

Neither of the two proposed budgets_____ enough funding for the new community health clinic.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. includes

B. include

C. have included

D. are including

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Neither" is an indefinite pronoun that is always grammatically singular, regardless of how many items it refers to.
- The phrase "of the two proposed budgets" is a modifying prepositional phrase, not the true subject.
- A singular verb, "includes," correctly matches the singular subject "neither."

Rule

Indefinite pronouns like each, every, either, and neither are always singular, no matter how many items follow them in a modifying phrase.

Tip

Whenever a sentence's subject is "each," "every," "either," or "neither," default to a singular verb immediately, regardless of what comes after it.

Trap

"The two proposed budgets" sits closer to the verb and is clearly plural, which tempts a plural verb — but "neither," not "budgets," is the sentence's true subject.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	includes	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the singular indefinite pronoun "neither."
✗ B	include	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly agrees with the nearby plural noun "budgets" instead of the true subject "neither."
✗ C	have included	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly in tense.
✗ D	are including	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B.

Question 6

Hard

The recommendations that the external consultants submitted after months of on-site interviews_____ still awaiting formal approval from the board.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. are

B. is

C. was

D. has been

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The true subject is "recommendations," plural — everything from "that" through "interviews" is a long intervening clause describing which recommendations are meant.
- Crossing out that entire intervening clause reveals "the recommendations...are still awaiting formal approval," which correctly agrees.
- The singular nouns embedded inside the intervening clause — "months," "interviews" — have no bearing on the verb's number.

Rule

An intervening clause between the subject and the verb can be far longer and more complex than a simple prepositional phrase, but the same rule applies: cross it out entirely before checking agreement.

Tip

In a long sentence, find the relative pronoun (that, which, who) marking the start of the intervening clause, then find where that clause ends, and mentally delete the whole span before checking the verb.

Trap

By the time a reader reaches the verb, several singular-sounding words — "months," "interviews" — have already appeared, making a singular verb feel like it's simply continuing the sentence's most recent "rhythm."

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	are	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the true plural subject, "recommendations," after the entire intervening clause is set aside.
✗ B	is	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly agrees with a nearby singular noun inside the intervening clause instead of the true subject.
✗ C	was	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.
✗ D	has been	Choice D is incorrect — uses a singular verb form that doesn't match the plural subject "recommendations" at all.

Question 7

Hard

The head coach, as well as the entire training staff,_____ confident that the new conditioning regimen will reduce injuries this season.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. is

B. are

C. have been

D. were

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "As well as the entire training staff" is an additive phrase, not a true compound subject joined by "and."
- As with "along with" and "together with," this phrase never changes the subject's number.
- The true subject remains "the head coach," singular, so the verb must be singular.

Rule

"As well as" behaves exactly like "along with" — it introduces additional information without changing the number of the sentence's true subject.

Tip

Treat every "along with / as well as / together with / in addition to" phrase identically: mentally bracket it off entirely and check agreement using only the subject before it.

Trap

"The entire training staff" suggests a large group of additional people, which makes a plural verb feel proportionate to how many people the sentence is actually describing — but grammatically, only the coach is the subject.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	is	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the true singular subject, "the head coach."
✗ B	are	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly treats the additive phrase as making the subject plural.
✗ C	have been	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B.
✗ D	were	Choice D is incorrect — makes the same number error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.

Question 8

Hard

There_____ still several unresolved questions about the long-term ecological impact of the proposed pipeline.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. are

B. is

C. was

D. has been

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "There" is a placeholder, not the sentence's true subject.
- The true subject, "several unresolved questions," appears after the verb and is plural.
- The verb must agree with that true subject, "questions," not with the placeholder "there."

Rule

In a "there is / there are" construction, find the true subject after the verb and match the verb to it — "there" itself never determines the verb's number.

Tip

Mentally reorder the sentence to place the subject first: "several unresolved questions...are still there" makes the required plural agreement obvious.

Trap

"There" sits immediately before the verb, which can make it feel like the subject the verb should agree with, even though it carries no number of its own.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	are	Choice A is the best answer. correctly agrees with the true plural subject, "several unresolved questions," which follows the verb.
✗ B	is	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly treats "there" as a singular subject rather than looking past it to "questions."
✗ C	was	Choice C is incorrect — makes the same error as Choice B, and also shifts incorrectly into past tense.
✗ D	has been	Choice D is incorrect — uses a singular verb form that doesn't match the plural subject "questions" at all.

Quick Review — Subject–Verb Agreement

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Subject–Verb Agreement	Cross out phrases between subject and verb.	Agreeing with the nearest noun, not the true subject.

SECTION 13 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Pronouns

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Pronouns

A pronoun must match its antecedent in number and must point clearly to exactly one possible noun — any ambiguity is treated as an error, even when context makes the intended meaning likely.

How to Approach Pronouns Questions

Step 1: Cover the pronoun and ask exactly what single noun it refers to — if more than one noun in the sentence could logically fit, the pronoun is ambiguous, even if the intended meaning seems obvious.

Step 2: Confirm the antecedent is an actual noun, not a possessive form of a noun (a possessive like "the director's" cannot be what a plain pronoun like "she" refers back to).

Step 3: For who/whom or subject/object case, substitute "he"/"him" or "they"/"them" into the clause — whichever sounds right tells you the correct case.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

A Pronoun's Antecedent Must Be an Actual Noun, Not a Possessive

A pronoun can only refer back to a noun functioning as a noun — a possessive form like "the director's" or "Maria's" is functioning as an adjective, and a pronoun cannot legally point back to it.

✗ Incorrect: *In the director's speech, she thanked the entire cast.* — "she" has no true noun antecedent; "director's" is possessive, not a stand-alone noun.

✓ Correct: *In her speech, the director thanked the entire cast.*

A Pronoun With More Than One Possible Antecedent Is Ambiguous

If a pronoun could logically point to two or more different nouns in the sentence, it is treated as an error even when the intended meaning seems clear from context — the sentence must be rewritten to name the specific noun.

✗ Incorrect: *When Maria spoke with Elena, she mentioned the upcoming deadline.* — "she" could refer to either Maria or Elena.

✓ Correct: *When Maria spoke with Elena, Maria mentioned the upcoming deadline.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Subject Form Performs the Action; Object Form Receives It

Who, they, and he perform the action of the verb; whom, them, and him receive it. Substituting a simple pronoun like he/him into the clause reveals which case is correct.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The award went to the researcher who discovered the compound. ("who" performs "discovered" — he discovered it)*
- ✓ **Correct:** *The award went to the researcher whom the committee selected. ("whom" receives the action — the committee selected him)*

"Its" Is Possessive; "It's" Means "It Is"

Read "it is" back into the sentence as a test — if that substitution still makes sense, "it's" is correct; if not, the possessive "its" is required.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The company reported its highest earnings in a decade. (possessive — earnings belonging to the company)*
- ✓ **Correct:** *It's likely that earnings will keep rising. ("it is likely" reads correctly)*
- ✗ **Incorrect:** *The company reported it's highest earnings in a decade.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Reflexive Pronouns Are Only for True Reflexive Action or Emphasis

Myself, himself, and herself refer back to the subject performing an action on itself, or add emphasis — they are never a substitute for a plain object pronoun like "me" or "him."

✓ **Correct:** *She taught herself to code over the summer. (reflexive action)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The professor gave the award to myself and my colleague. — "myself" cannot substitute for "me" here.*

✓ **Correct:** *The professor gave the award to me and my colleague.*

Relative Pronouns

PRONOUN	USE	COMMA?	EXAMPLE
who	People — subject of the clause	If non-essential: yes	The scientist who won the award...
whom	People — object of the clause	If non-essential: yes	The researcher to whom the grant was given...
whose	Possession (people or things)	If non-essential: yes	The company whose profits increased...
which	Things — NON-ESSENTIAL clause	YES — always commas	The device, which was invented in 2010,...
that	Things — ESSENTIAL clause	NO — never commas	The device that she invented...

Common Traps to Watch For

- A pronoun pointing to a possessive noun instead of an actual stand-alone noun.
- A pronoun that seems clear from context but technically has two possible antecedents.
- "Myself" or "himself" used casually in place of a plain object pronoun.

Relative Pronouns (cont.)

Rule: Cover the pronoun and ask “who or what does this refer to?” More than one possible answer means the pronoun is ambiguous and wrong.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Pronouns — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The nonprofit expanded_____ outreach programs to three additional counties this year.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. its

B. it's

C. its'

D. their

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The blank needs a possessive pronoun showing that the outreach programs belong to the nonprofit.
- "Its" is the correct possessive form; "it's" means "it is," which doesn't fit here.
- "The nonprofit" is a singular organization, so the singular pronoun "its" — not the plural "their" — is required.

Rule

"Its" is possessive; "it's" means "it is." Read "it is" back into the sentence as a quick test before choosing between them.

Tip

Say the sentence aloud substituting "it is": "the nonprofit expanded it is outreach programs" clearly fails, confirming the possessive "its" is correct.

Trap

"Its" in Choice C looks like a plausible possessive-plural hybrid, but it isn't a real word in standard English — possessive pronouns like "its" never take an apostrophe at all.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	its	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the possessive pronoun "its" to show the programs belong to the nonprofit.
✗ B	it's	Choice B is incorrect — uses "it's," which means "it is" and doesn't fit this possessive context.
✗ C	its'	Choice C is incorrect — uses "its'," which is not a standard English word.
✗ D	their	Choice D is incorrect — uses the plural "their," which doesn't agree with the singular "the nonprofit."

Question 2

Easy

The two co-founders credited their earliest mentors and_____ for the company's rapid early growth.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. themselves

B. theirselves

C. themself

D. them

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The co-founders, who are the subject of the sentence, are crediting both their mentors and — reflexively — themselves.
- "Themselves" correctly refers back to the subject performing the action, matching the reflexive use of the pronoun.
- "Them" would incorrectly suggest a separate, different group entirely, losing the intended self-reference.

Rule

A reflexive pronoun (themselves, himself, herself) correctly refers back to the subject performing the action — including in a list, when the subject is crediting or including itself.

Tip

Check whether the pronoun refers back to the same people who are the sentence's subject. If so, and the meaning is genuinely self-referential, a reflexive pronoun is correct.

Trap

"Them" can feel like the simpler, more natural default object pronoun, but it would wrongly imply a separate group distinct from the co-founders themselves.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	themselves	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the reflexive "themselves" to refer back to the co-founders crediting themselves.
✗ B	theirselves	Choice B is incorrect — uses "theirselves," which is not a standard English word.
✗ C	themselves	Choice C is incorrect — uses the singular "themselves," which doesn't agree with the plural "the two co-founders."
✗ D	them	Choice D is incorrect — uses the plain object pronoun "them," which incorrectly implies a separate group rather than the co-founders themselves.

Question 3

Medium

In the director's acceptance speech,_____ thanked the entire crew for their dedication.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- | | |
|------------------------|---------------|
| A. the director | C. her |
| B. she | D. it |

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The director's" is a possessive form, functioning as an adjective describing "speech" — it is not a stand-alone noun.
- A pronoun like "she" cannot legally refer back to a possessive form; it needs an actual noun as its antecedent.
- Repeating the actual noun, "the director," is the only option here that avoids this illegal pronoun reference.

Rule

A pronoun's antecedent must be an actual noun functioning as a noun — never a possessive form like "the director's," which functions only as an adjective.

Tip

When a sentence opens with a possessive noun ("the director's," "Maria's"), check whether a later pronoun tries to refer back to it — if so, that reference is illegal, no matter how clear the intended meaning seems.

Trap

"She" feels completely natural and unambiguous to a reader, since it's obvious in context who gave the speech — but the sentence's only available antecedent, "director's," is grammatically possessive, not a plain noun.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	the director	Choice A is the best answer. correctly replaces the illegal pronoun reference by repeating the actual noun, "the director."
✗ B	she	Choice B is incorrect — uses "she" with no legal noun antecedent available in the sentence.
✗ C	her	Choice C is incorrect — uses "her" with the same illegal-antecedent problem.
✗ D	it	Choice D is incorrect — uses "it," which is both grammatically illegal here and doesn't match a person.

Question 4

Medium

When the mentor met with the intern for the final review, _____ shared detailed feedback on the entire semester's work.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** the mentor
- B.** she
- C.** they
- D.** her

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- Both "the mentor" and "the intern" are possible antecedents for a pronoun like "she" or "they."
- Because either noun could logically be the one giving feedback, a pronoun here is ambiguous, even though context might suggest one reading is more likely.
- Repeating the specific noun, "the mentor," removes the ambiguity entirely.

Rule

If a pronoun could logically refer to more than one noun in the sentence, it's treated as an error — even when one reading feels more natural — and must be replaced with the specific noun.

Tip

Whenever a sentence introduces two people of the same category (two people, two organizations) before a pronoun, check whether the pronoun could plausibly point to either one.

Trap

Since mentors typically give feedback to interns rather than the reverse, "she" feels obviously correct in context — but the grammar itself doesn't rule out the intern as the pronoun's antecedent.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	the mentor	Choice A is the best answer. correctly removes the ambiguity by repeating the specific noun, "the mentor."
✗ B	she	Choice B is incorrect — uses "she," which could ambiguously refer to either the mentor or the intern.
✗ C	they	Choice C is incorrect — uses "they," which is both ambiguous and doesn't clearly indicate a single person giving feedback.
✗ D	her	Choice D is incorrect — uses "her," the wrong case for a subject pronoun, in addition to being ambiguous.

Question 5

Medium

The award went to the researcher_____ the committee unanimously selected after a lengthy review.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. whom

B. who

C. whose

D. who's

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- Within its own clause, the pronoun receives the action — "the committee selected [him/her]," not "[he/she] selected."
- Because the pronoun is the object of "selected," the object-case form "whom" is required.
- Substituting "him" confirms this: "the committee selected him" works, while "he" would not.

Rule

Use "whom" when the pronoun receives the action within its own clause, and "who" when it performs the action — substituting "him" or "he" is the fastest way to check.

Tip

Isolate the clause after the blank and mentally reorder it as a simple sentence: "the committee selected ____." Whichever pronoun — him or he — completes that naturally tells you the case.

Trap

"Who" is overwhelmingly more common in casual speech, even in positions that technically call for "whom," which makes "who" an easy default to reach for without checking.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	whom	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the object-case "whom," matching "the committee selected him/her."
✗ B	who	Choice B is incorrect — uses the subject-case "who" where the object case is required.
✗ C	whose	Choice C is incorrect — uses the possessive "whose," which doesn't fit this context at all.
✗ D	who's	Choice D is incorrect — uses "who's," meaning "who is," which doesn't fit this context.

Question 6

Hard

Employees_____ demonstrate exceptional leadership are automatically considered for the mentorship program.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** who
- B.** whom

- C.** which
- D.** whose

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- Within its own clause, the pronoun performs the action — "[they] demonstrate exceptional leadership."
- Because the pronoun is the subject of "demonstrate," the subject-case form "who" is required.
- "Which" is reserved for things, not people, and cannot refer to "employees."

Rule

"Who" refers to people and performs the action within its clause; "which" refers to things, never people, regardless of how the surrounding sentence is structured.

Tip

First confirm whether the antecedent is a person or a thing — that alone eliminates "which" immediately when the antecedent is a person, like "employees."

Trap

"Whom" can feel like the more sophisticated, "formal" choice, especially in professional-sounding writing about a workplace program — but the pronoun here performs the action rather than receiving it.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	who	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the subject-case "who" to perform the action "demonstrate" within its own clause.
✗ B	whom	Choice B is incorrect — uses the object-case "whom" where the subject case is required.
✗ C	which	Choice C is incorrect — uses "which," which cannot refer to people like "employees."
✗ D	whose	Choice D is incorrect — uses the possessive "whose," which doesn't fit this context.

Question 7

Hard

Despite_____ initial struggles, the fledgling company eventually secured a major round of funding.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. its

B. it's

C. their

D. it is

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The blank needs a possessive pronoun showing that the struggles belonged to the company.
- "Its" is the correct possessive form; "it's" means "it is," which fails the substitution test here.
- "The company" is singular, so the singular "its" — not the plural "their" — is required.

Rule

Before choosing between "its" and "it's," substitute "it is" into the sentence — if the result doesn't make sense, the possessive "its" is correct.

Tip

"Despite it is initial struggles" fails immediately as a substitution test, confirming that the possessive form is what's needed.

Trap

"Their" can feel like a natural, informal way to refer to a company as if it were a group of people, but "company" is grammatically singular and takes "its."

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	its	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the possessive "its" to show the struggles belonged to the company.
✗ B	it's	Choice B is incorrect — uses "it's," meaning "it is," which fails the substitution test here.
✗ C	their	Choice C is incorrect — uses the plural "their," which doesn't agree with the singular "the company."
✗ D	it is	Choice D is incorrect — spells out "it is," which doesn't fit grammatically in this possessive position.

Question 8

Hard

The professor invited two guest lecturers and_____ to co-teach the graduate seminar this term.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. himself

B. him

C. he

D. hisself

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The professor, the subject of the sentence, is including himself along with the two guest lecturers in the invitation.
- "Himself" correctly refers back to the subject performing the action — a reflexive use, just like including oneself in a list.
- "Him" would incorrectly suggest inviting some other, separate man, losing the intended self-reference.

Rule

When a subject includes itself in a list of people receiving its own action, the reflexive pronoun (himself, herself, themselves) — not a plain object pronoun — is correct.

Tip

Check whether the object pronoun in a list refers back to the same person as the sentence's subject. If it does, and the meaning is self-inclusive, use the reflexive form.

Trap

"Him" is the more common, simpler object pronoun and can feel like the safer default, but it would wrongly imply a separate person distinct from the professor.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	himself	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the reflexive "himself" to show the professor including himself in the invitation.
✗ B	him	Choice B is incorrect — uses the plain object pronoun "him," which incorrectly implies a separate person.
✗ C	he	Choice C is incorrect — uses the subject-case "he," the wrong case for this object position.
✗ D	hissself	Choice D is incorrect — uses "hissself," which is not a standard English word.

Quick Review — Pronouns

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Pronouns	Cover the pronoun; ask what it refers to.	A pronoun with more than one possible antecedent.

SECTION 14 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Nouns & Apostrophes

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Nouns & Apostrophes

This skill covers two related tests: choosing fewer vs. less for countable and uncountable nouns, and correctly placing the possessive apostrophe.

How to Approach Nouns & Apostrophes Questions

Step 1: Decide first whether the noun before the apostrophe is singular or plural — the possessive rule depends entirely on that answer, not on how the word sounds.

Step 2: Separately, check whether the sentence needs "fewer" or "less": ask whether the noun being counted is countable one-by-one, or a mass that isn't counted in individual units.

Step 3: Confirm a possessive pronoun (its, hers, theirs, whose) isn't being given an apostrophe it doesn't need — these words are already possessive.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Countable Nouns Take "Fewer"; Non-Count Nouns Take "Less"

If you could count the noun one by one (one error, two errors, three errors), use fewer; if the noun is a mass or an abstract quantity that isn't counted in individual units (water, information, time), use less.

✓ **Correct:** *The revised draft contained fewer errors than the original.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The revised draft contained less errors than the original.*

✓ **Correct:** *The new process requires less time overall.*

Singular Possession Always Adds 's, Even After a Final -s

To show that a singular noun owns something, add 's — this rule holds even when the noun already ends in -s.

✓ **Correct:** *The committee reviewed the boss's proposal.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The committee reviewed the boss' proposal.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Regular Plural Possession Adds Only an Apostrophe After the -s

When a plural noun already ends in -s, its possessive form adds just an apostrophe — no second s.

✓ **Correct:** *The students' feedback shaped the new curriculum. (multiple students)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The students's feedback shaped the new curriculum.*

Irregular Plurals Not Ending in -s Take 's, Like a Singular Noun

Words like children, women, and people are already plural without an -s, so their possessive form follows the singular pattern: add 's.

✓ **Correct:** *The children's playground was renovated last year.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The childrens' playground was renovated last year.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Possessive Pronouns Never Take an Apostrophe

Its, hers, ours, yours, theirs, and whose are already possessive by form and never take an apostrophe — adding one always creates an error, or in the case of its/it's and whose/who's, an entirely different word.

✓ **Correct:** *The company doubled its revenue last year.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The company doubled it's revenue last year.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- "Less" used with a plainly countable noun (people, errors, dollars) instead of "fewer."
- A singular noun ending in -s given only an apostrophe instead of the full 's.
- A possessive pronoun like "its" or "whose" wrongly given an apostrophe.

Rule: First decide if the noun is singular or plural, then apply the matching possessive rule — apostrophes never make a noun plural.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Nouns & Apostrophes — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

Because the revised application process required_____ forms than the previous version had, most applicants completed the entire submission in under twenty minutes.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** less
- B.** fewer

- C.** a less
- D.** lesser

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Forms" is a countable noun — you can count one form, two forms, and so on.
- Countable nouns require "fewer," not "less."
- "Less" is reserved for uncountable nouns like water, information, or time.

Rule

Use "fewer" with countable nouns and "less" with uncountable, mass nouns — a distinction based on whether the noun can be counted one by one.

Tip

Ask whether you could put a number directly in front of the noun. If yes ("three forms"), use "fewer"; if no ("three waters" sounds odd), use "less."

Trap

"Less" has become common in casual usage for both countable and uncountable nouns (as in supermarket signs like "10 items or less"), but formal Standard English still distinguishes the two.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	less	Choice A is incorrect — is reserved for uncountable nouns, but "forms" is countable.
✓ B	fewer	Choice B is the best answer. correctly pairs with the countable noun "forms."
X C	a less	Choice C is incorrect — is not a standard grammatical phrase in English.
X D	lesser	Choice D is incorrect — means inferior in quality, not smaller in quantity — the wrong meaning entirely.

Question 2

Easy

After nearly eighteen months of fieldwork across four countries, the_____ findings were published simultaneously in three major international journals.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. scientists'

B. scientist's

C. scientists

D. scientist

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The findings belong to multiple scientists, so the noun must be both plural and possessive.
- For a regular plural noun already ending in -s, possession is shown by adding only an apostrophe after the final -s.
- "Scientists'" correctly shows plural possession.

Rule

For a regular plural noun that already ends in -s, add only an apostrophe after the -s to show possession — never another -s.

Tip

For plural nouns ending in -s, add only an apostrophe after the -s to show possession — never add another -s.

Trap

"Scientist's" (Choice B) looks correct at a glance since it does show possession, but the apostrophe placement wrongly implies only one scientist owns the findings.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	scientists'	Choice A is the best answer. correctly shows plural possession by placing the apostrophe after the plural -s.
✗ B	scientist's	Choice B is incorrect — shows singular possession, implying only one scientist, which contradicts the plural "scientists."
✗ C	scientists	Choice C is incorrect — is plural but shows no possession at all.
✗ D	scientist	Choice D is incorrect — is singular and shows no possession.

Question 3

Medium

After _____ experience conducting fieldwork in three different climate zones, she was promoted to senior researcher and given her own team.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** five years'
- B.** five year's

- C.** five years
- D.** five year

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- This is a time-expression possessive, similar to "a day's work" or "ten dollars' worth."
- Since the amount is plural ("five years"), the possessive apostrophe goes after the final -s.
- The phrase describes experience that belongs to, or spans, five years, requiring the possessive form.

Rule

Time and amount expressions (a day's work, three years' experience, ten dollars' worth) take a possessive apostrophe just as if the time period were an owner.

Tip

Time and amount expressions like "a day's work," "three years' experience," and "ten dollars' worth" follow standard possessive rules — treat the time period as an "owner."

Trap

Choice C, without any apostrophe, might seem sufficient since "years" already shows the amount of time — but the idiomatic possessive construction still requires the apostrophe.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	five years'	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places the possessive apostrophe after the plural -s in this time expression.
✗ B	five year's	Choice B is incorrect — wrongly treats "year" as singular, misplacing the apostrophe.
✗ C	five years	Choice C is incorrect — omits the required possessive apostrophe entirely.
✗ D	five year	Choice D is incorrect — uses the singular "year," which contradicts "five."

Question 4

Medium

After weeks of contentious debate over the proposed budget cuts, the_____ recommendation was ultimately adopted unanimously by the full board.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. committees'

B. committee's

C. committees

D. committee

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Committee" is singular here (one committee made one recommendation).
- Singular possession is shown by adding an apostrophe plus -s, even when the noun itself ends in a vowel or consonant that might look unusual with -'s.
- "Committee's" correctly shows singular possession.

Rule

For a singular noun, always add 's to show possession, even when the noun ends in -s or an unusual letter combination.

Tip

For a singular noun, always add 's to show possession — this rule holds even for nouns ending in -s, like "boss's" or "class's."

Trap

"Committees'" (Choice A) applies the plural possessive rule, which might feel "safer" or more standard for a group noun, but here only one committee is meant.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	committees'	Choice A is incorrect — incorrectly applies the plural possessive rule to a singular committee.
✓ B	committee's	Choice B is the best answer. correctly shows singular possession with 's.
X C	committees	Choice C is incorrect — is plural and shows no possession at all.
X D	committee	Choice D is incorrect — is singular but shows no possession.

Question 5

Medium

Although negotiations dragged on for nearly six weeks, the two_____ competing proposals outlined strikingly different approaches to resolving the trade dispute.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. parties'

B. party's

C. parties

D. party

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The proposals belong to two separate parties, requiring a plural possessive.
- "Party" is an irregular plural (ends in -y, so it becomes "parties" rather than "partys").
- For a plural noun already ending in -s ("parties"), possession is shown by adding only an apostrophe.

Rule

Form the correct plural first, then apply the plural-possessive rule of adding only an apostrophe after a final -s.

Tip

First form the correct plural of the noun (party → parties), then apply the plural possessive rule (add only an apostrophe after the -s).

Trap

"Party's" (Choice B) correctly shows possession but incorrectly treats the noun as singular, contradicting "the two."

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	parties'	Choice A is the best answer. correctly pluralizes "party" to "parties" and adds the plural possessive apostrophe.
✗ B	party's	Choice B is incorrect — shows singular possession, contradicting "the two."
✗ C	parties	Choice C is incorrect — is plural but shows no possession.
✗ D	party	Choice D is incorrect — is singular and shows no possession, doubly incorrect.

Question 6

Hard

When the editorial team compared the two drafts side by side, they discovered that_____ errors were found in the final version of the report than in the original draft.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** less
- B.** fewer
- C.** a less amount of
- D.** lesser

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Errors" is a countable noun.
- Countable nouns require "fewer," never "less," regardless of how natural "less" might sound in casual speech.
- "Fewer errors" is the only grammatically correct option among the choices.

Rule

"Fewer" for countable nouns is one of the most heavily tested Standard English Conventions rules — treat it as an absolute, not a "usually."

Tip

This is one of the most frequently tested Standard English Conventions rules — "fewer" for countable nouns is worth memorizing as an absolute, not a "usually."

Trap

"Less errors" is extremely common in everyday spoken English, which can make the error nearly invisible unless you actively apply the countable-noun test.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	less	Choice A is incorrect — incorrectly pairs "less" with the countable noun "errors."
✓ B	fewer	Choice B is the best answer. correctly pairs "fewer" with the countable noun "errors."
X C	a less amount of	Choice C is incorrect — is an awkward, nonstandard phrase not used in formal English.
X D	lesser	Choice D is incorrect — means inferior in quality or importance, not smaller in number — the wrong meaning entirely.

Question 7

Hard

By the time the daycare center closed for the evening, the_____ toys, books, and art supplies were scattered across nearly every corner of the playroom floor.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. childrens'

B. children's

C. childrens

D. childs'

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Children" is already an irregular plural noun that does not end in -s.
- For irregular plurals not ending in -s, possession is shown by adding an apostrophe plus -s, just as with a singular noun.
- "Children's" is the correct plural possessive form.

Rule

Irregular plurals that don't end in -s (children, men, women, people) take 's for possession, following the singular pattern rather than the regular-plural pattern.

Tip

Irregular plurals like children, men, women, and people don't end in -s, so they take 's for possession just like a singular noun would.

Trap

"Childrens'" (Choice A) applies the standard "add apostrophe after -s" rule for regular plurals, but since "children" is already irregular and doesn't end in -s, that rule doesn't apply here.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	childrens'	Choice A is incorrect — incorrectly applies the regular plural-possessive rule to the irregular noun "children."
✓ B	children's	Choice B is the best answer. correctly adds 's to the irregular plural "children," just as with a singular noun.
X C	childrens	Choice C is incorrect — shows no possession at all.
X D	childs'	Choice D is incorrect — incorrectly pluralizes "child" as "childs" before adding the apostrophe.

Question 8

Hard

After nearly a decade of research funded largely by private donors, the institute finally published_____ landmark study on the long-term cognitive effects of chronic sleep deprivation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. its

B. it's

C. their

D. there

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "The institute" is a singular collective noun, requiring the singular possessive pronoun "its."
- "It's" is a contraction of "it is," which does not fit a possessive meaning here.
- "Their" incorrectly treats the institute as a plural entity.

Rule

Possessive pronouns like "its," "whose," and "theirs" never take an apostrophe — the apostrophe is reserved for contractions like "it's" (it is) and "who's" (who is).

Tip

Read "it is" back into the sentence as a test: "the institute published it is landmark study" doesn't make sense, confirming the possessive "its" (no apostrophe) is required.

Trap

The apostrophe in "it's" looks like a standard possessive marker, which is true for nearly every other noun in English — pronouns are the one major exception.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	its	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the possessive pronoun for the singular noun "institute," with no apostrophe.
✗ B	it's	Choice B is incorrect — is the contraction "it is," which fails the substitution test.
✗ C	their	Choice C is incorrect — wrongly treats the singular "institute" as plural.
✗ D	there	Choice D is incorrect — is an adverb of place, unrelated to possession.

Quick Review — Nouns & Apostrophes

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Nouns & Apostrophes	Decide singular or plural before punctuating.	Apostrophe placement on plural possessives.

SECTION 15 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Adjectives & Adverbs

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Adjectives & Adverbs

Beyond the basic adjective/adverb distinction, this skill tests comparative vs. superlative forms and catches redundant modifiers that repeat meaning already built into the word they describe.

How to Approach Adjectives & Adverbs Questions

Step 1: Count exactly how many things are being compared before choosing a form — that number alone determines comparative versus superlative.

Step 2: Check whether the word being intensified (very, more, completely) is already an absolute quality that logically can't come in degrees.

Step 3: For a handful of irregular words, recall that the adjective and adverb forms are identical — don't force an -ly ending where none exists.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Two Items Take the Comparative; Three or More Take the Superlative

Comparing exactly two things requires the comparative form (-er or "more"); comparing three or more requires the superlative (-est or "most").

✓ **Correct:** *Of the two proposals, the second was more persuasive.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *Of the two proposals, the second was most persuasive. — only two items are being compared.*

✓ **Correct:** *Of the five finalists, she gave the most persuasive presentation.*

Never Double a Comparative or Superlative Form

A word takes either the -er/-est ending or "more"/"most" before it — never both at once.

✗ **Incorrect:** *The revised plan was more easier to follow.*

✓ **Correct:** *The revised plan was easier to follow.*

✗ **Incorrect:** *This was the most highest score of the season.*

✓ **Correct:** *This was the highest score of the season.*

Absolute Adjectives Cannot Be Intensified

Words like unique, perfect, complete, and impossible already describe an all-or-nothing quality — they logically cannot be "very" or "more" of that quality.

✗ **Incorrect:** *The artifact was very unique.*

✓ **Correct:** *The artifact was unique.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

A Few Words Use the Same Form for Both Adjective and Adverb

Fast, hard, late, high, and early describe both nouns (as adjectives) and verbs (as adverbs) with no change in spelling — adding -ly to some of these either changes the meaning entirely or is simply wrong.

✓ **Correct:** *The runner finished fast. (adverb, modifying "finished")*

✓ **Correct:** *It was a fast finish. (adjective, modifying "finish")*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The runner finished hardly. — "hardly" means "barely," not "with effort"; the correct adverb here is simply "hard."*

Redundant Adjectives

The SAT tests whether adjectives add meaning or just repeat information already contained in the noun.

WRONG	WHY IT'S WRONG
✗ final conclusion	'Conclusion' is always final — 'final' is redundant.
✗ future plans	'Plans' are always future — 'future' is redundant.
✗ past history	'History' is always past — 'past' is redundant.
✗ completely unique	'Unique' means one-of-a-kind — it cannot be intensified.
✗ advance warning	'Warning' always comes in advance — redundant.
✗ very/completely finished	'Finished' = done — 'very/completely' add nothing.

Adverbs

Adverbs modify VERBS, ADJECTIVES, and other ADVERBS. They answer: How? When? Where? To what extent?

Misplaced Adverbs — 'Only' and Placement

'Only' changes meaning dramatically depending on where it is placed. It must be placed directly before the word it modifies.

SENTENCE	MEANING
Only I gave him money.	No one else gave him money.
I only gave him money.	I did nothing else (just gave money).
I gave only him money.	I gave to no one else.
I gave him only money.	I gave nothing else (just money).

Adverbs (cont.)

✗ INCORRECT <i>The researchers only tested the samples on Monday.</i>	✓ CORRECT <i>The researchers tested only the samples on Monday. / The researchers tested the samples only on Monday.</i>
Why: Where 'only' sits changes the whole meaning of the sentence. Place it directly before what it modifies.	

 SAT TIP

After a LINKING VERB (is, seems, appears) → adjective. 'She seems happy.' After an ACTION VERB → adverb. 'She runs quickly.'

2 items → comparative (-er / more). 3+ items → superlative (-est / the most). Never mix them up.

Coordinate adjectives: 'and' works between them AND order is reversible → comma needed.

Redundancy: if the adjective just repeats what the noun already means → remove it. 'Final conclusion' → just 'conclusion'.

Common Traps to Watch For

- A superlative used to compare only two things, or a comparative used to compare three or more.
- A double comparative or superlative ("more easier," "most highest") that sounds emphatic but is always wrong.
- An absolute adjective (unique, perfect) intensified with "very" or "more."

Rule: Count the items being compared — two calls for the comparative, three or more calls for the superlative — and never intensify an already-absolute word.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Adjectives & Adverbs — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

After the interview panel deliberated for nearly an hour, they agreed that, of the three candidates, she was the_____ qualified for the position.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. more

B. most

C. the more

D. much

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence compares three candidates, a group of three or more.
- Comparisons among three or more items require the superlative form.
- "Most" is the correct superlative form for this comparison.

Rule

Comparing exactly two things requires the comparative (-er / more); comparing three or more requires the superlative (-est / most).

Tip

Count the items being compared: exactly two calls for the comparative (-er/more); three or more calls for the superlative (-est/most).

Trap

"More" (Choice A) is the comparative form, commonly used and easy to default to, but it's reserved for comparisons between exactly two things.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	more	Choice A is incorrect — is the comparative form, correct only for comparing exactly two things.
✓ B	most	Choice B is the best answer. is the correct superlative form for comparing three or more candidates.
X C	the more	Choice C is incorrect — incorrectly pairs the comparative "more" with a definite article, still wrong for three items.
X D	much	Choice D is incorrect — is used for uncountable amounts, not for ranking multiple distinct candidates.

Question 2

Easy

Reviewers praised the new laboratory method for being simple, reproducible, and_____ in most standard laboratory settings across a wide range of institutions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. efficiency

B. efficiently

C. efficient

D. efficiencies

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence lists three parallel adjectives describing "the method": simple, reproducible, and the missing word.
- Since "simple" and "reproducible" are adjectives, the third item must also be an adjective.
- "Efficient" is the adjective form, matching the parallel structure.

Rule

Every item in a descriptive list must share the same part of speech as the first item in that list.

Tip

In a list of descriptive words, identify the part of speech used by the first items, then match the final item to that same form.

Trap

"Efficiently" (Choice B), the adverb form, might feel like a reasonable descriptive word choice, but it breaks the parallel adjective structure of the list.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	efficiency	Choice A is incorrect — is a noun, breaking the adjective list.
X B	efficiently	Choice B is incorrect — is an adverb, which cannot describe "the method" the way an adjective does in this list.
✓ C	efficient	Choice C is the best answer. is the adjective form, correctly matching "simple" and "reproducible."
X D	efficiencies	Choice D is incorrect — is a plural noun, also breaking the adjective list.

Question 3

Medium

Although several earlier studies had explored similar phenomena in laboratory settings, the results of this particular field experiment were widely regarded as remarkably_____, since no other study had produced anything comparable.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** very unique
- B.** completely unique
- C.** particularly unique
- D.** unique

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Unique" means one-of-a-kind and is already an absolute quality.
- Absolute adjectives like "unique," "perfect," and "impossible" cannot logically be intensified.
- Removing the intensifier entirely produces the grammatically correct sentence.

Rule

Absolute adjectives (unique, perfect, complete, impossible) describe an all-or-nothing quality and cannot logically be intensified by words like "very" or "completely."

Tip

Watch for absolute adjectives (unique, perfect, complete, impossible) paired with intensifiers like "very" or "completely" — the intensifier is always redundant and should be removed.

Trap

Intensifiers like "very" and "completely" feel like they add emphasis in everyday speech, which makes "very unique" sound natural despite being logically redundant.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	very unique	Choice A is incorrect — redundantly intensifies the already-absolute adjective "unique."
X B	completely unique	Choice B is incorrect — also redundantly intensifies "unique."
X C	particularly unique	Choice C is incorrect — again redundantly intensifies an adjective that cannot logically be qualified by degree.
✓ D	unique	Choice D is the best answer. correctly removes the redundant intensifier, since "unique" needs no qualifier.

Question 4

Medium

Sensing the growing frustration in the room, she gave a_____ answer that immediately resolved the committee's lingering concerns about the timeline.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** quick
- B.** quickly

- C.** quicker
- D.** quickest

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The missing word modifies the noun "answer," not a verb.
- Nouns are modified by adjectives, not adverbs.
- "Quick" is the correct adjective form describing the noun "answer."

Rule

Identify what part of speech the missing word modifies: a noun needs an adjective, while a verb needs an adverb.

Tip

Identify what part of speech the missing word modifies first: a noun needs an adjective, while a verb needs an adverb.

Trap

"Quickly" (Choice B) might feel like the safer, more "correct-sounding" choice since -ly adverbs are often associated with proper grammar, but here it would incorrectly modify the noun "answer."

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	quick	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the adjective form to modify the noun "answer."
✗ B	quickly	Choice B is incorrect — is an adverb, which cannot modify a noun.
✗ C	quicker	Choice C is incorrect — is a comparative adjective with no valid comparison point given in the sentence.
✗ D	quickest	Choice D is incorrect — is a superlative adjective, also with no valid comparison established.

Question 5

Medium

Even among a faculty full of accomplished researchers, he is_____ regarded as the leading expert in this particular subfield of applied linguistics.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** high
- B.** highly

- C.** higher
- D.** highest

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The missing word modifies the verb phrase "is regarded," describing how he is regarded.
- Verbs (and passive verb phrases) are modified by adverbs, not adjectives.
- "Highly" is the correct adverb form for this context.

Rule

"High" and "highly" are not interchangeable: "high" typically describes physical elevation, while "highly" describes degree or intensity.

Tip

"High" and "highly" are not interchangeable: "high" describes physical elevation (flew high), while "highly" describes degree or intensity (highly regarded, highly skilled).

Trap

"High" (Choice A) is a short, common word that might feel acceptable in casual speech ("he's held in high regard" is different from "he is high regarded"), but the specific construction here requires the adverb form.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	high	Choice A is incorrect — is an adjective typically describing physical elevation, not degree of regard.
✓ B	highly	Choice B is the best answer. correctly uses the adverb form to describe the degree to which he is regarded.
X C	higher	Choice C is incorrect — is a comparative adjective with no valid comparison established.
X D	highest	Choice D is incorrect — is a superlative adjective, also without a valid comparison.

Question 6

Hard

After running both experiments under identical conditions and comparing the two data sets in detail, the researchers concluded that the second method produced the_____ results.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** more accurate
- B.** most accurate

- C.** accurate
- D.** accuratest

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence compares exactly two methods.
- Comparisons between exactly two items require the comparative form, not the superlative.
- "More accurate" is the correct comparative form.

Rule

A clear signal of exactly two items being compared — "the two," "either," "between" — always calls for the comparative, never the superlative.

Tip

The word "two" (or a description of exactly two items) in the sentence is a strong, reliable signal to use the comparative, not the superlative.

Trap

"Most accurate" (Choice B) might feel like the stronger, more emphatic choice, especially if the results seem impressively better — but the SAT tests the two-vs-three-or-more distinction strictly regardless of degree.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	more accurate	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses the comparative form for a comparison between exactly two methods.
✗ B	most accurate	Choice B is incorrect — is the superlative form, reserved for three or more items being compared.
✗ C	accurate	Choice C is incorrect — is the base form, with no comparison expressed at all.
✗ D	accuratest	Choice D is incorrect — is not a standard English word — "accurate" takes "more/most," not an -est ending.

Question 7

Hard

Despite the tight deadline and several unexpected delays along the way, the proposal was_____ finished well ahead of the client's final submission date.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. completely

B. totally

C. (no word needed)

D. very

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Finished" already means fully done — it is an absolute state that cannot logically be intensified.
- Words like "completely," "totally," and "very" are redundant when paired with an already-absolute word like "finished."
- Removing the intensifier produces the cleanest, grammatically precise sentence.

Rule

Just as with absolute adjectives, absolute states like "finished," "dead," "empty," and "perfect" should not be paired with degree words like "very" or "completely."

Tip

Just as "unique" cannot be intensified, absolute states like "finished," "dead," "empty," and "perfect" shouldn't be paired with degree words like "very" or "completely."

Trap

"Completely finished" is an extremely common phrase in everyday English, which makes its redundancy easy to overlook without specifically checking for absolute-state pairings.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	completely	Choice A is incorrect — redundantly intensifies the already-absolute state "finished."
X B	totally	Choice B is incorrect — also redundantly intensifies "finished."
✓ C	(no word needed)	Choice C is the best answer. correctly removes the redundant intensifier.
X D	very	Choice D is incorrect — again redundantly intensifies an absolute state that cannot logically take a degree modifier.

Question 8

Hard

Caught in unusually heavy traffic on the way across town, she arrived_____ for the meeting and missed the opening presentation entirely.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. lately

B. late

C. more late

D. most late

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Late" describes how she arrived — modifying the verb "arrived."
- "Late" is one of a small set of words (fast, hard, high, early) that are identical in both their adjective and adverb forms.
- "Lately" is a different word entirely, meaning "recently," and does not fit this context.

Rule

A small set of words — late, fast, hard, high, early — use the identical spelling for both the adjective and adverb form; don't automatically add -ly.

Tip

Watch for words like "late," "fast," "hard," and "high," which use the same spelling for both adjective and adverb — don't automatically add -ly, since that sometimes creates a completely different word.

Trap

"Lately" (Choice A) looks like the expected adverb form since it follows the normal -ly pattern, but "lately" actually means "recently," a different meaning entirely from "not on time."

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	lately	Choice A is incorrect — means "recently," a different word with a different meaning than intended here.
✓ B	late	Choice B is the best answer. correctly uses "late," which serves as both adjective and adverb without needing an -ly ending.
X C	more late	Choice C is incorrect — creates a double comparative form; "late" doesn't need "more" here, and no comparison is being made.
X D	most late	Choice D is incorrect — creates a nonstandard superlative form with no comparison established in the sentence.

Quick Review — Adjectives & Adverbs

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Adjectives & Adverbs	Count the items being compared.	Double comparatives or intensifying an absolute word.

SECTION 16 • PART 3 — FORM, STRUCTURE & SENSE

Modifiers

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Modifiers

A modifier must sit as close as possible to the word it describes. When it doesn't, the sentence becomes illogical, ambiguous, or unintentionally funny — this is tested through dangling, misplaced, and squinting modifiers.

How to Approach Modifiers Questions

Step 1: For any opening phrase before a comma, ask: who or what is actually doing (or experiencing) this action? That noun must be the very next word after the comma.

Step 2: If no logical noun in the sentence could be doing that action, the modifier is dangling — the fix requires adding the correct noun, not just moving words around.

Step 3: If the correct noun is present but sits too far from the modifying phrase, or could attach to either of two nearby nouns, reposition the modifier directly next to the one word it's meant to describe.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Dangling Modifier: The Word Being Described Is Missing Entirely

An opening participial phrase describes whoever performs its action — if that person or thing never actually appears as the subject of the main clause, the modifier dangles with nothing to attach to.

✗ Incorrect: *Walking through the gallery, the paintings seemed even more vivid in person. — the paintings can't walk; the visitor who was walking is never named.*

✓ Correct: *Walking through the gallery, visitors found the paintings even more vivid in person.*

Misplaced Modifier: The Right Word Exists but Sits Too Far Away

When a modifying phrase is placed too far from the word it's meant to describe, other nouns in between create confusion about what's actually being modified.

✗ Incorrect: *The committee awarded the prize to the scientist wrapped in gold foil. — this implies the scientist, not the prize, was wrapped in foil.*

✓ Correct: *The committee awarded the prize, wrapped in gold foil, to the scientist.*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

Squinting Modifier: The Phrase Could Attach to Either Side

A modifier placed between two clauses or phrases creates real ambiguity when it could logically describe what comes before it or what comes after it.

✗ Incorrect: *Students who practice frequently improve their scores. — does "frequently" describe how often students practice, or how often they improve? Both readings are plausible.*

✓ Correct: *Students who frequently practice improve their scores. ("frequently" now clearly modifies "practice")*

The Noun Right After an Introductory Comma Must Be Exactly What the Phrase Describes

This is the fastest way to check any opening modifier: read the phrase, then check that the single noun immediately following the comma is the literal thing performing or experiencing that action.

✓ Correct: *Exhausted from the overnight flight, the delegates postponed the morning meeting. (the delegates were exhausted)*

✗ Incorrect: *Exhausted from the overnight flight, the morning meeting was postponed. — a meeting cannot be exhausted.*

Common Traps to Watch For

- An opening phrase followed by an inanimate object or abstract noun that logically cannot perform the described action.
- A modifying phrase separated from its intended noun by an unrelated noun that grammatically "fits" but is logically wrong.
- An adverb placed between two verbs or clauses so that it's unclear which one it modifies.

Rule: For an opening -ing or -ed phrase, ask “who is doing (or being) this?” — that noun must follow the comma immediately, with no exceptions.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Modifiers — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

Exhausted after the gruelling overnight shift in the emergency department, _____ finally went home shortly after midnight.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** the nurses
- B.** rest was needed
- C.** the hospital
- D.** going home

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Exhausted after the gruelling overnight shift" is an introductory phrase describing whoever felt exhausted.
- The noun immediately following the comma must be the one being described — here, the nurses.
- Only "the nurses" can logically be described as exhausted.

Rule

The noun immediately after an introductory modifying phrase must be the exact thing that phrase describes — never a different noun that merely appears nearby.

Tip

Read the introductory phrase, then ask: who or what is being described? That answer must be the very next word after the comma.

Trap

"Rest was needed" (Choice B) completes a grammatically plausible sentence on its own, but "rest" cannot logically be described as exhausted — only a person can feel exhaustion.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	the nurses	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places "the nurses" — the ones who were exhausted — right after the comma.
✗ B	rest was needed	Choice B is incorrect — illogically implies that "rest" itself was exhausted.
✗ C	the hospital	Choice C is incorrect — illogically implies that "the hospital" was exhausted.
✗ D	going home	Choice D is incorrect — illogically implies that the act of "going home" was exhausted.

Question 2

Easy

Walking into the lab early that morning after a restless night of preparation_____ the researchers began the experiment without delay.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. ;

C. :

D. (no punctuation)

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Walking into the lab early that morning after a restless night of preparation" is an introductory participial phrase.
- An introductory phrase must be followed by a comma before the main clause begins.
- The noun right after the comma, "the researchers," logically matches who was walking into the lab.

Rule

An introductory participial phrase must be followed by a comma before the main clause begins, regardless of how long the phrase is.

Tip

An introductory -ing phrase almost always needs a comma before the subject of the main clause, and that subject must be the one performing the described action.

Trap

Skipping the comma (Choice D) can feel acceptable in a short, clear sentence, but the comma is still grammatically required to mark the boundary between the phrase and the main clause, especially as the phrase grows longer.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a comma after the introductory participial phrase.
✗ B	;	Choice B is incorrect — a semicolon requires an independent clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — a colon requires a complete clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ D	(no punctuation)	Choice D is incorrect — omits the required comma between the introductory phrase and the main clause.

Question 3

Medium

The professor_____ who had won the Nobel Prize decades earlier for her work on cellular repair mechanisms_____ still lectures every Tuesday morning to a packed auditorium.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , ... ,

B. — ... —

C. (no punctuation) ... (no punctuation)

D. ; ... ;

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Who had won the Nobel Prize decades earlier for her work on cellular repair mechanisms" is a nonessential clause interrupting the subject and verb.
- A nonessential clause needs matching punctuation marks on both sides.
- Commas are the standard, correct choice for this nonessential interruption in a plainly stated sentence.

Rule

A nonessential interrupting clause must be boxed in by a matching pair of punctuation marks — commas, dashes, or occasionally parentheses — never a single mark on only one side.

Tip

Dashes and commas can both correctly box in a nonessential interruption, but pick the mark that matches the sentence's tone — plain, factual sentences typically use commas rather than the more dramatic dash.

Trap

Dashes (Choice B) are also grammatically valid for boxing in nonessential information, which can make it tempting when a sentence contains other punctuation nearby — but consistency with the sentence's neutral tone favors commas here.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	, ... ,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly uses matching commas to box in the nonessential clause in this plainly stated sentence.
✗ B	— ... —	Choice B is incorrect — dashes would also be grammatically valid but introduce unnecessary emphasis not suited to this neutral sentence.
✗ C	(no punctuation) ... (no punctuation)	Choice C is incorrect — omits any boundary at all around the nonessential clause.
✗ D	; ... ;	Choice D is incorrect — a semicolon cannot be used to box in a nonessential clause; it requires independent clauses on both sides.

Question 4

Medium

Developed over more than a decade by a team of over two hundred researchers working across a dozen partner universities_____ the model proved highly reliable in its very first large-scale field trial.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,**B.** ;**C.** :**D.** —

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Developed over more than a decade by a team of over two hundred researchers working across a dozen partner universities" is an introductory past-participial phrase describing "the model."
- An introductory phrase requires a comma before the main clause begins.
- "The model," the noun right after the comma, correctly matches what was developed.

Rule

Introductory participial phrases (starting with an -ed or -ing word) always take a comma before the subject they describe — never a semicolon or colon, which require a complete clause before them.

Tip

Introductory participial phrases (starting with an -ed or -ing word) always take a comma before the subject they describe — never a semicolon or colon, which require a complete clause before them.

Trap

A dash (Choice D) can sometimes replace a comma for dramatic emphasis, but the standard, expected choice for a long introductory descriptive phrase like this is a comma, especially with no matching second dash needed.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a comma after the introductory participial phrase.
✗ B	;	Choice B is incorrect — a semicolon requires an independent clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — a colon requires a complete clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ D	—	Choice D is incorrect — while sometimes stylistically valid, is not needed or paired here — the comma is the standard, expected choice.

Question 5

Medium

Using advanced imaging software that had only recently been approved for field use_____ the team analysed the geological samples collected from the excavation site in remarkable detail.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. ;

C. :

D. —

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Using advanced imaging software that had only recently been approved for field use" is an introductory participial phrase describing who used the software.
- The comma correctly separates the introductory phrase from the main clause.
- "The team," the noun right after the comma, logically matches who used the software.

Rule

Whenever a sentence opens with a phrase describing a tool or method ("using X"), the very next noun after the comma must be the one actually using that tool.

Tip

Whenever a sentence opens with a phrase ending in a tool or method ("using X"), double-check that the very next noun is the one actually using that tool.

Trap

Without careful checking, a version like "Using advanced imaging software, the geological samples were analysed" could slip through, since "software" analyzing something on its own sounds almost plausible in scientific writing.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a comma after the introductory participial phrase, followed by the logical subject "the team."
✗ B	;	Choice B is incorrect — a semicolon requires an independent clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — a colon requires a complete clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ D	—	Choice D is incorrect — is not the standard or needed choice for this straightforward introductory phrase.

Question 6

Hard

After months of painstaking analysis involving thousands of data points collected from field sites across the region, the_____ of the study confirmed the initial hypothesis beyond reasonable doubt.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** conclusion
- B.** concluding result
- C.** resulting conclusion
- D.** final conclusion

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Conclusion" already implies a final point — "final" is redundant.
- Redundant modifiers repeat information already contained in the noun itself.
- The plain noun "conclusion" alone is the cleanest, most precise choice.

Rule

Cut any modifier that repeats meaning already built into the noun it describes — "final conclusion," "past history," and "advance warning" are classic redundant pairs.

Tip

Watch for adjectives that repeat meaning already built into the noun — "final conclusion," "past history," and "advance warning" are classic redundant pairs.

Trap

"Final conclusion" sounds emphatic and natural in everyday writing, which is exactly why redundancy errors like this are easy to miss without specifically checking for built-in meaning.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	conclusion	Choice A is the best answer. removes the redundant modifier, since "conclusion" already implies finality.
✗ B	concluding result	Choice B is incorrect — is also redundant and additionally awkward in phrasing.
✗ C	resulting conclusion	Choice C is incorrect — reverses the redundant wording but remains just as repetitive.
✗ D	final conclusion	Choice D is incorrect — keeps the original redundant modifier "final" paired with "conclusion."

Question 7

Hard

Painted by an unknown artist sometime in the early eighteenth century and rediscovered only recently in a private collection_____ the portrait is now valued at several million dollars.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. ,

B. ;

C. :

D. —

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Painted by an unknown artist sometime in the early eighteenth century and rediscovered only recently in a private collection" is an introductory past-participial phrase describing "the portrait."
- The comma correctly separates this introductory phrase from the main clause.
- "The portrait," the noun right after the comma, is logically the thing that was painted.

Rule

Past-participial phrases describe whatever noun performed or received that action, and that noun must appear immediately after the introductory comma, no matter how many details the phrase piles on.

Tip

Past-participial phrases (starting with an -ed word like "Painted," "Discovered," or "Written") describe whatever noun performed or received that action, and that noun must come immediately after the introductory comma.

Trap

It's easy to focus only on whether a comma is present at all and miss checking whether the phrase logically matches the noun that follows it — always verify both the punctuation and the logic, especially in longer sentences.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	,	Choice A is the best answer. correctly places a comma after the introductory phrase, followed by the logical subject "the portrait."
✗ B	;	Choice B is incorrect — a semicolon requires an independent clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ C	:	Choice C is incorrect — a colon requires a complete clause before it, but the phrase is not one.
✗ D	—	Choice D is incorrect — is not the standard or needed choice for this straightforward introductory phrase.

Question 8

Hard

_____ the mountain after nearly seven grueling hours on an exposed and icy ridge, the climbers finally spotted a remote settlement in the valley far below them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** Having climbed
- B.** Climbing
- C.** They climbed
- D.** Climbed

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence needs an introductory phrase showing an action completed before the main action of spotting the settlement.
- "Having climbed" (perfect participle) correctly shows the climbing happened before, and separately from, the spotting.
- "Climbing" (Choice B) would suggest the climbing and spotting happened at the same time, which doesn't fit reaching a summit before seeing something below.

Rule

Use "having + past participle" for an introductory phrase whenever one action must be understood as complete before the main action of the sentence begins.

Tip

Use "having + past participle" for an introductory phrase when one action must be understood as complete before the main action of the sentence begins.

Trap

"Climbing" (Choice B) is grammatically a valid participle and avoids any dangling-modifier issue, but it changes the meaning to suggest simultaneous action rather than the sequence the sentence intends.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Having climbed	Choice A is the best answer. correctly shows the climbing was completed before the climbers spotted the settlement.
✗ B	Climbing	Choice B is incorrect — implies the climbing and spotting happened simultaneously, which doesn't fit the logical sequence.
✗ C	They climbed	Choice C is incorrect — creates a run-on by placing a full independent clause where an introductory phrase is needed, with no connecting punctuation.
✗ D	Climbed	Choice D is incorrect — uses the simple past participle alone, which doesn't function as a valid introductory phrase here.

Quick Review — Modifiers

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Modifiers	Match the opening phrase to the very next noun.	Dangling modifier with no logical noun to attach to.

SECTION 17 • PART 4 — HIGHER-LEVEL SKILLS

Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

Items in a list, a comparison, or a paired correlative structure must all follow the same grammatical form. This section also covers correlative conjunctions, coordinating vs. subordinating conjunctions, and idiomatic comparison structures.

How to Approach Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons Questions

Step 1: Find the first item in the list, pair, or comparison — its grammatical form (a verb, a gerund, a noun, an infinitive) sets the exact pattern every other item must match.

Step 2: If the sentence uses a correlative pair (not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, both...and), check that the same grammatical structure follows each half of the pair.

Step 3: For a comparison, confirm the two things being compared are actually the same type of thing — not, for instance, a city's population compared directly to another city's name.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point

Every Item in a List Must Match the First Item's Grammatical Form

Once the first item in a series establishes a pattern — a verb form, a noun, a gerund, an infinitive — every remaining item must follow that identical pattern.

✓ **Correct:** *The internship taught her to research, to write, and to present with confidence. (three infinitives)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The internship taught her to research, writing, and presenting with confidence. — the pattern set by "to research" breaks with "writing" and "presenting."*

Correlative Pairs Require Matching Structure on Both Sides

Not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, and both...and are fixed two-part phrases — whatever grammatical structure follows the first half must be mirrored exactly after the second half.

✓ **Correct:** *The policy not only reduced costs but also improved employee satisfaction. (verb phrase matches verb phrase)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *The policy not only reduced costs but also employee satisfaction improved. — the structure after "but also" no longer mirrors the structure after "not only."*

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

FANBOYS Join Equal, Independent Elements; Subordinators Create Dependent Clauses

Coordinating conjunctions (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) join two grammatically equal elements, often two independent clauses; subordinating conjunctions (because, although, since, while) instead turn one clause into a dependent one that relies on the other.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The results were promising, so the team expanded the trial.* (two independent clauses, comma + FANBOYS)
- ✓ **Correct:** *Because the results were promising, the team expanded the trial.* (dependent clause + independent clause, no FANBOYS needed)

"That Of" or "Those Of" Keep a Comparison Apples-to-Apples

When comparing a possessive or "of" phrase to another noun, insert "that of" (singular) or "those of" (plural) so the comparison lines up two like things instead of a thing and a place, person, or category.

- ✓ **Correct:** *The city's population growth outpaced that of its neighboring suburb.* (growth compared to growth)
- ✗ **Incorrect:** *The city's population growth outpaced its neighboring suburb.* — this illogically compares growth to an entire suburb.

Core Rules, Explained — With a Worked Example for Every Point (cont.)

"Like" Takes a Noun; "As" Takes a Full Clause With Its Own Verb

"Like" signals a similarity between two nouns and is followed by a noun or pronoun with no verb; "as" introduces a full clause with its own subject and verb, usually comparing actions or manners rather than things; "unlike" signals contrast between two nouns.

✓ **Correct:** *Like her mentor, she pursued a career in structural engineering. (noun to noun)*

✓ **Correct:** *She approached the problem as her mentor had taught her. (full clause, its own verb)*

✗ **Incorrect:** *She approached the problem like her mentor had taught her. — "like" cannot introduce a full clause with its own verb.*

Correlative Conjunctions — Always Require Parallel Structure

PNRE AEUX			
both ... and	Adds two items	Same form on each side	She is both a teacher and a researcher.
either ... or	Two alternatives	Same form on each side	Either call or email.
neither ... nor	Negates both	Verb agrees with CLOSER subject	Neither the teacher nor students ARE ready.
not only ... but also	Emphatic addition	Parallel immediately after each part	Not only effective but also efficient.
rather ... than	Preference	Same form on each side	She would rather walk than drive.

Correlative Conjunctions — Always Require Parallel Structure (cont.)

PNRE AEUX			
as ... as	Equal comparison	Same form on each side	The test was as difficult as last year's.
✗ INCORRECT <i>The device is not only compact but also increases efficiency.</i>		✓ CORRECT <i>The device is not only compact but also efficient.</i>	
Why: 'Not only compact' = adjective. 'But also' must also be followed by an adjective: 'efficient'.			

Common Traps to Watch For

- One item in an otherwise-parallel list quietly switching form (a gerund among infinitives, a noun among verb phrases).
- A correlative pair (not only/but also) with mismatched structure after each half.
- A comparison stacking a possessive or descriptive phrase against a bare noun instead of using "that of" or "those of."

Correlative Conjunctions — Always Require Parallel Structure (cont.)

Rule: Find the first item in the list that sets the pattern — every other item must match it exactly, and correlative pairs must always appear together.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Easy

The redesigned curriculum teaches students to analyse primary sources, to evaluate competing claims, and_____ persuasively using textual evidence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** arguing
- B.** to argue

- C.** persuasive argumentation
- D.** they argue

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The list has three parallel items, each starting with "to" plus a verb: to analyse, to evaluate, and the missing item.
- The first item sets the pattern: infinitive form (to + base verb).
- "To argue" matches this established infinitive pattern exactly.

Rule

Find the first item in a list — it sets the required grammatical pattern that every other item must match exactly.

Tip

Find the first item in a list — it sets the required grammatical pattern that every other item must match exactly.

Trap

"Arguing" (Choice A) is a perfectly natural-sounding word in isolation, but it's a gerund, not an infinitive, breaking the established "to + verb" pattern.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	arguing	Choice A is incorrect — uses the gerund form, breaking the infinitive pattern set by "to analyse" and "to evaluate."
✓ B	to argue	Choice B is the best answer. matches the infinitive pattern established by the first two list items.
X C	persuasive argumentation	Choice C is incorrect — uses a noun phrase, breaking the verb-based parallel structure entirely.
X D	they argue	Choice D is incorrect — introduces a full clause with its own subject, breaking the list structure entirely.

Question 2

Easy

Engineers who tested the prototype under a range of extreme conditions found the device to be compact, reliable, and remarkably_____ even in low-power settings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. efficiency

B. efficiently

C. efficient

D. efficiencies

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The list contains three parallel adjectives describing "the device": compact, reliable, and the missing word.
- Since the first two items are adjectives, the third must also be an adjective.
- "Efficient" is the adjective form, matching the pattern.

Rule

Identify the part of speech used by the earlier list items before choosing the final one — nouns must match nouns, adjectives must match adjectives.

Tip

Identify the part of speech used by the earlier list items before choosing the final one — nouns must match nouns, adjectives must match adjectives.

Trap

"Efficiently" (Choice B), the adverb form, might feel like a fine descriptive word on its own, but it breaks the adjective-based parallel list.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	efficiency	Choice A is incorrect — is a noun, breaking the adjective list.
X B	efficiently	Choice B is incorrect — is an adverb, which cannot describe "the device" the way an adjective does in this list.
✓ C	efficient	Choice C is the best answer. is the adjective form, correctly matching "compact" and "reliable."
X D	efficiencies	Choice D is incorrect — is a plural noun, also breaking the adjective list.

Question 3

Medium

According to the latest census figures released this year, the population of metropolitan Tokyo is now considerably larger than_____ metropolitan London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** that of
- B.** those of

- C.** the city of
- D.** (no word needed)

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence compares "the population of metropolitan Tokyo" to a population, not to a city itself.
- "That of" correctly stands in for "the population of," keeping the comparison apples-to-apples.
- "Those" (Choice B) would be needed only if the compared item were plural, which "population" (singular) is not.

Rule

When comparing possessive or "of" phrases, use "that of" (singular) or "those of" (plural) to stand in for the first noun, keeping the comparison logically consistent.

Tip

When comparing possessive or "of" phrases, use "that of" (singular) or "those of" (plural) to stand in for the first noun, keeping the comparison logically consistent.

Trap

Leaving out any comparison word (Choice D) creates an illogical comparison between "the population of metropolitan Tokyo" and simply "metropolitan London" — a population and a city are not the same kind of thing.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	that of	Choice A is the best answer. correctly stands in for "the population of," comparing population to population.
✗ B	those of	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly uses the plural stand-in for the singular noun "population."
✗ C	the city of	Choice C is incorrect — changes the comparison to a city, mismatching "the population of metropolitan Tokyo."
✗ D	(no word needed)	Choice D is incorrect — leaves the sentence comparing a population directly to a city, an illogical apples-to-oranges comparison.

Question 4

Medium

Colleagues who have worked alongside her for years often remark that she is not only a talented researcher_____ an unusually inspiring teacher.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. but also

B. but also being

C. and also

D. but she is also

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Not only...but also" is a fixed correlative conjunction pair that must always appear together.
- Each half of a correlative pair must be followed by matching grammatical structures — here, both halves are followed by a noun phrase ("a talented researcher" / "an unusually inspiring teacher").
- "But also" is the only choice that completes the fixed pair correctly while keeping the parallel structure intact.

Rule

Correlative conjunction pairs (not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, both...and) are fixed phrases — memorize them as complete units, not interchangeable pieces.

Tip

Correlative conjunction pairs (not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, both...and) are fixed phrases — memorize them as complete units, not interchangeable pieces.

Trap

"And also" (Choice C) sounds like a reasonable substitute in casual speech, but it breaks the fixed "not only...but also" pairing that the sentence has already begun with "not only."

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	but also	Choice A is the best answer. correctly completes the fixed "not only...but also" pair with matching parallel structure.
✗ B	but also being	Choice B is incorrect — adds "being," which breaks the parallel noun-phrase structure after "but also."
✗ C	and also	Choice C is incorrect — breaks the required "not only...but also" pairing.
✗ D	but she is also	Choice D is incorrect — adds a full clause with its own subject and verb, breaking both the pairing and the parallel structure.

Question 5

Medium

After engineers tested four separate cooling systems under identical laboratory conditions, they determined that the third design proved to be_____.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** more accurate
- B.** the more accurate
- C.** most accurate of all
- D.** the most accurate

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence compares four methods, a group of more than two.
- Comparisons among three or more items require the superlative form with the definite article "the."
- "The most accurate" is grammatically complete and correctly uses the superlative.

Rule

Superlative comparisons (three or more items) typically pair "the" with the -est or "most" form: "the most accurate," "the fastest," "the best."

Tip

Superlative comparisons (three or more items) typically pair "the" with the -est or "most" form: "the most accurate," "the fastest," "the best."

Trap

"Most accurate of all" (Choice C) sounds emphatic and complete, but it drops the necessary "the" before "most," which Standard English superlatives require.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: D

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	more accurate	Choice A is incorrect — is the comparative form, reserved for comparisons between exactly two items.
X B	the more accurate	Choice B is incorrect — incorrectly pairs the definite article with the comparative form instead of the superlative.
X C	most accurate of all	Choice C is incorrect — omits the required article "the" before the superlative "most accurate."
✓ D	the most accurate	Choice D is the best answer. correctly uses the superlative form with its required article for a comparison among four items.

Question 6

Hard

Under the terms of the newly signed agreement, the company is now responsible_____ all quality-control procedures at every stage of production.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. for

B. to

C. of

D. in

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- "Responsible" idiomatically pairs with "for" when describing an area of duty or accountability for outcomes.
- None of the other prepositions form a standard idiomatic phrase with "responsible" in this sense.
- "Responsible for" is the correct, fixed idiomatic pairing.

Rule

Idiomatic prepositions like "responsible for" must be memorized as fixed units — logic alone won't reliably predict the correct preposition in English.

Tip

Idiomatic prepositions like "responsible for" must be memorized as fixed units — logic alone won't reliably predict the correct preposition in English.

Trap

"Responsible to" (Choice B) is a real English phrase describing accountability to a person or authority (e.g., "responsible to the board"), which can cause confusion with the different meaning intended here.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	for	Choice A is the best answer. correctly completes the idiomatic "responsible for" pairing describing an area of duty.
✗ B	to	Choice B is incorrect — would describe accountability to a person or group, a different meaning than intended.
✗ C	of	Choice C is incorrect — is not a standard idiomatic pairing with "responsible."
✗ D	in	Choice D is incorrect — is not a standard idiomatic pairing with "responsible."

Question 7

Hard

After surveying employees across every department, the internal report focused on three central goals: reducing operating costs, improving overall efficiency, and_____.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** to retain talent
- B.** talent retention

- C.** retaining talent
- D.** retained talent

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The list has three parallel items, each a gerund phrase: reducing costs, improving efficiency, and the missing item.
- The first two items set the pattern: gerund (-ing) plus object.
- "Retaining talent" matches this established gerund pattern exactly.

Rule

Once you spot the pattern in a parallel list (infinitives, gerunds, or plain nouns), test each answer choice by mentally substituting it into the first list slot to see if it still sounds structurally identical.

Tip

Once you spot the pattern in a parallel list (infinitives, gerunds, or plain nouns), test each answer choice by mentally substituting it into the first list slot to see if it still sounds structurally identical.

Trap

"Talent retention" (Choice B) expresses the same idea in perfectly correct English, but it's a noun phrase, not a gerund phrase, so it breaks the parallel structure the first two items establish.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	to retain talent	Choice A is incorrect — uses the infinitive form, breaking the gerund pattern set by "reducing" and "improving."
X B	talent retention	Choice B is incorrect — uses a noun phrase, breaking the gerund-based parallel structure.
✓ C	retaining talent	Choice C is the best answer. matches the gerund pattern established by the first two list items.
X D	retained talent	Choice D is incorrect — uses a past-participle phrase, also breaking the established gerund pattern.

Question 8

Hard

_____ many experienced researchers who have spent decades refining a single methodology, junior scientists often overlook the importance of rigorous peer review early in their careers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. Like

B. As

C. Such as

D. Unlike

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The sentence draws a contrast between how junior scientists behave and how experienced researchers behave.
- "Unlike" correctly signals this contrast, while "like" would incorrectly signal similarity.
- "As" would require a full clause with a verb ("as experienced researchers do"), which the sentence does not have.

Rule

"Like" and "unlike" both correctly precede a noun with no verb needed, but they carry opposite meanings — similarity versus contrast — so context and logic must determine which one fits.

Tip

"Like" and "unlike" both correctly precede a noun (no verb needed), but they carry opposite meanings — similarity versus contrast — so context and logic must determine which one fits.

Trap

"Like" (Choice A) is grammatically identical in structure to "unlike" and easy to mistake for it if you only check grammar and not meaning — but it would flip the sentence's intended contrast into an illogical claim of similarity.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Like	Choice A is incorrect — would wrongly claim junior scientists behave similarly to experienced researchers, reversing the intended contrast.
X B	As	Choice B is incorrect — requires a full clause with its own verb, which is not present here.
X C	Such as	Choice C is incorrect — is used to introduce examples from a group, not to draw a contrast between two groups.
✓ D	Unlike	Choice D is the best answer. correctly signals the contrast between junior scientists and experienced researchers.

Quick Review — Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

Skill	Key Move	Main Trap
Parallel Structure	Find the first list item's pattern.	One item breaking an established grammatical form.

Golden Rules

- Read every choice fully before selecting — one wrong word makes the whole answer wrong.
- Isolate the subject and verb by crossing out everything in between.
- Check both sides of every punctuation mark against what that mark is actually allowed to do.
- When two fixes both look grammatically valid, choose the one that also matches the sentence's logic and meaning.
- There are no trick questions. If you apply the rule carefully, the correct choice will be clearly the best fit.

Well done.

Standard English Conventions: theory and worked questions complete.